Notes on Shuori

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Safe Travel

NS-01

Bedroom, St. Petersburg

"The smoke of the fatherland is sweet and pleasant to us," especially in the early morning when someone is about to travel far from home.

However, it's not obvious to this complaining lady.

Noble Lady: Newspaper? Their cart hasn't been here for a long time. They said the price was too low and they were short-handed. Those vendors are as greedy as a bottomless pit, like those farmers.

Noble Lady: The smoke, the dust, and the opportunists are the last things needed in this poor town.

Noble Lady: *sighs*

Noble Lady: Last time, she was away for a whole year and didn't write a single letter back. Now, she's leaving again, to the places where she can only make friends with mosquitos, lice, and exiles!

Noble Lady: Sweet Mary forbid she should get sick or come back blind, like that woman.

Noble Lady: Oh, you mean the medal awarded by His Majesty. It's made of bronze. Who knows how many rubles it's worth? Not to mention the balls she had missed. Young cavaliers had come and gone, but she hadn't had the chance to meet any of them ...

The grumbles easily sneak into the room through the window with the floating dust.

The one being complained about closes the door. She needs to pack carefully in a room free of noise and interruptions. For a long journey, everything is too essential to forget.

???: ... Route confirmed ...

???: Clothes, maps, carriage ticket, reference letter, glass bottles, rock hammer ...

???: And the knife, in my pocket. Oh, I need to waterproof the papers.

???: Linen, it's emm ... Oh, here it is.

The fabric, left from the last trip, has a broader width than remembered. Perhaps because it is holding paper for only one user this time, it seems much more empty than it had been.

Using such a large fabric is a luxury for her.

???: I can bring more new parchment this time.

???: ...

???: Hmm? Wait, why is it ...

???: ... already used?

A written document is hidden between blank sheets of paper. The handwriting is inconsistent but neatly penned. It seems to have been deliberately forgotten and is now being rediscovered at this very moment.

—Fortunately, there are signatures in the margins, left as a discreet footnote on each page.

"Recorded by"

"Yenisei"

Yenisei: It's a record I wrote from dictation.

Yenisei: Judging from the handwriting, I must have done it in the wilds. The edge is ragged, so probably it's been stored for over a year since it was dried.

Yenisei: Over a year ... Oh, it's the travel diary Madam Bessmert asked me to write down for her.

Yenisei: Maybe I should call it travel "notes"? Haha ...

Yenisei: Either way, I think I had completed the arrangement and sent the original to her.

Yenisei: There's no way I forgot such an important thing. So what is it doing here?

Yenisei: And it's ... it's missing a few days of records.

Yenisei: October 10, October 16, October 17 ...

Yenisei: "... October 17, cloudy. We sold the carriage and rented boats from the local farmers to sail along the Om River before it froze ..."

Yenisei: "In this way, we might be able to enter the city of Omsk without passing the north gate."

Yenisei: "After all, the travelers from the Far East had said ... the city was heavily guarded like a fortress, and the guards would not overlook the slightest inconsistency between people's stories and their documents."

Yenisei: "We had to go through this trouble because we were in such a rush when we set off that we had little time ..."

???: "... to prepare the documents. They were far from authentic enough to convince the guards."

???: "Before we left, I gave several speeches to raise funds for the travel. The last speech was in a new park in the downstream area of the Om River."

???: "My assistant described to me that the park was crowned by a large pile of cumulate rock, which was burdened with the European Russian vegetation, all in its best time of year."

???: "This is the note on the 17th. The day after ..."

???: "Emm, October 18th ..." I have almost no recollection of that day. Child, do you recall anything?

The girl is busy checking her records, but after a while, she opens her mouth to respond.

Yenisei: October 18 ... I do. After we took a break and collected the supplies we needed, you talked to the governor.

Yenisei: He introduced you to a historian and sent a land surveyor ...

???: Oh. Yes, I remember it now. Bits of trivia. Let's skip that day for now.

Yenisei: Yes, Madam.

???: "October 19, partly sunny. I elaborated on my plan in my speech in the park. One of my arguments mentioned the Dùshuò Festival in the Eastern Land."

Yenisei: Legend ... of the Dùshuò Festival ...

???: "... I was gratified to see that the audience was drawn to the relations between land worship and the historical geological features in Asia and the investigation materials about a long-lost arcane skill."

???: "While the forms of land worship vary from one religion to another, the stories about an Eastern arcane skill known to the merchants as Ask and Acquire are almost identical."

???: "In those stories, men and women with determined minds overcame the highest mountain and the deepest canyon to seek an answer ..."

???: "... They patiently endured the suffering like the ascetics, pleading for the Gods of Shètí's motherly mercy and hoping to be given what they asked."

The girl quickly makes a note of these important words. From unknown to familiar, she has known these names for a long time.

???: "Even till this day, after the seekers are long gone, the god has never shown Itself to any one of us ... But we know It was there, for there is no better proof of the Ask and Acquire than this revived land."

???: "There is a sureness in people's remarks on Ask and Acquire. They are certain about its authenticity, like any geologist would not doubt the difference of soils in flood plains and mountains."

???: "That's right. Do we really have to see it to believe it? None of us have ever touched one sedimentary rock, but we can infer that such a thing exists ..."

The girl's speedy transcription follows in close synchronization with the speaker's words. But even so, she hesitates at this moment.

Yenisei: Madam, your analogy ...

Bessmert: Is there a problem?

Yenisei: The existence of sedimentary rock can be verified, but that of the "lost arcane skill" cannot.

Bessmert: Which is what I'm going to do now—to find the last piece of the jigsaw puzzle.

???: Pardon me, ladies.

A third voice rings out. A young man in glasses tidies up his clothes and walks towards them.

???: She's right. We do need to find something; otherwise, how are we supposed to make up for this time we've spent running and waiting?

Yenisei: What?

???: Take a good look around you.

The girl realizes that there will be nothing more for her to record today, and puts away her pen and paper. Then she stands to take in a complete view of the steppes now that the roaring wind and rain had ceased.

Vultures, the same color as the dark earth, hover above their heads, gazing with a scavenger's intent at all the creatures below them that seem to have stopped moving.

Yenisei: The rain has stopped.

???: Don't act like you just noticed it, Miss.

???: How much longer are we going to wait? Long enough for the vultures to eat our flesh and bones?

Yenisei: You ...

Bessmert: Mr. Krolik. You're troubled by unnecessary concerns.

Bessmert: The vultures are scavengers. They are here only for the animal corpses brought by the thunderstorm. They will leave us alone.

Krolik: So they don't pose a threat. Then what's with the waiting?

His hurried speech reveals his nervousness. Though Yenisei doesn't understand why.

Yenisei: If you are trying to get us back on the road, you have the right to propose it directly.

Yenisei: The team discusses to decide the next step. That's how things have worked all the way. We are not trying to waste your time.

Krolik: That's what I mean. We should get going now.

Yenisei: I see. We will suggest the directions as usual, and everyone will vote to decide ...

Krolik: Oh, no, you don't get it. There's no need to discuss or vote.

Yenisei: Hmm?

Krolik: Because we are not going forward, but going back! That's the only direction available.

Yenisei stares silently at Krolik. She disagrees, but politely waits for him to finish speaking.

Krolik: I'm not the only one with this idea, Ms. Bessmert.

Krolik: Those legends from the East, that ... Dùshuò Festival, is it? And the arcane trick you call "Ask and Acquire" ...

Krolik: None of them matter more than our lives!

He is right. The girl can only turn her head in silence further away, to that desolate, boundless, snowless winter landscape, all that remained of the temperate land after its withered grass scattered with the wind.

The storm they had encountered had blown through here as well, sweeping away almost every living thing.

And the young man's purpose is as clear as the open land that lies in front of them.

Krolik: Can anyone promise there won't be another emergency like this? What if we can't find a shelter next time?

Krolik: Yeah, we'll be lying dead out there, just like those corpses.

Bessmert: I hear you.

It has been 37 days since they left Omsk heading south. The fifth day on these steppes they have gone without fresh water.

If everything had gone according to plan, they would've already been sitting in the supply station drinking tea.

If they hadn't encountered this sudden storm ...

Yet, the two people, who put this very team together, did not anticipate such an eventuality.

Bessmert: Given what happened earlier, it is only reasonable that you would wish to return.

Yenisei: ...

This marks a moment of disagreement, when all the half-met measures sow the seeds of discord.

6#1

Adagio

NS-02

There is neither a single voice of opposition nor one of support from their fellow travelers.

If Bessmert could see their expressions, she might realize that this silent assent had actually been the sound of plotting minds.

Krolik: So, are we on the same page?

Bessmert: I fully understand where you're coming from, and I acknowledge your reasoning.

Krolik: What are you trying to ...

Bessmert: But we still need a vote to decide.

Krolik opens his eyes wide, pure joy flickering within them, and waits for the person in front of him to utter the words he longs to hear.

Yenisei: Wait!!

Yenisei couldn't stop the inevitable. The explorer, with a knack for speeches, always seems to have a strong belief in her own persuasiveness.

Krolik: No problem, of course. It's the civilized way to solve it.

Krolik: But I require we skip the speech. We have no time to waste on your monologue.

Bessmert: Alright.

Yenisei: Madam!

Krolik: Alright, gentlemen. If you agree to go back, please raise your hand.

As these words land on the listeners not far behind him, the people slowly begin to raise their hands to their ears, fingers crossed.

In the end, Krolik has it. He faces both of them, simply raising his hands, as though grandstanding somewhat, and a victorious smile stretches across his face.

Krolik: Four to two. See, we can make decisions in no time, right?

Bessmert: ...

Yenisei: This is their trap, Madam! We can't just ... Are you really fine with going back empty-handed like this?

Krolik: The vote was required by Ms. Bessmert, not me.

Krolik: And you, I'll take it that you're challenging me to a duel if you continue with the slander.

Bessmert: No, good sir, please don't take her the wrong way. We don't have to go physical.

Yenisei: What about Mr. Jurien? He has not voted yet, so the vote is not over!

The girl believes she has reached the heart of the matter, even if her rational mind knows that a single vote would be of no use.

Still, she insists.

Krolik: Oh, he's too tired to show up, but I'm sure he shares the same idea with us, because ...

Krolik: We are all humans. Of course, he's on our side.

Yenisei doesn't intend to say much to the young man, and decides to cross over to the group of people ahead to search for their final voter.

That is until another tall man stands up, seemingly to block her path.

Team Member I: Say no more, Krolik. Pack your things. Let's head back.

Yenisei: ...!

Yenisei: Fine. We'll split up from here, then.

Team Member I: We'll take all the supplies with us, or we can't make our way back. No discussion.

Yenisei: ...

He looks even tougher than the communicators they sent, and after saying his piece, he brushes past Yenisei down through the narrow rock crevice and leads the way toward the supply box behind them.

A moment ago, they were all there, recounting their previous journey together.

Bessmert: Gentlemen, the team was put together in good faith. Perhaps we should negotiate, not ...

Yenisei's solution is to chase after him and plant herself between the man and Bessmert.

Yenisei: The compass doesn't work here. You need me to find the way back.

Yenisei: Leave our supplies, and I'll show you the way.

Team Member I: You have to do this the hard way.

The man shakes his head, clearly unwilling to accept the proposal.

In her shock, Yenisei instinctively protects the person behind her, realizing that confrontation seems inevitable.

???: *coughs* That, my friends, is not how civilized people solve their problem.

The voice is calm and composed, but its gravity brings a swift end to the playful duel.

Bessmert: Mr. Jurien!

In a makeshift team of this sort, the eldest member is often bestowed a special prestige based on their experience.

Krolik: Mr. Jurien ...

Jurien: Mr. Krolik. I thought you were here to discuss the reallocation of supplies with Madam Bessmert. I didn't expect this ...

Krolik: Well ...

Jurien: It's true that you didn't choose to be here. You are here because you have an important mission given by the governor to complete.

Jurien: We have come this far. Do you really want to give up now?

The man's frame visibly shrinks. Their pretense of "communication" has been exposed, and every word spoken by his elder makes it more and more impossible for him to offer a rebuttal.

Jurien: As for you gentlemen ... Petrov, I'm surprised you're here too.

Jurien: It's a risk that none of us expected, but it shouldn't have broken your will. I remember you showed a great interest in those ancient strata in the South when we were at the speech.

Team Member I: All we need is safety.

Team Member I: There will always be a buffer period after extreme weather. We should seize the chance and head back.

Team Member I: If you persuade Ms. Bessmert to give us a confirmed date, before which we can find the running water and come back, we can stick to the original plan.

Jurien: Madam Bessmert?

Bessmert: Certainly. You see, these are all negotiable.

Yenisei: Wait. About the date, we can only decide after making an inventory.

Upon hearing these words, the man takes out his pocket watch, shakes it twice, and shows Yenisei the current time.

Team Member I: You have 30 minutes.

Yenisei: That's enough.

A brief consensus is reached, and the others scatter back to their former places, gathering supply boxes together and waiting for a response from the two in charge.

Bessmert cautiously touches the wooden boxes. The young girl comes to her side with a pen and paper, making a quiet record of things.

For a moment, the only sound between them is of pen on paper.

Bessmert: You know ...

Yenisei: Hmm?

Bessmert: Mr. Jurien is very interested in arcanum and arcanists. He is the keenest supporter of our journey, besides the governor.

Bessmert: Even if his understanding of Ask and Acquire is significantly different from mine ...

The girl continues her rummaging and recording, while responding gently and deftly to Bessmert's habitual broaching of this parallel topic.

Bessmert: The legend of Ask and Acquire, as told by many merchants, always involves a certain price. The price takes different forms in the stories, but mostly it is a great danger.

Yenisei: I believe that refers to "the highest mountain and deepest canyon" in those stories.

Bessmert: I reckon so. But Mr. Jurien, as a human historian studying the arcane skill, believes it's a form of exchange that arcanists make with nature ...

Yenisei: Mm-hmm. And you think he's wrong?

Bessmert: At this stage, we can't verify anything, so all these assumptions will have to remain assumptions. However, as we are getting closer to that mysterious land, my craving for its knowledge is also becoming stronger.

Between these words, Bessmert walks around to another box and notices that the closer the instrument is placed to it, the more distinctly she can smell the alcohol.

It is obvious that the alcohol prepared for boiling point measurements had been used as an "emergency resource" during the night when the temperature dropped drastically.

We shouldn't ask too much from such a ragtag team.

Bessmert: What do we know about the supplies?

Yenisei: Put aside the water problem, the supplies can feed everyone for eight days, maybe twelve if we economize. We can hold even longer if there are any preys or herders along the way.

Bessmert: Are there any supply stations?

Yenisei: Our supply stations are not on these plains, at least not on the map.

Bessmert: How much drinking water and alcohol do we have left?

Yenisei: Approximately ...

Yenisei: Oh, great. These idiots put water in the alcohol. Now we are short of both.

Bessmert: At least the alcohol has kept them warm.

Yenisei: They could have just drunk the alcohol.

Bessmert: Alright, alright, child. Now we should focus on the direction for the next step, not these bits of trivia.

Bessmert: Regarding which, just to be clear, what I have in mind is only slightly better than nothing.

Yenisei: Better how?

Bessmert: The moist air and the soil. Have you noticed? The soil beneath our feet is way too sticky, even for a land after a thunderstorm.

Bessmert: I'm not entirely sure about this ... But I tend to think that there is groundwater beneath us.

Bessmert: Which means we are close to running water.

Yenisei: Alright. Let me think about how to get us there.

Bessmert: Can't you use your arcane skill?

Yenisei: What?! Just because you don't know what to do doesn't mean you should count on this thing. You are not like them!

Bessmert: I just want to make use of everything we have ...

Yenisei: Fine. I told you how it works. Without new running water, the old samples in the bottles can only show us the way back. That's the best they can do.

To prove this, the girl takes a glass bottle from her person and places it in the waiting, doubtful hand.

Yenisei: This one is from the lower course of the Om River. The arcane energy I can use for divination has almost faded away.

Yenisei: Can it show us the way back? Sure, but that's not what we want. Only Mr. Krolik and his men would be happy to hear that.

Upon hearing this, Bessmert stands up straight. Although she cannot see her eyes, her silent posture alone seems to affect an aura of rapid thought.

Yenisei looks up at her and can almost hear the sound of gears spinning in her skull.

Bessmert: To think on the bright side, we still have a chance to go home.

Yenisei: But I didn't leave my homeland to go back there, Madam.

Bessmert: Yes, yes, I know. I feel the same. I'm not suggesting we turn back immediately. It's just an option.

Bessmert: To the best of my recollection, such moist soil is often found in the mountains and floodplains of the temperate zone, especially in the forest steppes covered with chernozem. The landscape is very different from where we are now.

Bessmert: Before we sheltered from the thunderstorm, you told me about a mountain in the southeast. It blocked the horizon from our sight, right?

The girl's eyes widen upon hearing these words—the expression of a hopeful epiphany.

Bessmert: Based on this, I would assume, the thunderstorm was the result of a stronger convection coming from the other side of the mountain. Now, on the steppe, to form a cloud large enough to bring a thunderstorm would require a large amount of running water ...

Yenisei: And the source of the running water is probably on the other side of the mountain!

Bessmert: Exactly ... We can set off in that general direction.

Bessmert: We might not find any water there. That's the worst result. In that case, we can still return here with the help of your arcane skill.

Bessmert: As long as we have that glass bottle with us.

Yenisei: That's right.

Bessmert: We tell them we need another five days ...

Bessmert grips the glass bottle in her hand as though clinging on to one final trace of hope.

Bessmert: They won't accept more days than that. If they won't even settle for this, I will convince them, like I did when I first got them on the team.

6#1

The Fairyland

NS-03

Bessmert did indeed succeed.

On one hand, as she clearly points out the direction of her thinking and provides reasons and arguments for her judgment, her human companions are easily convinced.

On the other hand, all other concerns soon cease to be of significance—

Two days later

Yenisei: ...!!!

The girl's eyes widen as she looks blinking at the flowing stream appearing seemingly from thin air not far from them—as though staring at it might restore it all to its original state.

She remembers clearly when she was only a mile from here yesterday evening, there was nothing to indicate the presence of such a miraculous hidden feature.

Jurien: Ladies ...

Jurien: This is a miracle. I'm glad we didn't give up and go back.

Yenisei: Wait, something's not right ... I ...

Krolik: What-what are we waiting for?

Not intending to wait for an answer, he runs toward the stream. An unheeded reaction to the long labors of their journey through the desolate wilderness.

Krolik: We are on the right path. I have nothing to say.

The humans move briskly toward the rushing stream.

For a moment, only the two arcanists remain skeptical about this new variable.

Bessmert: No ... Wait! Please don't ... !

Unable or unwilling to heed her shouts, they rush into the stream. Sinking their faces into the water and pulling them out, with smiles as wide as if they had never seen such natural beauty before.

Standing beside Bessmert, who had failed to stop their advance, the red-haired girl cautiously retreats as well, marking a sharp contrast with the humans who embrace the water like a fish too long in the air.

Yenisei: Wh-What ...

Yenisei: Madam, you didn't tell us the running water was right on the side when we pitched camp yesterday.

Bessmert: Yes, because I didn't notice any signs of water.

Yenisei: I thought it was your doing!

Bessmert: I wish it was, but, sadly, this is beyond my power. I'm not even sure if we are still staying on the planned route.

This is obviously not good news, as Yenisei's silence reveals. Bessmert immediately realizes the ambiguity of her words.

Bessmert: Indeed, I can hear the river flowing and running against the stones and shores.

Yenisei: Have you noticed anything else?

Bessmert: Yes, um, I'm not an expert, though.

Bessmert: The soil here is moist too, but it feels different, like just dampened by frequent spring rains.

Bessmert: The dry air of winter has completely gone.

Yenisei: And the grass here looks nothing like the temperate grass we should be seeing in December. It's so green, as if it were April or May now.

Bessmert: But we haven't gone that far. Is this ...

Bessmert: Is this some kind of illusion brought by arcane power?

Yenisei: Whether it's an illusion or something else, there must be something wrong with the water they drank.

Bessmert: You're right. We can't let them drink it.

Yet, their rational repudiations could not change the fact that their companions had already drunk from the abnormal water.

Bessmert instinctively runs forward, wishing to minimize the damage before things get worse.

Bessmert: Gentlemen, please listen! The water ...

Yenisei: Hold on, Madam! It's too late!

Yenisei grabs her hand, trying to prevent Bessmert from running in a panic and potentially suffering a fall.

Bessmert still wishes to rush forward, but finds herself unable to break free.

Bessmert: I have to tell them. I am the reason why they are here.

Yenisei: Listen. They have filled the water bags and are coming back.

Their momentary joy at finally being able to move forward is rapidly diluted.

The only consolation is that the human walking back toward the two of them still appears to be normal.

Team Member I: What's wrong? Are you not going to fill your water bags?

Yenisei: Nothing. We'll go later.

Team Member I: The water is clean. You can even see the trouts swimming. Too bad, we need to keep our packs light.

Yenisei: ...

Bessmert: Thank you. We'll fill our bags once we figure out which way we should go next.

Team Member I: Krolik is still by the river. He seems parched. Is he the reason you didn't go there?

Yenisei: No.

Team Member I: Alright, no problem, then. I'll go check and fill the rest.

Their tall companion nods and walks past the two of them, and toward the previously set-down baggage.

Once he is gone, Yenisei speaks once more.

Yenisei: Please wait here, Madam. I'll go check ...

Jurien: Madam Bessmert.

Bessmert: Mm? Mr. Jurien, did, did you drink the water?

Jurien: Oh, we ... I did. Just like Petrov said, the water is clean, a bit sweet to taste, even.

Bessmert: That's good, that's good then. You were looking for me. Is there a problem?

Jurien: No, no. Look, I know you don't need any compliments, but thank you for leading us to the running water. I'm glad you once again earned their trust.

Bessmert: Maybe we should thank the "Ask and Acquire."

Jurien: Haha, perhaps.

Jurien: Now, it's time for us to set out again for the Eastern arcane skill you mentioned.

Jurien: But before we do that ... I remember you once mentioned your assistant during your speech, saying her arcane skill was related to water and could find directions in the wild.

Bessmert: Yes, you remember it correctly.

A glad smile of acknowledgment appears on the face of the middle-aged man, his enthusiasm compelling him to ask one question after another.

Jurien: Ah, that is so wonderful! Earlier, you said that this was a safeguard, but at the time you did not explain in detail how it would work ...

Jurien: Now, may I have the honor to witness it? How does she communicate with water? Will she be possessed?

Jurien: Or like those mystics in the Palace ...

Yenisei: Sir, my arcane skill cannot predict what will happen precisely, and it is not cast through "possession."

Yenisei: Please do not overestimate what you don't understand and simply count on it.

Jurien: I know, child. I'm only curious and hoping to see it with my own eyes ...

Yenisei: No, Sir. It is not an exhibit in the museum or a play in the theater.

Jurien: Oh ...

The girl shakes her head and firmly refuses Jurien's request once again.

But he doesn't care. He has received more of an answer than he expected, and as he leaves, he smiles and straightens his collar again, bidding goodbye to both of them, respectively.

Yenisei: They look alright.

Bessmert: For now, yes. I feel uneasy about it. I have to go there ...

Yenisei: There's little you can do even if you go there, given the condition of your eyes. I will go check them, one by one.

Bessmert: Wait. Mr. Jurien just asked about your arcane power. Maybe now it's a good time.

Yenisei: What?

Bessmert: When you look for the direction with your arcane skill, check if the "water" is real.

Yenisei: What if it's not?

Bessmert: ...

Bessmert: In that case, child, we have no choice but to divine our way back, with the water in your bottle.

Bessmert's worried and helpless words echo in Yenisei's ears.

Yenisei: ...

Yenisei: Fine. I'll do it.

Yenisei: I will find the direction through divination, verify if the water is running, and check if anything's wrong.

The girl takes a step forward and walks toward the strange babbling stream that seems to have come from nowhere.

Yenisei walks barefoot into the river.

Flowing water on a temperate plateau like this should naturally be cold. It gently laps at her, just beneath her calves.

She closes her eyes, trying to make herself unaware of the temperature.

Yenisei: *Sacred water, please flow and flow ...*

Yenisei: *May your love and care drift far away with the flowing foam.*

Yenisei: *May you water the roots, moisten the grass, and sweeten the souls.*

Yenisei: *Like lifting a current from a reef where waves are breaking.*

The light spots gather and gradually fill the empty glass bottle.

Yenisei: *And I ...*

Yenisei: *I will go to that current.*

Yenisei: *Everything will be as I said.*

Yenisei: ...

Yenisei: Southeast.

The empty glass bottle falls from her loosened grip.

The girl looks dazed as she picks up her damp and heavy feet from the water, heading to the southeast.

Bessmert: ...

Bessmert: HEY!

Bessmert: Where are you going?

Yenisei: Hmm ...

Yenisei: Mmm? I ...

Half of her mind is still in the realm of delirium. The sounds she hears are fragmented into pieces that she can only attempt to fit together.

Yet, through the difficulty of her present state of mind, she tries her best to make sense of what Bessmert is saying.

Yenisei: Mmm ...

Bessmert: You've found something, haven't you?

Yenisei: I, emm ...

Bessmert: Easy, Yeni, take your time.

Yenisei: Yes.

Yenisei: Yes. The sign has come out.

Yenisei: I asked the river to show me the place with the strongest arcane energy. Then, it pointed at the southeast among all the other directions.

Yenisei: That is probably the direction we are looking for.

Yenisei: And yes, this river is real running water. It is flowing with vitality.

Bessmert: Alright. Perhaps I was wrong.

Yenisei: It's never wrong to consider all the possibilities, Madam.

Yenisei: Please wait here. I will mark the direction and inform everyone of it.

Bessmert: Sure.

6#1

Strange Horses

NS-04

The spring scenery of the steppes stretches out to the edge of the horizon.

The expedition team continues to trek in the direction indicated by the river.

As they do, they scarcely notice as the terrain beneath them changes. Until the party at last finds themselves walking across bare rock.

The uneven green rocks merge with grayish and purple granite, rough and jagged. In spots, tumbleweed and sand rice plants pierce through the jagged stone, billowing and cascading, and then plummeting down the cliff.

The travelers also feel as though they are moving downward. As the surrounding peculiarities increase, so too does their breathing, which becomes increasingly restricted.

Yenisei: *pants*

Krolik: You proved yourself right by ... finding running water for us ...

Krolik: So, I'm not ... judging you ... this time, but ...

Krolik: Are we going the wrong way?

Yenisei: No. This is the right direction.

Krolik: But it's getting harder and harder to breathe, even if we are going down the mountain.

Yenisei: What about you, Madam? Are you feeling alright?

Bessmert: I feel fine. Perhaps because I'm used to climbing mountains.

Bessmert: But we are definitely 3000 meters above the sea level now. It's normal if you're feeling unwell at this height. If only we still had alcohol ...

Bessmert: Well, it's just a thought. I wouldn't have gathered enough courage to climb up that slope if I hadn't taken the last few sips.

Bessmert shakes her head, dispelling unnecessary thoughts, and instead pursues another possibility.

Bessmert: But, child, are you sure we are on the right path?

Yenisei: I don't think it's wrong. The clearer the sign, the higher the accuracy.

Yenisei: And the sign I just saw happened to be exceptionally clear.

Bessmert: What about the others? Are you feeling alright? Shall we stop and take a short break?

Krolik: I have a bad feeling. Instead of a break, we need a new direction. Back home, for example.

Jurien: Before we do anything, can we have some rest? My head has been pounding for a while. I thought it was common in the mountains and you all felt the same.

Bessmert: Yes, headache is a common altitude sickness, Sir.

Yenisei: Wait, is that tumbleweed?! I don't think it belongs here.

Yenisei finally notices a large bundle trundling on not far away.

Bessmert: I hear ... Are they rolling nearby? Are you sure?

Bessmert: This is not the right season for them to roll and spread seeds.

Yenisei: I'm not seeing things, I guess, but I don't know why they are here. And those flowers ...

The team members at the end of their procession stop in their tracks. The others beside him also stop as a result.

Until the entire team comes to a standstill.

Team Member I: Something's wrong.

Team Member II: Hey you ... where are you taking us?

Team Member II: Haven't you noticed the rocks around us? Their color is abnormal. I've never seen anything like this, not even in books ...

Team Member II: And look at the holes in the rocks! They were made by water erosion! And that's not supposed to happen in this climate!

Yenisei: Calm down, Sir. Perhaps we have reached somewhere beyond other adventurers' records, but that's all ...

Team Member II: What about this?! How are you going to explain it?!

Team Member II: Another one of your stupid arcane skill tricks?

Yenisei lowers her head to look at what seem to be ordinary yellow flowers.

But these flowers wither almost immediately after blooming. It would be difficult to describe such a scene as anything less than a miracle or a curse.

Yenisei: What? This is ...

Bessmert: What is it? Explain what?

Yenisei: I don't know what species it is. It looks like a mini sunflower, but ...

Krolik: Told you we should head back. Something's wrong with this dump.

Team Member I: Agree. We have a situation now. We should go back while we still can.

Jurien: Ladies, I have to say this is beyond my imagination.

Yenisei: ...

Bessmert: It's just a flower, yes? Why are you all so scared? I can't see, but ...

Bessmert reaches out to grasp the flowers again, but the petals wither beneath her fingertips. Now more puzzled, she tries touching a complete cluster, but only ends up with a handful of withered husks.

The scent of these withered fragments turns rotten as their sweet fragrance disappears, leaving her having captured only the base note of their "perfume."

Bessmert: Emm? The smell ...

Krolik: Everything is wrong here. The fog is not supposed to form at this latitude, the terrain is strange, and the plants ... they wither in an instant!

Team Member I: I don't want to say this, but this place seems to be cursed.

Team Member I: These phenomena make no sense. We have to go back now.

The voice of the young man is more resolute than ever before.

Faced with such a bizarre situation, escape is unarguably the most rational choice.

Yenisei: You heard them, Madam. What do you say? Things are indeed weird.

Bessmert: No, we are not returning. We have made it through the thunderstorm. What could be more dangerous than that?

Bessmert: Perhaps we are getting close, like those merchants said, there will be a "price" we must pay for the Ask and Acquire. Mr. Jurien, you also asked me about it, don't you remember?

Jurien: On the contrary, Madam, I remember it clearly. I have also told you my suspicion—it could be an exchange made between the arcanists and nature.

Bessmert: What? Of course not.

Jurien: Look around you—all these bizarre phenomena! You know I wasn't making things up. You set out to pursue that arcane skill, yet we ended up here ...

Krolik: I don't know what your next plan is, but count me out.

Agitated by this abnormal phenomenon and talk of a possible sacrifice, the young man pushes Bessmert aside and stands with the others at the back of the group.

A previous scene of division and opposition repeats itself.

Bessmert: No, I swear on my life, that is not my intention!

Yenisei: Madam Bessmert would never do that.

Yenisei: The point is, the compass doesn't work here. You will get lost on the way back without me.

Krolik: There's no doubt this is part of your scheme.

Yenisei: Excuse me?

Krolik: Mr. Jurien already told us about your secret arcane skill. It's our last hope of getting home in this plight.

Bessmert: ...

Krolik: We trust him. That being the case, you must come with us.

Yenisei: No. I came here with Madam Bessmert. I'm not leaving without her.

Yenisei also expresses her intentions clearly. Never having been one to be swayed by external forces, unless ...

Bessmert: Let's ...

Yenisei: It's fine, Madam. We can keep going on our own ...

Bessmert: Let's go back.

Yenisei: ...?!

... Unless the person she is supporting lowers her head first.

Bessmert: It's alright. Though I can't see, I can imagine how shocking it must be to make you so uneasy.

Bessmert: When we get back to the pastureland ...

Krolik: I'm sorry, Madam. We are not taking you.

Krolik: I don't think we have enough supplies for everyone to make it back, so certainly someone must be abandoned.

Yenisei takes a step closer until she is completely blocking the depressed Bessmert's path.

Yenisei: Then, allow me to say no. I will not show you the way without Madam Bessmert in the team.

Bessmert: No, Yeni. You're going with them.

Yenisei: But they are leaving you behind!

Krolik: Looks like your assistant has made her own decision. Sorry, but I never thought it would end up like this ...

Team Member I: Enough with the talking. My apologies, ladies.

Yenisei: What ... What are you doing?!

They are now facing each other, seeming to have decided to end their dispute through force.

They are acutely aware that sacrificing one might save the many.

It is a simple matter of arithmetic.

Standing upright is a phenomenon exclusive to humans. It is a miracle born of a desire to break free from the earth and move upward towards the sky.

The outcome unfolds quite apart from everyone's expectations.

Yenisei: What?

Striped Horse?: *neighs*

Yenisei: I-I don't understand. What is ... What is going on?!

Even though they acknowledge the untimely nature of their dispute, they are left to witness all hope of reconciliation disintegrate before them.

Yenisei receives no answer, as the people standing in front of her now have lost the ability to reply.

6#1

Language Barrier

NS-05

Striped Horse?: *neighs*

Yenisei: No way ...

Turning around, she finds that her companion has transformed in an instant from a human on two feet to a strange hoofed animal on all fours.

As the only person to have witnessed the entire process in detail, with every aspect too difficult to comprehend, she can only turn her puzzled gaze toward her elder.

But Bessmert is also in the dark.

Bessmert: What's this noise? Mr. Krolik?

The only answer she receives is the impatient stirring of the odd-toed ungulate as it tramples the grass.

Bessmert: Mr. Jurien?

Striped Horse?: *neighs*

Bessmert: Strange. I heard animals. What happened?

Yenisei: Emm ...

Bessmert: Yenisei, I can't see. I need your help.

Yenisei: Oh dear, give me a minute ... Emm, looks like they turned into ... I don't know, striped horses?

Yenisei: I ... Sorry, I'm not sure. I've only seen similar animals in books.

Yenisei: They look a bit smaller than horses, but taller and bigger than donkeys. And they have yellow stripes on their skin.

Bessmert: Perhaps some local species on the temperate steppe? Are you certain they're transformed from Mr. Jurien and others? Not the livestock of nearby herders?

Bessmert: I didn't cast any violent arcane skills on them, nor did you. Besides, I didn't sense any fluctuations of arcane energy ...

Yenisei: I'm sorry, Madam. I have no idea.

Bessmert: I think ... if this wasn't because of us, there must be someone else around.

Bessmert: Stay close to me.

The importance of rallying together and remaining vigilant has already been proven to them.

The sound of raptor wings rapidly slicing through the air rushes towards the two travelers and their horses.

Bessmert: It's here. Watch out!

Yenisei: What is it?!

Bessmert: Some bird of prey? It's fast, judging from the flapping sound of its wings. We must go up front to protect Mr. Jurien and the others. They might be its target ...

Bessmert: Oh, yes, the flint! Take out the flint! Kindle the sand rice to drive it away!

Yenisei: No, wait ...

Yenisei: I don't think that's a bird of prey, but a human with wings!

Yenisei: And it's not coming any closer?

The girl hesitates upon hearing the sound of music.

The music had been playing for only a short while. When those huge wings stirred the air into a violent storm, it was totally drowned out.

It wasn't until it gave up on advancing that the slow flapping of wings was covered up by the music.

But the tune of the music is unknown to all present.

The music starts from the bird and spreads around, like a torrential rain, enveloping the restless brown animals on the ground below.

The horses look up in search of the source of this melody, as do the two other listeners.

It is a simple and repetitive melody, but more than enough to consume Bessmert's full attention.

???: ...

Yenisei: Madam! That thing is a creature with a human's head and a bird's body ...!

The fierce steppe winds carry off her cries.

Bessmert: What? What did you say? I can't hear ...

Yenisei: I said, that thing looks like a human with wings!

Bessmert: A human? You mean it has the face of a human? Is the music also coming from it?

Yenisei: Yes!

Bessmert: The music-playing winged creature with a human's face. Sounds familiar, don't you think?

Yenisei: ... An angel?! You are not serious!

Yenisei: But angels blow trumpets! That stick it uses to play music—I'm not sure whether it's a wand or some instrument.

The girl's voice cannot conceal her doubt. She grabs Bessmert, wishing to step back, but remembers not to stray too far from the horses.

This conflict between her instinct and reason is revealed in her fragmented words.

She tries to understand the current situation, but finds it strangely difficult.

Yenisei: Madam, we, I, we ...

Bessmert: Calm down, child.

Bessmert: Look closer and tell me. What does it look like? What about its wand?

Yenisei: It ... It has a human's head, dressed in gray, with black wings instead of arms. Looks ... looks like a huge bird of prey ...

Yenisei: While the wand, I don't know how to describe it ...

The girl hurriedly lifts her head again to confirm, and add a supplementary defense to that which she still cannot clearly express.

Yenisei: But that thing is not even holding it! It's making the sound in mid-air.

Bessmert: Sounds like a Harpy, if there wasn't a wand.

Yenisei: But it doesn't quite fit the descriptions in the book ... Neither the color of its feathers nor the environment does.

As they're trying to figure out what's going on, the horses, effecting a brisk piaffe, look up to the source of the sound.

After a brief moment, the "Harpy" turns around, flapping its wings and slowly flying away, with the horses following closely behind as if compelled.

Yenisei: Mr. Jurien ... They are leaving after that thing!

Bessmert: Stay calm, Yenisei.

Bessmert: They must be under its control, but I'm not sure if ... if a Harpy can manipulate its subjects from a distance.

Bessmert strains to extract something useful from her mind, hoping to find anything that might explain the absurdities before her.

In the end, she gains nothing, and the doubt strikes at her head again like a well-paced hammer.

Bessmert: Err, alright, let's hope that ...

Yenisei: Hope that "Harpy" doesn't eat horses? Madam, we can't just stand here and hope ...

Bessmert: Nonsense. Hope that this is just a mind-controlling arcane skill, and they're just affected by it.

Bessmert: That's right. We must follow that creature and break the spell on them.

Bessmert: Now you need to ...

Bessmert grabs Yenisei, while her other hand points firmly upstream toward the herd of horses.

Yenisei takes only a moment to understand her intentions and calms down.

Yenisei: Alright. I see what you mean.

Yenisei: I'll go first. Please listen carefully to my footsteps and find us as soon as possible.

Unfortunately ...

They quickly realize the creature doesn't need to look back to know what's going on behind it. It merely raises its talons to deftly parry Yenisei's attacks.

That is to say, they realize soon enough that its power is far beyond what the two of them had imagined.

Yenisei: Hold there! What on earth do you want!

Yenisei: Answer me!

???: ...

Perhaps it is because of this disparity in strength that the "Harpy" seems not to feel any need to pay attention. It whirls around in midair.

However, Yenisei struggles to see any discernible expression on its human face.

???: Turn thee back.

???: Seek what thou desire elsewhere.

Yenisei: What?

???: Turn thee back, there is naught to find here.

Bessmert: What is this sound? Speaking or singing? Sounds like a young man, how so?

Bessmert: Well, at least it's definitely not a Harpy.

Yenisei: Perhaps it's talking, but the tone sounds strange. I've never heard any language like this.

Yenisei tries in vain to continue forward, but the "giant bird" shakes its head in the air as though issuing a warning.

???: Thine pursuit will cost thee greatly, and yet little will be thy reward.

???: Tread not one step more.

As the wings of the "giant bird" rise and heave, in addition to the strange instrument, the horses also turn around.

Their unhinged companions stand in the way as the music suddenly shifts from a melodious tone to a piercing frenzy.

It paints the scene of a hopeless conflict.

The striped horses are driven by the giant bird, turning their heads to block her path.

Yenisei can only lift her hands against the encirclement and continue launching her attacks upward.

Striped Horse?: *neighs angrily*

Yenisei: Ugh!

Yenisei: Ugh ... Gentlemen ... Get out of the way. Out!

Yenisei: And you, hey, the flying one! You can talk, right? I don't know your language, but ...

Yenisei: If you are going to eat them, you'd better think twice.

Yenisei: Horse meat has a bad smell.

???: ...

The bird remains silent. Yenisei notices a slender, white stick poking out from his feathers.

Like a bone, but yet also like a wand.

Yenisei: No ... Madam, watch out!

Bessmert: What? I don't sense any hostility ...

This "attack" indicates that it is, in fact, a wand.

However, the two individuals supposedly subjected to this attack seem unchanged. Both physically and mentally, they are exactly as they were before.

Yenisei: Hmm?

Bessmert: Don't worry. I'm fine. It wasn't an attack.

As the two of them begin to explore their uncertainty, the figure flapping its wings in the air speaks once again.

This time, though, something is different.

???: Those whom you chase are no longer related to you once they walked in here and moistened their throats with the flowing water.

???: They are the Zhící's concern.

???: No more chasing.

Yenisei: What is a Zhící? I don't understand ...

Yenisei: No, wait, I-I understand his words now. What?

Yenisei: But ... What is happening? Am I seeing illusions again?

Yenisei: Madam, what about ...

Bessmert: No, it's not an illusion. I can understand it, too.

Yenisei: Unbelievable. Is he able to speak different languages, or can he learn from our conversation in no time?

Bessmert: The "attack" he just made could be his arcane skill.

Bessmert: I can sense the fluctuation of his arcane energy. It's a wondrous power that allows people to communicate.

???: Speculation is unhelpful to your situation. Go back ...

???: ... To where you came from.

This time, its meaning is clear. But neither these words of advice nor its tone of refusal can shake their resolve.

Turning back had never been a consideration before, so of course, they wouldn't consider it now.

Yenisei: No.

Yenisei: First, you must turn them back. Second, to go back or not is our decision to make, not yours.

???: That was not my doing.

Yenisei attempts to understand the true meaning hidden in the giant bird's words. Her mind spins rapidly, and countless questions clamber up, desperate to leap from her tongue.

Yenisei: You stopped here and cast that arcane skill for us to talk, which means you think communication is an available choice between us.

Yenisei: You just mentioned "the flowing water." Do you mean the river we passed by?

Yenisei: And you said these striped horses are "Zhící's concern." I need to know where that place is because they are my teammates.

Yenisei: Besides ... who on earth are you?

???: ...

???: What you ask, I have no answer.

Yenisei: Then what do you know?

???: The Four Books and Five Classics, Geomancy and Feng Shui, Chen-Wei Divination.

Yenisei: What are you talking about?!

???: Mm? The answers to many questions, naturally.

The doubt in his tone seems to come straight from the bottom of his heart.

Bessmert: Yenisei, listen to me. We might be asking the wrong questions.

Yenisei: But we need to collect more information or buy more time. Whatever we are going to do, we can't just let him go.

Yenisei: He will take Mr. Jurien and the team away from us!

Bessmert: But clearly, he is reluctant to answer these questions.

Bessmert: Perhaps he'd be willing to exchange them for our supplies?

Bessmert: He is trying to take them away, perhaps because they are carrying the supplies he needs.

Yenisei: You mean food, or what? Let's ...

???: Stop, there's nothing else for you here.

???: And I need nothing ...

???: What I yearn for is beyond even my own grasp.

Bessmert: Wait, good sir ...!

The bird turns around and flaps its wings, flying away much faster than before.

This time, there is no music. Yet the odd creatures follow closely in the wake of the wind raised by the motion of its wings.

Yenisei: Hey!

Yenisei: Darn. He flew away!

Bessmert: ... Did I say anything wrong?

Yenisei: Don't blame yourself, Madam. He appeared to be the unpredictable type.

Yenisei: Do you still have the strength to walk? We need to hurry up and go after him ...

Bessmert grabs Yenisei's arm and quickly chases after the piercing sound of the wind.

6#1

The Yellow Sand Road

NS-06

In the battle between two legs and four, they find themselves on the back foot from the beginning.

The burdenless horses gallop wildly as the giant bird flies further and further, leaving exhausted Bessmert and Yenisei far behind.

Yenisei: *pants*

Yenisei: Madam ...

Their stamina slips away faster than it did before on the plains.

Their actions become increasingly labored, and their steps slow to a plodding halt.

Bessmert: Are we going upstream?

Bessmert: If we are, he must be taking his preys back to his nest. Is-Is there a forest there?

Yenisei: I'm sorry, Madam. I can't ... I can't think right now.

Yenisei: I can't see ... anything. Only ... stars ...

Yenisei: *exhales*

The girl suddenly realizes that she can no longer pull Bessmert along.

With her energy dwindling, the sudden pause only leaves her more flustered.

Yenisei: Huh?

Yenisei: Why ... *pants* ... Why stop?

Yenisei: *pants*

Bessmert: ...

Bessmert: I hear horses, right in front of us.

Bessmert: And people.

And not just people.

The clamor of commerce, a melody in the trundling of carriages, rolling wheels on the ground, and the sound of footsteps on the soil and stones soon follow ...

No matter what lies ahead ...

Bessmert: No. It's not a forest.

Yenisei: There are walls and people ... I-I don't understand. Wait ... Could it be ...

Hard city walls made of earth and stone, and a soaring gate tower, the likes of which they have never seen before, encompass the bustling town and the vivid figures within.

The gate is opened wide. Pedestrians pass under it, as guards wearing silver armor stand at the entrance to the city.

Yenisei: Emm, is it ... a supply station?

Yenisei: No, no ...

Yenisei: Where ... Where on earth are we?!

Bessmert: Child, please tell me where we are.

Bessmert: I can't hear the rustling of the sand rice anymore, but there are other noises. I'm thinking ... is this a settlement?

The girl shakes her head, failing to answer Bessmert's question.

Having never seen such a place before, she is naturally apprehensive of all that stands before her.

Yenisei: No. At least it doesn't look like one. Not like any towns or villages we've seen.

Yenisei: I-I think I'm seeing another illusion. I see a desert, some plants, and a wooden pavilion on the yellow walls.

Yenisei: The roof of the pavilion looks like bird wings, and the people down the walls are quite different from us ...

Bessmert: Walls and people, right? Only a city has walls around it. I also hear those noises. It's not an illusion.

Yenisei: No, you don't understand. Those yellow walls and the gates don't look real at all!

Yenisei: I've never seen any buildings like this. A pavilion on the stone walls with four pointy tips around the roof. They seem to be flying in the mid-air ...

Bessmert: Perhaps it's just a foreign architectural style.

Yenisei: Besides, we couldn't have gone far enough to reach a city, unless ... unless it's a fake one.

Yenisei: We must not go there rashly.

Bessmert: We've lost track of the giant bird and the others long before we heard the noises of this city. The last thing I can recall is that the flapping of the huge wings disappeared in the south.

The girl tightly clasps Bessmert's sleeve, realizing that things are sliding in a direction beyond her control.

Bessmert: The city wall before you is also to the south, is it not?

Bessmert quietly turns her face toward Yenisei. Even though the girl knows her eyes are covered by fabric and are unable to see a thing, this gesture still possesses the power of a gaze.

A kind of soothing, stable, but at the same time questioning power.

Yenisei: Madam ... you are doing it again. You never listen to me.

Bessmert: Child, we are standing in the right place.

Bessmert: Behind these walls, our teammates might be suffering due to my misjudgment.

Yenisei pauses a brief moment, before she makes up her mind.

Yenisei: The gate is open. I can see the people in the city.

Yenisei: But there are guards patrolling around. They are holding some spear-like weapons, and the one in the front looks ...

Yenisei: Quite different from us.

Yenisei: I don't think they understand our language, even if we ask them to let us in ... Remember those herders? Almost impossible to communicate with them without an interpreter!

Bessmert: Hope our "travel documents" can get us through that gate.

6#1

The Guests From Afar

NS-07

Gate

According to Yenisei's description, the peculiar-looking city defenders are all clad in silver armor and bear sharp weapons in their hands.

It sounds like a scene from the medieval era. Having passed every barrier smoothly all the way from Omsk, they think the garrison here is also a piece of cake.

But as it becomes clear, they are wrong to underestimate them.

Even though both sides miraculously understand each other's words, the passes here are still well-guarded.

Yenisei: ...

Gate Keeper: Please show me your Pass.

Yenisei: You have all our documents.

Gate Keeper: This is not a Pass.

Bessmert: Sir, you have the documents. Please, take a closer look at them.

Gate Keeper: I'm not a Sir.

Gate Keeper: Please show me the right Pass, which shows where you come from and where you are going.

Yenisei: I wouldn't have been here if I knew the answers.

Gate Keeper: No Pass, no entry.

The problem seems to lie in both parties failing in the art of effective communication.

This bickering back and forth over useless technical pitfalls undoubtedly wastes everyone's time.

Bessmert: *sighs* I think it has been clearly stated on our documents.

Bessmert: The documents were issued by the association. They worked in all the borders in the North. What makes the difference here?

Gate Keeper: It's not verified. I don't know which pass let you pass with this Pass, let alone the writing and the seal on it cannot be recognized.

Gate Keeper: If I let you in, it would be my negligence.

Yenisei: Can we talk to someone else? You don't understand what we are talking about.

Gate Keeper: I understand every word you say.

Bessmert: Very well, if you do, friend, this is what happened:

Bessmert: Our teammates were transformed into "horses" and taken away by a winged man. We think they might have been brought here, so we need to get into the city to find them.

Bessmert: This is urgent. I hope you can understand ...

Gate Keeper: I've been on duty for over six hours. There was no such thing as a "winged man."

Gate Keeper: You can't fool me with your stupid story. I've seen too many of these little tricks.

Gate Keeper: The rule is, no Pass, no entry.

The defender in silver armor looks like a wall of iron from whichever angle he's seen.

Yenisei looks up and sees the wooden eaves above the masonry, rising straight into the sky to cast a shadow over the ground. She remembers the "giant bird" and suddenly wishes she too had wings.

Yenisei: Fine. This man understands our language, but he won't buy it.

Bessmert: Yeni?

Unfortunately, she doesn't have wings, and so she must find some other way to deal with their predicament.

Yenisei: Then I'll see if we can make it in without this Pass.

Gate Keeper: Trying to break in? You're overestimating yourself.

Yenisei: Just trying, because we are not given any choices, Sir.

Bessmert: Wait, Yenisei ...!

Emptying the glass bottles one by one, Yenisei's "weapons" are quickly depleted.

Across from them, the dry iron wall—the poor guard—has become a wet iron wall.

Gate Keeper: ...

Gate Keeper: Warning! Intruders!

Gate Keeper: Close the gate!!

The guards on the wall above the city gates respond in a quick and rhythmic step.

Below, those within the city gates scuff the sand, as the gates' heavy cables are twisted in reply, held tightly in expectant hands awaiting their next command.

Bessmert: They are closing the gate!

Bessmert: This is bad! We, we have to get in, or how are we going to get them back? We can't just leave them here ...

Bessmert: Neither can I just turn away from the clues to the Dùshuò Festival and the mysterious Eastern arcane power ...

Bessmert: Sir, I beg of you!

Bessmert rushes forward, attempting to pull back the guards and city gates with all her might.

But her lack of sight impedes her, unable to detect the hidden dangers on the uneven, packed-sand road.

—A loose stone is enough to trip her, and despite the demands of the moment, it takes her time to get back up again.

Gate Keeper: Don't get any closer.

Yenisei: Madam! Are you alright?!

She anxiously helps Bessmert to her feet, with her other hand tightly gripping an empty glass bottle.

They've had countless unpredictable mishaps along the way, enough to write an adventure story few would believe, and experienced more than enough to exhaust the will of any explorer.

Perhaps simply allowing the city gates to close is a safer and more appropriate approach.

Yenisei: Maybe we should just give up, Madam ... I'm even thinking if all these things we've been through are just illusions.

Yenisei: The unusual terrains, the teammates turned into striped horses, and now this nonsense ...

Yenisei: I won't let you go in there and risk your life!

Bessmert cannot see her companion's expression, but can hear the hesitation in her voice. It proves enough to add to her struggle to get up again.

Bessmert: No, on the contrary, child.

Bessmert: The unknown people, the uncharted city ... We are very close to what we've been chasing. We were born to run after these exciting and amazing things.

Bessmert: You're also looking for an answer from Ask and Acquire, right?

Bessmert: Besides, we have no idea how Mr. Jurien and the others are doing ... There is more to consider other than our own safety.

???: Well said. Speaking of which ...

???: The city is much safer than the wild. You have my word.

Lizheng: As for me, I am the Lǐzhèng of the biggest merchants hub in this city. You can address me by my title. **Lǐzhèng: A low-ranking government official responsible for taxation and household registrations.*

Yenisei: Lǐzhèng ...?

Bessmert: He sounds like a decent gentleman.

Gate Keeper: Lǐzhèng, they are the intruders!

Lizheng: Noted. The situation is under control. No need to close the gate. The ladies look like foreign merchants. Their business is within my purview.

Lizheng: Besides, it's holiday time. They could be here for the celebration. Don't be so harsh on them.

Gate Keeper: Understood.

The guard holds his hands in front of him and makes a gesture that Yenisei cannot understand before retreating to one side.

A glimmer of expectation is reignited in the hearts of Yenisei and Bessmert, as if their misfortune might have at last dissipated.

Lizheng: If I'm correct, you have lost your Pass, right?

Bessmert: We do have a Pass, but it seems it doesn't work here.

Lizheng: Well, just an understandable mistake for people from afar.

Lizheng: However, either for business or the Dùshuò Festival, it is troublesome without a proper Pass.

Bessmert: Dùshuò Festival? Is it taking place now?

Lizheng: That's what I said. I thought that is why you're here in Pèi City.

Bessmert: Uh, yes! We were told of it, but we've never been to one. We are not sure.

Bessmert: We all heard of the legend about it.

Lizheng: Hmm. So, is the festival sung as a nursery rhyme in your tribe?

Bessmert: Uh, "tribe"? We are not tribal people. We come from the North.

Lizheng: Northerners? Oh, I mistook you for the descendants of the Wūsūn from the westward.

Lizheng: It is said that they have migrated outside the Zhéluómàn Mountain. No one has ever met them until now. Your clothes also have a unique style. I should apologize for my mistake.

Lizheng: What's more, this lady by your side has red hair, green eyes, and a fair complexion. The features match the records in history books ...

Bessmert: History books? Mr. Lǐzhèng, in your history books, do you have ...

Lizheng: Like I said, you may just call me Lǐzhèng.

Lizheng: The book says, "Wūsūn, one of the tribes in the Western Regions, has the most unusual appearance. The present foreigners are their descendants with features of green eyes, red hair, and the looks of macaque monkeys."

Yenisei: M-Monkeys ...

Lizheng: Heh heh ... Maybe we can't believe every word in the book. No matter.

Lizheng: Where were we just now? Was it ...

Bessmert: Dùshuò Festival. We are here for the festival.

Lizheng: Oh, right. Exactly!

The old man in front of her seems to be full of interest, and with his hands clasped, he resumes his topic.

Lizheng: The Pèi City is famous for its grand celebration and joyful spirit during the festival. It attracts countless travelers from far away every year.

Lizheng: I could only imagine how hard it was for you to arrive here. Well done.

Lizheng: However, forgive me for being offensive. It seems you have lost sight in both eyes ...?

Bessmert: Yes. Would that be a problem?

Lizheng: Under this city's caring policy, you have the privilege of traveling without a Pass.

Lizheng: The gate guard is new here. I sincerely apologize for his offense.

He bows slightly, implying a subtle apology, and leads the two toward the city proper.

Lizheng: Come, follow me. It's not safe to stay outside of the city.

Lizheng: There have been many missing persons cases recently. We intensified the patrol, in case someone is blocked out of the city and goes missing.

Yenisei: Missing persons cases ...

Between further topics of conversation, the two follow Lǐzhèng's guidance and, at last, pass through the city gates.

6#1

Questions and Answers

NS-08

Tower

Lǐzhèng leads the two of them up the city wall to a connected inner chamber.

Yenisei cannot shake the notion that her next step will land on thin air, until they at last enter the room, and she can let go.

From the city gate to the room, the scenery is completely different from outside the city. Though it's a short distance, she is very impressed.

Yenisei: Emm ...

Lizheng: Have a seat.

Bessmert: Thank you.

Yenisei: Here, Madam.

Bessmert: I don't feel any chairs around me. How am I going to ...

Yenisei: It seems the people here sit on their heels. Here, cushion.

Lizheng: Just make yourself comfortable.

The two of them hobble onward, imitating the old man's unfamiliar posture as he kneels down beside a low table.

Lizheng: You ladies look better now. What were you going to ask?

There are many fears and doubts in their hearts that beg expression. However, the first to break the silence is nothing more than an odd query.

Yenisei: Your walls ... Won't they collapse?

Lizheng: Hmm? Why do you think that?

Yenisei: Because they seem to be made of only earth and stone. I don't think these materials can stand the weathering ...

Yenisei: Not to mention the wooden pavilion on the walls.

Lizheng: Haha. You draw the conclusion only by its appearance. In fact, the stakes are deeply driven into the ground and stand firmly. No need to worry about the peeling bricks and clay. It's just the sign of the city's longevity.

Yenisei: The city's longevity. So how old is this city?

Lizheng: As I recall, hundreds of years. Its annals take up most of the library. Each volume records a decade. Considering the large quantity, "hundreds" may not be the best quantifier.

Lizheng: There are many historical sites in the city. You may take your mother for a sight tour.

Yenisei: Madam Bessmert is not my mother.

Lizheng: Ms. Be- ... Oh, I apologize. I forgot about her sight ...

Between his words, Lǐzhèng instinctively casts an apologetic glance in Bessmert's direction.

Though she cannot see, she seems to feel something and turns her head towards his voice.

Bessmert: That's alright. People often mistake me for having good eyesight because I walk around freely like others.

Lizheng: The silver lining is, we have a caring policy in this regard. We're here to help, whether you need assistance or not.

Bessmert: You keep talking about my eyesight. May I ask why?

Lizheng: The government is obliged to provide help to people with severe impairments, including those who have lost their sights in both eyes. Isn't it the same with the Northerners?

Lizheng: Oh, if my question is offensive ...

Bessmert: No. That's fine. More than fine, actually ...

Bessmert: In the North, I have to do more to be treated like an ordinary person.

Lizheng: I see. I've heard that people in the North idolize the strong and pay little attention to the weak. Little did I know the disabled enjoy no privilege.

Lizheng: But now you're here with us in Pèi City. Please rest at ease.

Lizheng: Moreover, you speak fluent Hanese. I'm sure your stay here will go swimmingly.

Yenisei: ...! You mean we are speaking the "Hanese" right now?

Yenisei feels her hand being pressed lightly by Bessmert's own.

Lizheng: Are you not? It's interesting you ask. According to the records of the hub, most of the foreign merchants with fluent Hanese have lived a long time in the Central Plains. **Central Plains: the name given to China by the ancient Chinese.*

Lizheng: While you are obviously not one of them, neither have you paid frequent visits here, otherwise ...

Lizheng: You wouldn't have forgotten a proper Pass.

This somewhat insightful witticism surprises Bessmert.

Bessmert: You're a man of sharp wit, I have to say.

Bessmert: Back where we are from, merchants come and go, including those who speak your tongue. We've dealt with them a lot throughout the years.

Bessmert: If it weren't for their advice, we wouldn't have made it this far on our first journey as a new caravan.

Lizheng: I see. Foreign merchants are well-informed and welcomed by the citizens in Pèi City. Oh, there are other foreign merchants in the hub. If you have no place to stay, the caravanserai there might be a good choice ...

As he speaks, Lǐzhèng takes out a sheet of paper from a large stack.

Lizheng: Take this with you. It is the Pass to verify your identities.

Lizheng: You can enjoy your stay here with it, or you might end up being expelled.

Bessmert: Thank you. Then how are we going to ...

Lizheng: Please show me the documents you have now.

Bessmert: Certainly. Let me just ...

Yenisei: I have them. I always have them with me, Madam.

Bessmert: Oh. Thank you. You are reliable as always, child.

They hand over a document in a brown paper envelope.

Lizheng: Thank you. I will take a look.

Lizheng: Hold on a second.

Lizheng: ...

On this "document," besides a drawn red seal that roughly illustrates its purpose, the remaining descriptive handwriting looks like scrawled symbols, with the beginnings and ends of sentences connected hastily without leaving any gaps.

The embarrassment between reader and writer grows like a bubble waiting to pop.

Lizheng: Er ...

Lizheng: Looks like it's written in Turkic. Is it Turkic?

Yenisei: What? No ...

Bessmert makes a move before Yenisei finishes speaking. She pats the girl's back and gestures for her to allow her to explain.

Despite her doubts, the girl habitually follows her lead.

Bessmert: Yes, a variation of it. This is the written language in the North.

Yenisei: ...

Bessmert: Yeni, this is the written language in your hometown, also known as Yeniseic, isn't it?

Yenisei is almost certain that her companion is winking at her, despite her eyes being covered.

Or perhaps it is just her own intuition prompting her. She realizes then, in a moment of enlightenment, that in their precarious situation, she may well need to learn how to quickly accommodate these occasional lies.

Yenisei: Oh, yes. That's right.

Bessmert: My apologies. I should have known that our language is a rare kind in the Central Plains.

Lizheng: I understand. It's alright, but I'm afraid you have to write it down yourself, including where you came from.

Lizheng: Please take this file as a reference.

Yenisei: Thank you. I'll do it.

Yenisei: ...

Yenisei: Emm, sorry, but I don't think I can read it.

Lizheng: Hmm?

Lizheng: Oh, my mistake. I should have realized the paper work is much harder than oral communication.

Lizheng: But the servant is not here today ...

Lizheng: Alright, you can tell me, and I'll write it down. Like ... this one. What did you come to the city for?

Bessmert: For business.

Lizheng: How many of you are there in the team?

Bessmert: Seven, including us.

Yenisei: There WERE seven of us.

Lizheng: Were? Where are they now?

Bessmert: This is also what we are trying to find out.

Bessmert: On our way here, they were transformed into "horses" and taken away by a giant bird.

Lizheng: Transformed into horses? Um ... Then how come you didn't get transformed?

Yenisei: We have no idea. Perhaps because Madam Bessmert and I are arcanists, while the others are humans.

Lizheng: What do you mean?

Lizheng: Does the giant bird only attack humans? Then how does he identify them?

Lizheng: There is no huge difference between humans and arcanists, after all.

Yenisei: What? Emm ...

Bessmert: No huge difference?

This is an answer they had never considered before.

Or rather, it was a premise that seemed so distant to their own views that it defied being considered.

As if saying a diamond was no different from a clump of soil.

Lizheng: Is that a problem?

Bessmert: No, not at all.

Bessmert: Let's go back to the difference between humans and arcanists later.

Bessmert: My guess is, there might be something wrong with the water.

Bessmert: We found a river when crossing the steppe. Our teammates were too thirsty and drank the water in haste. Then we realized something was wrong.

Yenisei: Yes. It came from the northwest. Not a big one, but quite clean.

Lizheng: That might be the main river of Pèi City, called Pèilín River.

Lizheng: But it has been shrinking these past years. Also, there are no cases of people drinking it and turning into horses ... What were the features of that giant bird?

Yenisei: He has black or brown wings, red tail feathers, and a man's face.

Bessmert: Also, as I recall it, he has the voice of a young man.

Lizheng: A giant bird with a man's face. A feather man. Did he play a musical instrument?

Yenisei: He played a stick-like instrument. His music could lead the horses to where he went.

Lizheng: Was there a bone-like wand with him?

Yenisei: Could be, but I'm not sure. He was so far away from us.

Lizheng: I have a rough idea now.

Lizheng: ...

Lizheng: If that's what I think it is, even though he is not a Xiángruì, I have to say ... *sighs*

He seems to be overcome with regret.

Bessmert demurely adjusts her kneeling position, keenly sensing a new development.

Bessmert: Sounds like something happened when you last met.

Lizheng: The giant bird, or the feather man, as we say, was considered the Xiángruì by some citizens. It is because he looks like the legendary Gōumáng.

Bessmert: What is this Xiángruì? Is it some kind of guardian?

Lizheng: Not exactly. In most cases, Xiángruì is just Yāo, but in the good way. They are benevolent, using their power to help people and bless the area.

Lizheng: Before your report, there was someone else witnessing a feather man with a bone wand. He once brought some animals to the Zhící and claimed they were transformed from humans.

Bessmert: This ... this is exactly what happened to our teammates.

Lizheng: If these two are the same feather man, then he is very likely involved in these missing persons cases.

Yenisei: Oh, the cases you mentioned ... I see.

Lizheng: Too bad, that witness couldn't remember anything, even the slightest feature, for us to draw a picture. Since no one could provide other evidence, her word was considered nonsense.

Lizheng: The Fǎcáo thought she was "possessed" and suggested she take a break in her hometown during the holiday.

Bessmert: We want to pay her a visit. Will she come back?

Lǐzhèng waves his hand. There is little value to be gleamed from such a faulty clue.

Lizheng: I'm afraid not. She worked as the Zhílǐ in the Zhící. It's not a crucial position, but clearly not suitable for a possessed person. There is someone filling in for her now.

Yenisei grips the fabric on her knee. She is as persistent as a soldier when executing orders, and this time is no different.

Yenisei: What if ... What if I can offer a drawing of the feather man?

Yenisei: He was far away in mid-air at the time. I couldn't see the details, but I remember his outline and the color of his wings. Besides, I have experience in making sketches and maps.

Yenisei: I can totally make a drawing of him.

Lizheng: Sketch? Map? Hmm ... But we can only attach your drawing to the wanted poster for the moment. We can't put him in prison without solid evidence. Everything is yet to be confirmed by the court.

Lizheng: But a drawing is better than nothing. Please give it a try.

Lizheng: Here is the brush and the ink. Help yourself.

Yenisei approaches the table and picks up the brush that was used to write just moments ago.

Yenisei: This is the same long pen you just used?

Lizheng: That's right.

Yenisei: And this is ... the ink? But it won't adhere to the pen.

Lizheng: To get the liquid ink, you need to rub the ink stick on the ink stone first. It's fine. I'll rub it for you. You can focus on the drawing.

The old man rolls up his sleeves and deftly grinds out some ink for Yenisei to dip the brush in.

And the girl does not hesitate to write—

Yenisei: Huh? The lines it draws are really heavy ...

Yenisei: And do we only have the black ink?

Lizheng: ...

Lizheng: No, there are different colors.

Yenisei: May I have the red one?

Lizheng: Please hold on. I'll get it for you.

The slow and steady footsteps gradually move away.

6#1

Chaos on Streets

NS-09

Lizheng: This is great. With your drawing, we can issue wanted posters to find the feather man.

Yenisei: ...

Lizheng: You stay silent. Any questions or concerns?

Yenisei: You mentioned a former employee of the Zhící ... Or should I call her the Zhílǐ?

Yenisei: You said she had seen the feather man and the animals he brought. Then maybe he will come again today. If he shows up with our horse teammates ...

Lizheng: That is to say, the feather man she saw is the same person you met.

The old man follows his train of thought to its destination, frowns and ponders, before taking the brush from its holder yet again.

He neatly spreads out a new piece of paper, rubs an ink stick on the slab, and begins to write with a calm and swift hand.

Lizheng: In this case, a visit to the Zhící might be a good choice for you.

Lizheng: I will write a letter for you. Please take it to the Zhící and show it to Jiǔ Niángzǐ, the current Zhílǐ. If the feather man has been there, you can take over the animals he brought to her.

Lizheng: Even if he hasn't, you can still proceed with the letter, since Jiǔ Niángzǐ is very warm-hearted. She should be in the Zhící right now. You can find her there.

Yenisei: Thank you.

With this glimmer of hope, the turbulent emotions of these two strangers in a strange land find themselves anchored, temporarily at least.

Street, Inside the City

After receiving their pass, they are finally permitted into the city. Colorful silks hanging between pointed eaves. People bustle around, taking no notice of the extraordinary beauty around them.

On both sides of the street, there is a silver or copper charcoal pot in front of every house, crackling subtly and bringing spots of warmth to the cold day.

Yenisei: ...

Bessmert: We should go, Yeni.

They walk in the direction indicated by Lǐzhèng, from the silent neighborhood, to the dusty and bustling market.

The peddlers and street performers lay a steady claim to their spaces, forming eddies in the stream of pedestrians that flows toward the center of the main boulevard.

The more people flow toward that intersection, the more crowded it becomes. Until it becomes a slow-moving throng, impeding anyone wishing to move through it.

Yenisei: This is going to take forever if we have to follow the crowd.

Yenisei: Madam, do you think we can take the gaps between the houses? Or find a shortcut. That'd be even better ...

Citizen I: Ahh!

Insisting on politeness in a crowded space like this can often lead to such accidents.

Bessmert: Careful. What's wrong?

Yenisei: Sorry, we were in a hurry. Are you alright?

Citizen I: No problem. Don't worry about the bumping. Oh, aren't you the foreigners? I've never seen any red hair in the city. It's pretty.

Citizen I: It's holiday time. It's fine to stumble into people. But what's with the rush? Where are you going?

Yenisei: We are going to the Zhící.

Citizen I: Oh. But the way there is crowded with visitors. Maybe you can take the other road.

The gaudily-dressed woman frowns, clearly pondering how to describe it, but is just as soon distracted by a commotion.

A group of strange black creatures appear from somewhere nearby, dragging their long tails before soaring into the air.

Citizen I: Huh? They are ... Oh no, they are Zhúyès! What are they doing in the street during the daytime?!

Yenisei: Zhúyè? What's that? Some kind of critter?

Zhuye the Monster?: Squeak ... Coo ... Squeak!

They jump down from the eaves, flapping their sticky little wings and violently raising a wave of flying dust accompanied by strangely fragrant drops of water.

Bessmert: Umm, an extraordinary smell. Like liquor.

The travelers on the street run away, harangued by the creatures flapping their wings at them everywhere they turn.

Citizen II: Why are they here? Oh! I smell liquor. A lot of liquor!

Citizen II: Who broke the liquor jar and attracted them here?!

???: People! A Zhúyè in the street during daytime is a sign of auspiciousness. Stay calm!

Yenisei: It's coming our way! Watch out, Madam!

It seems as though the ringleader's movements are even more exaggerated than the others, perhaps realizing that it is being underestimated.

It flies straight toward the center of the crowd, readying its talons.

Zhuye the Monster: Coo!

Zhuye the Monster: Coo! Squeak! Squeak!

The Zhúyè's ambition to dominate the street is ended by the sudden intrusion of rampaging livestock that burst into the scene.

The milieu of beasts, pedestrians, and fliers soon becomes so entirely chaotic, that no one present seems to have any grasp of what is happening beyond the end of their nose.

???: Um ... S-sorry!

???: You ... You guys! COME BACK!

???: Bad boys and girls!

Zhuye the Monster: Coo coo! Coo! Coo!

Bessmert: What's going on? All this shouting and running about ...?!

Bessmert: I smell liquor and dust. What happened?

Yenisei: A kind of local animal named Zhúyè popped up in the street. Maybe they are arcane creatures? I don't know. I've never seen one in books. The liquor smell probably comes from them.

Yenisei: And ... I think a herd of livestock rushed out of the fence over there, but I can't see it clearly.

Yenisei: Sorry, Madam. We are not supposed to stop here.

Ignoring the chaos around them, the two travelers decide to leave before even more commotion starts.

This bizarre scene of animals, critters and people leaping every which way and everywhere was never part of their plan.

Citizen I: We are already having enough trouble with the Zhúyè. Who let out these Festive Animals now?

It seems life has seen fit to frustrate their plans yet again.

Citizen I: Wait ...

Citizen I: Jiǔ Niángzǐ?!

—The familiar name hums in Yenisei's mind.

Citizen I: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, aren't you supposed to be in the Zhící during work hours? What are you ...

Jiu Niangzi: Um ... I ...

Jiu Niangzi: No time for explaining!

Jiu Niangzi: Anyway ... They're escaping!

Jiu Niangzi: And I'm ... I'm losing them!!

Yenisei: Jiǔ Niángzǐ? That's the one Lǐzhèng told us to talk to, isn't it?

The girl named Jiǔ Niángzǐ tries to sound as relaxed as possible in reply, but the scene before her is one obviously and rapidly spiraling out of her control.

A panicked sweat drips down her forehead.

If she lets go now, these wild creatures will wreak havoc on the market street and everyone on it.

Yenisei: Madam, I ...

Yenisei's instincts tell her to step forward. She looks toward the Zhící, still out-of-sight in the distance, then turns back to look at Bessmert.

Bessmert can feel her gaze and nods gently.

Bessmert: Go. I will wait here.

Jiu Niangzi: Er ...

Two of the horses suddenly bolt forward, as if testing the strength of the people behind them.

Jiu Niangzi: Whoa!

Jiu Niangzi: Please, please, guys ... I can't hold on anymore!

The girl in the center of the crowd strains to keep her eyes fixed on the horde of animals more than outmatching her strength.

Her obviously waning control does nothing to contain the chaos. All she can do is twist the hemp rope tightly in her hand, winding it one hoop after another, until it is so tight that rough-edged rope cuts into her hand.

Citizen IV: Oh, let me help!

Citizen II: Yeah! I'll help, too!

Citizen II: I wonder how these animals got out ...

It is at this moment that finally—heeding the call to come to their senses, the crowd begins to rush forward to assist.

Jiu Niangzi: Thank you! Thanks ... everyone ...

Jiu Niangzi: Please ... help me ... pull harder!

Jiu Niangzi: Hold on!

Jiu Niangzi: You all get a drink on the house!

After a short while, with help from the other streetgoers, she manages to get the rampaging, if festively decorated, animals back under control.

She deftly ties the quelled animals to the flagpole, then, breathing a well-earned sigh of relief, lets the rope finally slack down from her hands.

Jiu Niangzi: Oh dear, thank you so much ...

Jiu Niangzi: I couldn't do this without you ... Making so much trouble on the first day of work ...

She pants heavily, still recovering from her battle—a battle to defend her hometown.

Citizen I: Where were you, Jiǔ Niángzǐ? I didn't see you in the tavern.

Jiu Niangzi: Me? I was in the Zhící.

Citizen III: What were you doing there?

Citizen I: Oh, Mr. Liǔ, did you forget again? The former Zhílǐ went back to her hometown. Jiǔ Niángzǐ is the new Zhílǐ now.

Jiu Niangzi: No, no, that's not it. I'm just, um, covering for her! I was counting the Festive Animals, and then I heard the noise outside ...

Citizen II: Haha, you must have been distracted by the Storyteller, huh? He was telling the end of the story today, so you would never miss it.

Jiu Niangzi: Well, yeah. I thought he might tell the story of Xiángruì, so I hurried out and forgot to lock the fence. Hmm ...

Citizen I: You're talking about Xiángruì again. People would think you were another Storyteller if they didn't know you just really like these tales.

Citizen III: Are your palms bruised? Go to my clinic for medicine if it hurts.

Citizen II: Remember the drinks on the house!

Jiu Niangzi: Of course, I will! Thank you so so much!

She speaks with warm familiarity to the other residents, but keeps an eye in the direction of the tea house—as though anxious to confirm whether the Storyteller from before is still there.

After seeing his swaying figure in the distance, a look of joy lightens up her face.

Yenisei: ...

Yenisei quietly observes the scene and retreats, turning around to walk toward Bessmert. The conversations among the locals flow into her ears, allowing her to confirm a crucial fact.

Yenisei: Please follow me, Madam. That lady must be the "Zhílǐ" that Lǐzhèng mentioned.

Yenisei: Please mind your steps, as we are walking in a mess now. We need to follow the crowd and see if we will have a chance to talk to her.

Storyteller: Let's put aside the Zhúyè for now ...

Yenisei: ...?

Little sooner than they reach the tea house, do they notice the crowd rushing toward a stone platform, filling up every nearby space before they have a chance to find a seat.

The crowd fills the tea house tightly. The surge of people pushes Bessmert and Yenisei right in front of the Storyteller.

Storyteller: ... And talk about Emperor Yáo. He had seen strange beasts like this many times ...

He speaks with eloquence, as if possessing some strange magic that naturally attracts even those who didn't go there to hear him.

Storyteller: It was the seventh year of his reign. Yáo granted an audience to an envoy offering a treasure from the Jiéxiōng Kingdom. The envoy had a strange face and a bulgy chest. He claimed to have come from somewhere millions of miles away from the Yùmén Pass.

Storyteller: "This bird is born with the talent for human languages and the phoenix's voice. Our people see it as a Xiángruì, and I am here to offer it to you, Your Majesty!"

Storyteller: Then Yáo and his people saw a real giant bird. It was as huge as a mountain and as dazzling as a phoenix. It had an azure body and red tail feathers!

Citizen II: Was it really a phoenix?

Storyteller: Oh no, no. The bird was called Mièméng. It was said to be able to read one's bones, change their fate, and even remove misfortune!

Storyteller: Yáo was pleased with the gift and kept the bird in Dùshuò Mountain. Naturally, that very bird was the ancestor of all the Mièméngs nowadays.

The envy in the eyes of the girl clad in green matches her attire completely.

Jiu Niangzi: H-have you seen a Mièméng with your own eyes?

Storyteller: Be patient and listen. Mièméngs tend to inhabit silent and clean environments, so since the ancient times, the people have always cleaned their yards carefully from time to time, hoping the Xiángruìs will gather and stay beside them. It may not work immediately, but it makes things possible in the long term.

Citizen III: So that's why we have the tradition of cleaning the yards on Shuòrì?

Storyteller: Exactly. Some even make Mièméng statues with jewelry and use them to decorate their homes, hoping the Mièméngs will bless the family. Remember the "chicken" statues on your roof? Actually, they are not chickens but Mièméngs, so are those birds you see in the paper-cutouts on the doors.

After saying this, he lifts a piece of red paper, carved in the shape of a peculiarly familiar bird.

Storyteller: Look, everyone. This is the Mièméng.

The crowd expresses an underwhelmed disappointment.

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm. But this looks like a normal chicken ...

Yenisei: More like a capercaillie to me.

Yenisei: And like the bird I just drew, isn't it?

Bessmert: The way he is speaking is interesting, rhythmic, like singing. It would be great if there was some music to accompany him. Something is missing in his story without the music.

Bessmert: If he could ...

Before Bessmert can finish speaking, the red paper instantly ignites in the hands of the Storyteller, and before touching his fingers, it becomes ashes and falls onto the stone platform.

The little boy standing beside him stands on his tiptoes, quickly taking the initiative to sweep the ashes into the charcoal pot below.

Storyteller: Among the Five Elements, Mièméng belongs to the Fire. That's why people set fire in spring to drive away misfortunes. Speaking of ...

Yenisei's attention is diverted. She witnesses the child's movements, but doesn't yet understand the meaning behind them, choosing to stare ahead until a crackling sound explodes behind her.

Bessmert: What is this noise?

It seems no one cares about the noise of the cracker. Only Jiǔ Niángzǐ, who had previously worked so hard to restore order to the bustling city, turns around with the two of them.

As she turns around, she seems to remember something and shows a remorseful look.

Jiu Niangzi: The cracker ... Shoot. I almost forgot!

Jiu Niangzi: Sorry, excuse me! Please let me go out ...

Citizen II: You won't listen to the rest? It's still early. Oh, are you going back to the tavern to make our drinks?

Jiu Niangzi: Not drinks, but other stuff! Oh, and "drinks on the house" tomorrow!

Everyone chuckles warmly, making way for Jiǔ Niángzǐ. Yenisei holds onto Bessmert to prevent her from falling behind.

This time, they follow her without incident. Despite the strangers' otherwise eye-catching hair, everyone's attention seems focused intently on the Storyteller telling the legend.

6#1

Treat Them Right

NS-10

Not far away, Jiǔ Niángzǐ can be seen stopping near the post where the animals were tied, vaguely moving as if whispering something to them.

Jiu Niangzi: Um, can you understand me?

Jiu Niangzi: Can you tell me where you are from?

Yenisei: Hello ...

Yenisei waits for a moment before walking forward and attempting to pat her shoulder.

The girl turns around to reveal her young and eager face.

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm? What's wrong? I don't know you. Have we met before?

Yenisei: I don't think so. We just arrived here.

Jiu Niangzi: Really? Oh, welcome to Pèi City!

Yenisei cannot help but hold her eyes on the bundled hemp rope the girl is holding in her hand, and the many animals now tied at the end of it.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ blinks, then blinks again, as though realizing what the other girl is staring at.

A blush quickly rises to her cheeks like two sunset clouds.

Jiu Niangzi: Oh ... Y-you were on the street, weren't you?

Jiu Niangzi: I am so sorry. I didn't mean to make such a scene there. I promise, it was just an accident!

Bessmert: I can imagine. You reacted quickly and saved us from more trouble.

Jiu Niangzi: No, no, no, it was my responsibility. And the people on the street also gave me a hand there!

Jiu Niangzi: How can I help you? Please feel free to let me know.

She seems to be a warm-hearted type.

Yenisei: Here's the case: The people call you Jiǔ Niángzǐ, and you work in the Zhící, right?

Jiu Niangzi: Ng, ng. Yes!

Yenisei: Lǐzhèng told us to find you, and we happened to hear your conversation on the street.

Yenisei: So did the feather man come here today?

Jiu Niangzi: Feather man? You mean the Xiángruì out of the city? Um, I heard that he had been here. As for today, I have no idea.

Yenisei: What about the animals in the fence? Any new ones?

Jiu Niangzi: I-I'm not sure about that either. When I arrived at the Zhící this morning, there were already many Festive Animals in the fence.

Jiu Niangzi: They're getting more and more ... How weird is that!

Jiǔ Niángzǐ mutters inaudibly before turning around, pointing out the culprits who caused her so much trouble earlier with her index finger.

Yenisei inspects the creatures briefly but doesn't seem to notice any difference. It seems to be a show for common livestock, where various cattle, sheep, and horses might compete to show their worth.

Jiu Niangzi: See, they all look alike. I can't tell which of them were brought here today. Counting is troublesome as well. I always think, "where am I?"

Jiu Niangzi: If only I could read and write. You write them down, then you won't miscount.

Yenisei: Our teammates have been turned into striped horses, like these.

Yenisei: Actually, we are a team of merchants. When we reached the outskirts of the city, our teammates were turned into horses and brought away by a giant bird.

Yenisei: Lǐzhèng said that bird was probably the feather man they've been looking for, and he appeared around the Zhící once.

Yenisei: That's why we are here to ask for help.

Jiu Niangzi: They're-They're not horses, I suppose.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ seems hesitant to say anything further.

Jiu Niangzi: But-but how is that possible? Are you saying that the feather man can turn people into ... into horses ...?

Jiu Niangzi: I don't understand. How did he get this power? Is it because he is the Xiángruì?

Upon hearing the word "Xiángruì" again, Bessmert's interest is immediately captured.

Bessmert: We've also heard about the Xiángruì from the Storyteller. It does sound like some kind of local guardian.

Jiu Niangzi: Guardian? Is it the Gods of Shètí we're talking about?

Bessmert: Oh, yes, the Gods of Shètí. These are the gods you serve.

Bessmert: I guess Xiángruì is closer to a local legend, like a reputed arcanist in this area. The use of arcane skills seems common here. Perhaps there are also many arcanists around.

Bessmert: But, could you please tell us more about the Gods of Shètí?

Jiu Niangzi: There are 12 ... or 13 of them, I guess? That's all I know. I can't read most of their names.

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, but I know this year is the year of Zhíxú! We will bring lots of Festive Animals to the broken bridge to worship It.

Jiu Niangzi: The Fortune Walk and Bridge Leap are the most fun parts! We go to the broken bridge on the cliff with the animals, count our steps, and swing our bodies, like dancing. And at last, we will try to jump over it!

Yenisei: Jump over a broken bridge on the cliff? It sounds dangerous and quite ... familiar.

Bessmert knows exactly what Yenisei is hinting at. The familiar rule of "Ask and Acquire" resurfaces in their minds, but no one attempts to ask it out loud.

So that Jiǔ Niángzǐ's explanation interrupts their thoughts with perfect timing.

Jiu Niangzi: No, no, no, we can't do that. No one has even done that! Even the goats can't do that, let alone humans.

Jiu Niangzi: We'll also cast arcane skills as safety measures to protect anyone from falling.

Jiu Niangzi: The valley is deeeep down there. Once you fall down, you're not coming back.

Bessmert: Intriguing. And who's in charge of the safety measures, may I ask?

Jiu Niangzi: The staff in the Zhící. It's the place to manage arcane affairs in the Pèi City.

Jiu Niangzi: But not me ... I'm new here, filling in for the former Zhílǐ after she went back to her hometown.

Jiu Niangzi: They told me to take care of Zhící for a couple of days. That's good enough for me!

Her eagerness to be able to help is clear.

Yenisei: So, simply put, you're a doorkeeper?

The barb of her conclusion makes Jiǔ Niángzǐ fluster into a red blush.

Jiu Niangzi: I-I'm not-I'm not just keeping the door safe! I do stuff too!

Jiu Niangzi: Like, um, take good care of those startled by the fire crackers! There is a kind of firecracker enhanced by arcane skill. It can make a huuuge sound! Much more louder than what you heard in the tea house!

Bessmert: Please forgive her. She didn't mean to hurt your feelings. We speak bluntly in the North.

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, it's alright. I can tell she's a bit anxious.

Jiu Niangzi: But it's not getting us anywhere. Like, um, pigs can't learn how to climb in a day ...

Yenisei: ...

Jiu Niangzi: Or, let's think another way. Can you recognize your teammates from these horses?

Jiu Niangzi: Let me see, there are one, two, three ... three striped horses. Come see for yourself.

Yenisei: I can't. There was little time for me to memorize the difference. Besides, even if they are my teammates, two of them are still missing.

Jiu Niangzi: More than three teammates?

Jiu Niangzi: When three plus two ...

Jiǔ Niángzǐ counts out the numbers on her fingers, calculating with great care.

Bessmert: How about we wait and see what Lǐzhèng has found out?

Bessmert: That's right, child, didn't Lǐzhèng leave us with a letter?

Yenisei: Oh, right. I almost forgot. Please read this, Ms. Jiǔ Niángzǐ. It may have clues about the feather man.

She produces the letter, offering it to the girl.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ opens it in front of them without a moment's hesitation, but all Yenisei can see on it are several images.

Jiu Niangzi: Um ...

Jiu Niangzi: Make the fence taller ... Get off work earlier and ... go back to the tavern?

Jiu Niangzi: What is he trying to say?

Jiu Niangzi: What do these have to do with the feather man?

Yenisei: Hmm?

Bessmert: ...

Jiǔ Niángzǐ mutters to herself as she stares at the pictures on the letter, before frowning and smoothing it out. She clumsily folds it and clips it to her waist.

Jiu Niangzi: Well, don't worry! I'll pay close attention to the new horses for you!

Jiu Niangzi: If there's any good news, I'll ask Lǐzhèng to tell you.

Bessmert: You're so kind. But we just got here and haven't decided where to stay for the night. How are we going to keep Lǐzhèng informed once we find a place to rest?

Jiu Niangzi: Oh ... I see ...

An answer leaps to her mind, bursting through and out at the same time.

Jiu Niangzi: How about staying in my tavern? I forgot to tell you that I'm the owner of a tavern.

Jiu Niangzi: And I'm doing it well!

She laughs, as though just the saying of it might render it true.

Jiu Niangzi: It is located in the merchants hub, two streets away from the Zhící. Lǐzhèng will know your whereabouts since he's in charge of the hub.

Jiu Niangzi: I'll take you back to the tavern, also escort these animals back to the Zhící. You can check out other animals there as well!

Yenisei: Good idea.

Bessmert: That'd be great. Saves us from all the trouble sleeping on the streets.

Jiu Niangzi: Let's go then. Oh, the street looks beautiful later in the night. You can't miss the golden lanterns and bonfires lit on Dùshuò Festival! They light up the sky and the street as if it's daytime.

Jiu Niangzi: Everything seems brighter at night.

6#1

Night Talk

NS-11

A breathtaking number of animals lie within the Zhící—a fact that only hinders their efforts to find their companions.

After weighing their options, they decide to follow Jiǔ Niángzǐ and settle in at the tavern first. The weary travelers are more than eager to relieve their fatigue after journeying non-stop for so long.

And they've more than earned it, because strange things have indeed happened to them, non-stop for several days.

Yard, Tavern

Yenisei: Madam ...

Yenisei: What do you think about Jiǔ Niángzǐ's words? Could that be "Ask and Acquire"?

Bessmert: Jumping over a broken bridge is like "jumping over a canyon or climbing over a mountain." It's a condition that cannot be met, like those merchants said.

Yenisei: An inevitable price?

Both of them fall silent, lost in thought.

However, Bessmert's doubts do not seem to have fallen on deaf ears, as Jiǔ Niángzǐ responds while walking out from the tavern.

Jiu Niangzi: Are you talking about the broken bridge outside the city?

Jiu Niangzi: I'm so sorry. The chairs in the lobby have not been cleaned yet. Please take a seat here, just for now.

Bessmert: Oh, don't worry about it. Thank you for letting us stay here.

Bessmert: As for the broken bridge we talked about ... can you tell me more about it?

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm, when I first got here, the bridge was already broken.

Jiu Niangzi: Beneath that is a deeeep canyon. Across that canyon stands the Yuān Temple. You can't see it from the other side of the bridge. It's surrounded by fog. So, I'm not sure if there really is a temple there or not.

Yenisei: The Yuān Temple ...

Jiu Niangzi: They said you can talk to Zhíxú in the Yuān Temple. Be faithful and ask It. It will answer you.

Jiu Niangzi: What did they call this? "The Divination," I think? They also said that the fog was strange. You can't stay there for long, or you'll pass out or get overexcited ... Well, I haven't seen such things so far.

Bessmert: ...!

Jiu Niangzi: But even so, people of that time still rushed there and prayed. Doesn't it mean that The Divination is for real? After the bridge was broken, no one's wish was ever granted.

Bessmert: Seems odd. There was already a bridge in the first place. Why wouldn't people rebuild it in all these years?

Jiu Niangzi: I can answer this one! The river dried out. People couldn't swim across, and the cliffs between the mountains were too dangerous to jump over.

Jiu Niangzi: But, if one can be the new Xiángruì, the problem will be solved.

Jiu Niangzi: The Xiángruìs are awesome! They protect the city, help the people ... There's nothing they can't do ...

As she speaks, she sinks into her own personal contemplation.

Yenisei: Never mind. We'll check the striped horses in the Zhící again tomorrow.

Jiu Niangzi: Alright, I'll go with you! It's time to rest now. I got the rooms cleaned for you upstairs.

Jiu Niangzi: And here, take the liquor with you. They can help you sleep tight!

Jiu Niangzi: You got to have some.

Yenisei: Sorry, Ms. Jiǔ Niángzǐ. I don't drink, neither does Madam Bessmert.

Jiu Niangzi: Why did you call me "Ms." twice?

Jiu Niangzi: Um, if you want some water, wait a second, please. The water jars are on the other side of the yard. I'll get it for you.

Yenisei: Oh, I can do it myself. You don't have to ...

Jiu Niangzi: It's fine. There is no light near the jar. You need to cross a stream. I'm afraid you might get lost ...

Yenisei: Thank you.

Once the girl's voice and figure are obscured by the night, Yenisei turns to look at Bessmert.

She seems puzzled, or perhaps, just tired.

Yenisei: There were so many different striped horses in the Zhící. I couldn't recognize them at all.

Yenisei: We are going to get up early tomorrow. Please have some water and go to bed.

Bessmert: I'm not thirsty, thank you. But I do feel like some rest.

Yenisei: Okay. I'll take you to the room.

The girl returns from fetching water, only to find Yenisei alone in the hallway.

Looking around and not seeing Bessmert, she walks over and naturally sits where Bessmert sat earlier.

Jiu Niangzi: I didn't see you from there. I thought you went to sleep.

Yenisei: Oh, sorry. Madam Bessmert is tired, so ...

Yenisei: Thank you for helping us.

Jiu Niangzi: Don't bother. Here's the water.

As she takes up the ceramic cup, Yenisei is slightly surprised.

In her mind, a material like this is one of two extremes—crudeness and finesse, one of handmade rough bowls used by the populace, and the latter of delicate treasures owned only by the rich nobles ...

Yet this cup is a combination of the two extremes—it's used by an ordinary tavern owner, but it is marked by a refined, tasteful aesthetic.

Yenisei: ...

She rubs the side of the cup with her fingers, gently brushing across the painted patterns, as if feeling a fine porcelain vase.

Yenisei: The cup ...

Jiu Niangzi: What's wrong?

Yenisei: It looks expensive.

Jiu Niangzi: It's a gift I received. I don't know how much it costs, but it's delicate, isn't it?

Yenisei: Yes, it is delicate.

Yenisei feels compelled to rub the surface of the ceramic cup again, as though she cannot bear to part from it, and loses herself in thought.

Jiu Niangzi: The pattern is a Lùshǔ, also a kind of Xiángruì.

Jiu Niangzi: See? It's majestic. The tail is like the sunset clouds. I really like it. I hope you do too.

Yenisei: Majestic indeed. And it looks a bit like those striped horses in the Zhící. Both of them are similar to horses.

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm ... but people still think they are horses. Don't they?

Yenisei: Sure, they do. I think this species is native to Pèi City. It's an interesting discovery and will help enrich our travel notes.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ lowers her head to look at the cup in her own hand. Yenisei can smell a fermented aroma emanating from within, like kvass, but without the sweet aroma of wheat.

Jiu Niangzi: She is in bed now. I can only drink it for her.

Yenisei: Your drink smells good. Is this the liquor that helps one sleep tight?

Jiu Niangzi: Not exactly. It's just unfiltered liquor.

Yenisei: Sounds like you have a lot of different kinds of liquor here.

Jiu Niangzi: Sure, we do. There are a lot of different liquors. The unfiltered ones, the clear ones, the ones made of herbs, the fine ones ... and on and on. Bedtime liquor is made of herbs with Spine Date Seeds.

Yenisei: I thought liquor was just liquor. At least there aren't so many types in my hometown.

Jiu Niangzi: Well, to be honest, I too have no idea why they are still "liquor," though they have different names.

Jiu Niangzi: If the color is the standard to classify them, then what am I when I'm wearing different colored clothes? Am I not Jiǔ Niángzǐ anymore?

Yenisei: Haha.

Shocked, Yenisei cannot help but break into a laugh.

Seeing the other girl smile, Jiǔ Niángzǐ's eyes begin to sparkle. She nods and decides to go one step further and express her thoughts.

Jiu Niangzi: That is to say, if your teammates are turned into horses or other animals in different colors, are they not your teammates anymore?

Yenisei: They are, of course ...

Yenisei stops talking. This childish conversation might have caused her to erupt with laughter, but the weight of the situation is still acute, and her worries swell deep within her.

The chirping of birds in the cold night gently blankets the sound of her anxious breathing.

Yenisei: I'm worried, actually.

Yenisei: Well, maybe not just worried. I don't know.

Jiu Niangzi: Looks like you really miss your teammates.

Yenisei: "Miss" them?

Yenisei: I ... I won't use this word to describe my feeling.

Yenisei: All I'm thinking is, they were turned into animals because I gave them the wrong direction.

Yenisei: What if ... What if they can't turn back to who they really are ...

The frankness of her own inquiry unmasks the long unease Yenisei had been harboring since entering this strange city.

After speaking, she holds her breath and controls the impulse to turn back and look toward Bessmert. For a moment she is no longer even sure of where she is.

Jiu Niangzi: But I don't think that will happen! Things won't get any worse.

Yenisei: Hmm?

Jiu Niangzi: There must be a way. I promise!

Jiu Niangzi: Like the clouds turn colorful, pool water gets sweet like liquor ... There are many signs of auspiciousness. They just need time.

Jiu Niangzi: Think about it, what if the story about the Yuān Temple is real? Maybe, maybe there will be another way for you to recognize your teammates.

Jiu Niangzi: Even if the feather man is not a Xiángruì, there are other Xiángruìs in the city.

Jiu Niangzi: All in all ...

Jiǔ Niángzǐ racks her brain to find another way to persuade Yenisei, but is stopped by the other girl before she can begin.

Despite the cultural differences between the two of them, Yenisei feels a surge of warmth from her brief trembling words.

Yenisei: Thank you, Ms. ... No, Jiǔ Niángzǐ.

Yenisei: I see what you mean. I really do.

Yenisei takes a deep breath and exhales both calm emotions and words together, so that like a light white smoke they soon drift away.

Yenisei: Thank you.

Jiu Niangzi: It's nothing! I will definitely help you!

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, here are some other Spine Date seeds. Drink the water, and I'll go make you a cup of tea with the seeds. It also helps you sleep ...

Jiǔ Niángzǐ shoots up to immediately rummage around in the bag beside her as she urges Yenisei to drain what is left in her cup.

Yenisei drinks down all of the cold, sweet water and hands the still-compelling cup back to her ...

She then watches Jiǔ Niángzǐ step onto the porch and run back into the hall at a trot.

Yenisei: *exhales*

She takes a long breath and turns to look at the arid night sky.

It seems even in a strange city like this, she can enjoy the same bright moonlight as the steppes.

6#1

Dancing Dolls

NS-12

The curtain of night has already fallen, but even after drinking another cup of tea promised to induce drowsiness, Yenisei finds that sleep evades her.

In theory, someone so heavily fatigued, should fall fast asleep the very moment the opportunity presents itself. But not for her.

On the contrary, her mind, so sick with worries, seems to run faster now than ever in the stillness of night.

Yenisei: ...

Bessmert: ...

Yenisei: *sighs*

She stands up, steps away from the couch, and treads lightly down the stairs.

Unwelcome in even her own dreams, she wanders around without direction.

Yenisei: The yard ... Go downstairs and through the main hall ...

Groping around for the railing in the darkness, she walks up and then down the steps.

One step, another step ... As she descends, a rustling sound envelops her in the darkness, like an indelible point that demands her whole focus.

Yenisei: Hmm? What's that sound ...

Yenisei: Where does it come from?

???: **By the flowers in the snow, raise a toast and don't say no.**

Yenisei: ...

Yenisei: Who is it? Someone's ...

Yenisei: ... singing?

Without realizing it, she departs the second floor and follows the sound into the spacious hall of the tavern.

With the cascading moonlight and melodious singing, the scene laid out before her is one that defies description.

Yenisei: What ...

Yenisei: The striped horses—how come they are ... glowing?!

Yenisei: What ...

Yenisei: What on earth is happening?!

Yenisei: I ...

Yenisei: Gosh!

With its red mane and luminous stripes, the "horse" stands there in the courtyard and turns gently toward her.

The singing continues, almost freezing Yenisei in place. She turns around sharply, trying to escape the sound, only to realize that she has already been surrounded ...

... by the group of wooden dolls who were in her cup earlier.

Wooden Dolls: **By the flowers in the snow, raise a toast and don't say no.**

Yenisei: ...?

Wooden Dolls: **Fill your cup, fill your cup!**

Yenisei: Are they ... asking me to drink?

Yenisei: Jiǔ Niángzǐ! Where are you?

Yenisei: Is she ...

Now, the wooden dolls, originally submerged in the stream in the courtyard, have begun to climb up the bank.

They surround her, spinning, singing, and contorting, with bodies clearly possessing a flexibility beyond what wood should possess.

Using this odd flexibility, they repeatedly lift their full cups toward Yenisei.

Wooden Dolls: **No turning down, no turning down!**

Yenisei: No ...

This invitation, perhaps initially hospitable, turns increasingly creepy in the dark night.

Making a choice now requires next to no thought. Yenisei jumps out from their enclosure and runs toward the other end of the yard—toward the water jar.

Fortunately, she clearly remembered the location pointed out by Jiǔ Niángzǐ.

Yenisei: I can't go back to my room. Need to lead them away.

The wooden dolls still sing happily, as if they are only playing a game of tag.

Yenisei: Ugh!

The wooden dolls stage a disorganized offensive, with a piercing song that twists Yenisei's perception of her surroundings.

She can only stand by the water jar, in a constant retreat, consciously nearing a dead end.

Wooden Dolls: *sound of wood rubbing*

Wooden Dolls: Clack. Clack. Clack.

Yenisei: No ...

Yenisei: Can't stop here. I must go ... farther.

Yenisei: Come here! This way!

The wooden figures have no ears, so it seems unlikely they hear or understand her.

Nonetheless, they are lured in, leaping forward with strange enthusiasm.

Never tiring. Just like those cups, always lifted high, constantly spilling and overflowing.

Wooden Dolls: *sound of wood rubbing*

???: ...

It seems these crude wooden creations are quick to be alert to sudden interlopers.

They immediately stop their siege of Yenisei and abruptly turn toward the tall trees in the courtyard.

Yenisei: Hmm? Where are they going?

Wooden Dolls: Clack! Clack!

Wooden Dolls: Clack! Clack!

The coercive rhythm plays heavier and faster than before, as they jump a few more hops toward the bottom of the tree—

???: Be off!

A wand of bone flies out from the darkness, scattering liquor and shattering the wooden figures into pieces.

???: ...

Serenity comes back to the scene, the end coming as swiftly as its beginning.

???: They are conjured ...

???: ... so feebly.

Yenisei: Who ... Who is it?!

???: Hmm?

???: It's you?

Yenisei: You? The feather man who stole our horses!

???: No matter. You're leaving with me.

Yenisei: Leave me alone! What is going on?

???: Silence. It's dangerous here, and words are no help to us.

Without hesitation, the giant bird grabs Yenisei's arms quickly, lifting her up and away from the courtyard.

Her struggle proves futile in the howling wind.

Yenisei: Aaaah!

The sound of flapping wings punctuated by the shrieking girl gradually fades in the distance, leaving only a disordered mess as evidence in the courtyard.

In the morning, Jiǔ Niángzǐ walks into the shambolic scene.

A still-intact wooden doll bounces around, gathering the remains of its kind into a ball.

Wooden Doll: **Alas, alas. An arm is missing. Can't put them together, anymore.**

Jiu Niangzi: ...

Wooden Doll: **Late. You are late.**

Jiu Niangzi: What's going on?

Jiu Niangzi: I told you to keep the house, not to tear it down.

Wooden Doll: **Being, a, good host. Offering, a drink.**

Jiu Niangzi: Offer a drink to whom?

Jiu Niangzi: Those two ladies should be soundly asleep upstairs.

Wooden Doll: **One, was downstairs, at night. Bird man, with her.**

Jiu Niangzi: Bird man ... You mean that feather man? He had been here?!

Jiu Niangzi: What was he doing here? He's not even a Xiángruì, nor is he doing anything good. Do not offer a drink to him!

Jiu Niangzi: Humph. If I were the one treating him, I would ...

Wooden Doll: **He took one, with him.**

Jiu Niangzi: I would ... I, wait, what?

Jiu Niangzi: Took whom with him??

Wooden Doll: **The scarlet. The brown, took away, the scarlet.**

Jiu Niangzi: Brown? Scarlet? What color is that?

Jiu Niangzi: *sighs* You're just confusing me. I'll make you one more mouth next time. What on earth are you talking about.

Bessmert: Hiss ...

Jiǔ Niángzǐ turns around to see Bessmert fall over the threshold.

She quickly approaches with her skirt held up, and the wooden doll jumping up and down, hiding behind her.

Jiu Niangzi: Be careful! I'll help you.

Bessmert: Thank you. Thank you so much.

Bessmert: Where's Yenisei? Did you see her upstairs or in the yard?

Jiu Niangzi: Are you talking about your red-haired friend? Did she go out?

Bessmert: No, not very likely. She would have told me if she was going out. Or at least ask someone to pass on the message.

Bessmert: Did you really not see her today?

Jiǔ Niángzǐ racks her brain, her voice coming out serious and resolute.

Jiu Niangzi: No, not this morning, no.

Bessmert: ...

Bessmert: The missing persons cases! Is this how they happened?!

Jiu Niangzi: I-I don't know. Lǐzhèng didn't make it in time to tell me the details ...

Bessmert falls into silence. This is a loss that she finds difficult to accept.

Bessmert: If—I'm only saying—if this is another missing case, there must be a clue or two telling us what happened.

Bessmert: Could you please look around and see if she has left anything in the yard? She must have been taken from there, or I would have definitely heard the noises.

Bessmert anxiously grasps Jiǔ Niángzǐ's hands. Their hands are equally coarse—one pair exposed to age and sun, and the other exposed to grueling work.

Jiu Niangzi: Stay calm. Let's go ask Lǐzhèng.

Bessmert: Wait ...

Jiu Niangzi: What's wrong?

Bessmert: I sense an arcane energy. Someone cast a skill in the yard.

Bessmert: Follow me.

Jiu Niangzi: Where are you going? You can't see! Just tell me. I'll take you there.

Bessmert: No, please follow me.

Jiu Niangzi: You're heading toward the water jar. I was here last night to get water.

Bessmert: It's somewhere close to the water jar. I sense it clearly.

Bessmert wades through the stream and stops in front of the water jar. She crouches down to find something among the scattered leaves in front of her.

Jiu Niangzi: Is this a bone?

Bessmert: That makes sense. Lǐzhèng told us that the feather man uses a bone wand. Yenisei also saw something similar in that giant bird's hand when we faced him outside the city.

Jiu Niangzi: I knew it! Now, we have the proof, we can ...

Bessmert: No, it's not enough. And Yenisei is missing.

Jiu Niangzi: Why not enough? He left his bone wand, which means he was here before. And your friend is missing! Still not enough to prove his guilt?

Bessmert: But only Yenisei knows what the giant bird looks like. She also drew the picture of that bird.

Bessmert: Without her, we cannot confirm that the feather man and the giant bird are the same creature.

Jiu Niangzi: I don't understand. You're saying that, even if we have his bone wand, we can't prove anything?

Bessmert: Exactly.

Jiu Niangzi: But, I think you're overthinking.

Bessmert raises her head slightly, conveying her confusion in unsubtle movements.

Jiu Niangzi: I-I mean, whether enough or not, it's not up to us, right?

Jiu Niangzi: I know nothing about the law. It ... it just doesn't feel right.

The girl's voice quietens down, giving rise to her own hesitation.

Jiu Niangzi: I'm just thinking ... we should do something, because you are sad.

But Bessmert already understands.

Bessmert: ...

Bessmert: You have a point. Then we ...

Jiu Niangzi: Let's go to the Zhící now! Lǐzhèng will be there today. He is supposed to tell me something about the Dùshuò Festival.

Jiu Niangzi: Let's tell him what happened today. He will know what to do!

Bessmert: Sure.

They decided to head towards the Zhící. Bessmert puts away the bone wand and follows Jiǔ Niángzǐ's footsteps carefully, one at a time.

They leave the wooden doll standing in place, a sentinel atop the rest of the debris.

6#1

Gesheng

NS-13

Zhici

Lǐzhèng is flipping through annual expense account records from previous years, worries written on his heart and wizened face.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ is sure to report for duty on time, and he must have a decision ready before she does.

Lizheng: In past years, the Festive Animals used in the Fortune Walk and the Bridge Leap were less than three.

Lizheng: "A cow, a goat, and a donkey. Without exception."

Lizheng: The poorer the harvest, the less food for the animals and less well-fed donkeys, so people had to use horses instead. However ...

Lizheng: Aren't there too many Festive Animals this time? Even if it is for celebrating the birth of Zhíxú? Not to mention some of them are transformed from humans! We shall act prudently.

Lizheng: If we have to cancel the ceremony, we must make the decision before New Year's Eve ...

He writes the words "Fortune Walk" and "Bridge Leap" into a blank space on the account records in his hand, then circles them in red ink to serve as his reminder.

As he does, he ponders and shifts his gaze nearby to the portrait of a giant bird.

Lizheng: ...

Lizheng: A giant bird ... a feather man ...

Lizheng: *sighs* There is always trouble around New Years.

Suddenly, there comes a loud fluttering of wings. This sound is not like one of common birds flapping, but is rather a droning hazardous sound the kind of a titanic bird of prey approaching.

Lizheng: Hmm?

A winged shadow covers the portrait on the desk.

Lǐzhèng turns his head to see the visitor clearly, meeting it with a look of shock and heart-shaking doubt on his face.

Lizheng: You?!

The visitor is no less than the very giant bird or feathered man depicted in that portrait.

He glides in as smoothly and naturally as if he were entering an open glade. It seems as though the guards of the Zhící were unaware of his arrival entirely.

???: You ... Are you responsible for this place?

???: It was ... someone else when I last visited.

???: *sighs*

???: No matter. I have an urgent matter to discuss, or it will be too late.

Without waiting for Lǐzhèng to react, a bizarre horse, or something like it, rushes in behind him.

The horse's mane and tail are both red, and it bears a tiger-stripe pattern along its body, the combination of which produces a truly incomparable sight.

Striped Horse?: *neighs*

It steps forward, allowing Lǐzhèng to see it clearly. It suggests a great sort of intelligence in its movements.

As for the feather man—he simply folds his wings and lands. The narrow space forces him to pinch himself tightly into the cramped room.

Lǐzhèng notices a hint of embarrassment in his visitor as a result.

Getian: I'm Gětiān, and I'm here to advise caution. The lady owner of the tavern can turn people into Lùshǔ. She needs to be stopped, or more people will suffer.

Getian: She has extremely light bones, which means she's still in the stage of development. She might be unstable, hence a danger to keep in the city.

Lizheng: You are referring to ... Jiǔ Niángzǐ?

Getian: Precisely.

Lizheng: Bones ... Are you the Goddess of Lí Mountain that can read one's bones? But you don't look like her at all ...

Getian: ...

The brief silence conveys Gětiān's astonishment at the unexpected change in topic.

Getian: I am no Goddess of Lí Mountain.

Lizheng: Then your words have no weight at all. You should have claimed to be her.

Lizheng: Besides, "Goddess of Lí Mountain," take a look around you.

Though puzzled, Gětiān looks around as advised, only to find some paper with the same bird totems painted on it. Some of the papers even bear ink stains yet to dry, indicating their recentness.

Getian: You mean ... these paper-cutouts?

Getian: A man-faced bird with a red tail. You're drawing me ...

Even though he recognizes the image in the painting, the idea of being "worshipped" through such artwork comes across as quite unnecessary.

Striped Horse?: *neighs*

Horseshoes impatiently clank on the ground, seeming to urge a sense of haste. This prompting though goes unnoticed.

Getian: But I'm not a Xiángruì. These paper-cuts won't send me your prayers and wishes.

Lizheng: They're not paper-cutouts for worshiping the Xiángruì, but wanted posters, and you are wanted.

Gětiān is stunned for a moment, as if unable to understand Lǐzhèng's words. Whether paper cuttings or wanted notices, they are complex things found only in the world of the mundane.

As such, he opts to ignore them for now and continue on with the purpose of his journey.

Getian: The most important thing is to find Jiǔ Niángzǐ. She's the culprit of the missing persons cases in the city.

Lizheng: Humph.

Lizheng: I thought you came here to confess or make peace, but it seems not.

Lizheng: You come to defame Jiǔ Niángzǐ, while being ignorant of the fact that you're the top suspect.

Upon learning that the culprit is not in fact the one he identified as Jiǔ Niángzǐ, Gětiān falls into an even deeper confusion.

Many things outside the mountains are beyond his understanding.

Getian: How am I related to this?

Lizheng: Every time a disappearance was reported, you were witnessed bringing animals to the Zhící.

Getian: No, the nature of my visit has been taken wrongly. The Zhílǐ there knew what I came for.

Lizheng: Humph. When we arrived at the Zhící, you had already fled without a trace.

Lizheng: No one could testify in front of the Fǎcáo for her, so her words were considered nonsense. Now, she has returned to her hometown.

Upon hearing this, Gětiān breathes a sigh of relief.

Getian: I wouldn't have shown up in the city if not for the urgent matters. What's the purpose of lingering around when my business is done here?

Getian: Besides, the Zhící allowed arcane skills to be cast without restrictions in the city, so it is your responsibility to bear the consequences of such negligence.

Lizheng: You're very articulate ...

Lizheng: But how can you explain the testimony provided by the two foreign merchants?

Lizheng: All roads are leading to you.

Getian: ...

Getian: Yes. The two foreigners.

Lizheng: ... Do you confess?

Getian: They are the other reason why I'm here.

Getian: One of the two is here with us. She can explain to you.

Gětiān leans over and asks the red-maned horse beside him to signal to Lǐzhèng.

Striped Horse?: *neighs*

The strange horse, after being ignored for a long time, seems to acknowledge that it can now finally make itself useful and steps forward on proud hooves.

Lizheng: Wait, you mean she is ...

Before Lǐzhèng can react, Gětiān flaps his wings, causing the tea on the table to flip onto the ground.

The red-maned horse takes another step forward and turns to the spot where the stone bricks have been wetted.

The tea seeps out over the interior stone, forming a pool in a small indentation. There the reflection of the horse appears in a flash.

Getian: I ask for your patience. Please look at the water on the floor.

Lizheng: Hmm?

Lǐzhèng looks towards the spot Gětiān's line of sight indicates, where the fading reflection remains.

But the liquid drains out along the low-lying and uneven floor, and eventually disappears into the crevices of the stone bricks.

The tea, it seems, is just tea.

Getian: ...

Lizheng: What is this for?

Lizheng: Is this a demonstration of your discontent, because I didn't treat you as a guest, offer you a seat, and give you a cup of tea?

Getian: No ...

Getian: This should not be.

He appears to murmur to himself and turns to the red-tailed horse beside him, his words muddled with confusion.

Getian: Why ... why didn't your arcane skill work this time?

Getian: Or must it be clean water to reflect it?

Getian: No. The water in the river was no cleaner. How did you do it earlier?

Having now weathered this series of absurd confrontations to his limits, the cultured manner of Lǐzhèng breaks along with his patience.

Lizheng: ...

Lizheng: Guards!

Lizheng: Catch him!

Gětiān is startled by the sudden and rapid footsteps, and immediately flies upward.

Within the narrow chamber, the shadow of his wings appears unusually large, and even the red-haired horse retreats beyond the shadow's range.

Getian: What is the meaning of this?!

Lizheng: You're a suspect. That's ...

Getian: What I know, I told you truthfully. Why are you troubling me instead of going after Jiǔ Niángzǐ?

Getian: Find some clean water. I will prove it to you ...

Lizheng: That's enough. Surrender now.

Getian: I will not fight you. But neither will you have me.

Lizheng: *sighs*

Lizheng: Be careful not to hurt that horse. It might be one of the victims.

Gětiān flaps his wings and flies out, escaping to the courtyard.

He does not leave immediately, instead deftly avoiding the attacks of the guards as he flits around the courtyard. Despite the fact that this brief conflict has already left him injured.

Lizheng: Your strength will eventually run out.

Getian: Is this necessary?

Getian: Find me the clean water, and I will show you what Jiǔ Niángzǐ has done.

Lizheng: How will I know if you're using your arcane skill to fake the result?

Lizheng: The truth is, we know the girl very well, but nothing about you.

Getian: ...

Lizheng: No one had gone missing in Pèi City before you showed up.

Lizheng: So how can we trust you or your "proof"?

Gětiān gently shakes his head and lowers his wings.

Lizheng: And you have denied that you're a Xiángruì ...

Getian: *sighs*

Getian: It is true that I am not a Xiángruì, nor have I ever visited here.

Getian: I never wanted to leave the mountain.

His movements make the wounds on his wings visible. His stance is low and reverent, suggesting his willingness to discuss a truce.

Lǐzhèng hesitates and, as a result, raises his hand to stop the storming advance of the guards.

Lizheng: But you still left.

Getian: I really shouldn't have come to the human world.

Lizheng: What do you mean?

Getian: My people have left the mountain and come to help you. They renounced their names, families, and even lives for you ...

Getian: They gave up everything so that you would have gods to worship. They became symbols, totems ... except themselves.

Lizheng: What are you talking about, feather man?

Getian: I told you my name. I'm not a "feather man."

Lizheng: ...

Getian: "This feather man is not one of us. No need to call him by name."

It isn't any sort of prescience. It's only that the answer is a simple deduction.

Lizheng: !

Getian: ... Seems like my people have been long forgotten.

Getian: You forgot the Gětiāns who left the mountain, the city-builders, the bridge-masters, the flood-fighters ... They all faded into oblivion. You only remember the Gods of Shètí, who never answered to your prayers!

Getian: That's why I'm discouraged ...

Getian: ... by the idea of leaving the mountain like my people. I don't want to face such suspicion and disbelief after giving you all the help.

Lizheng: Who-who are you?

Getian: Now that I see it, the destruction of the bridge was inevitable. It was bound to happen, like I was bound to be left in the mountain and be the last of us.

Lizheng: The bridge? Did you have something to do with the broken bridge? Feather man, tell us!

Getian: Question no more. You can have me, if that's what you want.

The message conveyed by Gětiān's words and actions forces those present to hold their breath.

He gives up his resistance and sees the connection between the broken bridge and this vague allegation.

Though the onlookers wonder whether this might be merely a stalling tactic.

Jiu Niangzi: Lǐzhèng!

The two who set off from the tavern, heading toward the Zhící, arrive in time to witness the end of the standoff.

Bessmert had been following Jiǔ Niángzǐ closely all the way, but now stops just short of the Zhící's gates.

Bessmert: Ms. Jiǔ Niángzǐ, please wait.

Even without the ability to see it, she stops to analyze the tense atmosphere ahead.

Lizheng: Come no further!

Jiu Niangzi: Huh?

Getian: ...

The gaze of almost everyone in the courtyard converges now on Gětiān, wary of any possible movement.
No one present believes that he would just surrender like this.

And in an unnoticed corner, the red-tailed horse deftly bypasses them all before running off in agitation.

Striped Horse?: *neighs*

The horse that had rushed into the crowd then just as immediately weaves back out, seeming to aim to snatch Bessmert out from behind Jiǔ Niángzǐ.

Bessmert: Ah!

And it succeeds.

6#1

The Old Days

NS-14

Jiu Niangzi: What, what just ran out of there?

Jiu Niangzi: That "thing" took away the lady. What's going on?!

Jiǔ Niángzǐ's words dissipate in the air without stirring a response. The eyes of all stare at Gětiān in the center of the courtyard. Most of these are filled with doubt, suspicion, and fear.

As the strange horse and its unwilling rider disappear in the distance, the communication arcane skill cast by the bone wand also seems to dissipate.

Lizheng: Now we lost another witness. Did you plan this?

Getian: I left my wand in her tavern yesterday. Ask her. You will know.

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, is that so?

Jiu Niangzi: We did find a bone in the yard, but it's with that foreign lady now.

Lizheng: ...

Lizheng: Tie him up first. Do you have more to say?

Getian: Everything I need to tell you, I have spoken it all. Catch her now, or even a real Xiángruì cannot save you from the disaster.

Lizheng: Why are you so obsessed with calling Jiǔ Niángzǐ the "culprit"?

Jiu Niangzi: What? You ...? I ...? I am the culprit?!

Jiu Niangzi: What kind of culprit am I?

Lizheng: It's fine, Jiǔ Niángzǐ. We all know you have nothing to do with the missing persons cases ...

Jiu Niangzi: And he said ... said that ... "Even a real Xiángruì cannot save you." He is more of a fake one to me!

Jiǔ Niángzǐ rushes angrily toward Gětiān, striding forward until she stands just before him, but in her rush of emotion, she loses her ability to speak.

Jiu Niangzi: You ...

Getian: ...

Lizheng: Stay calm. We will hold him in detention in Zhící for now. I'll report this to the Fǎcáo.

Lizheng: The first thing to do is catch up with the horse and the foreign lady ...

Lizheng: And find his wand to figure out his arcane skill.

The crowd quickly moves according to Lǐzhèng's command and exits the courtyard in an orderly fashion.

Only a few scattered guards remain in the courtyard, along with the three figures located in the center.

At this point, it would seem obvious that Gětiān must be taken away, but as Lǐzhèng has not yet ordered anything to that effect, no one dares step forward. For though subdued, his huge wings and claws still serve as effective deterrents.

Lizheng: Take him away. Everyone else dismissed.

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, follow me. There is something we need to talk about.

Jiu Niangzi: What do you want, feather man?

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ?

Jiu Niangzi: You look like a decent Xiángruì. Why did you say something like that?

Jiu Niangzi: Even-even if you're not, aren't you afraid that ... the real Xiángruì will blame you for doing the wrong thing?

The girl appears as though she has not heard Lǐzhèng's words. The doubt in her questions is conveyed in an almost whispered tone.

Gětiān doesn't even lift his head. He remains motionless, like a statue.

Getian: ...

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ. It is true that he is not the Xiángruì of our city. The Xiángruì, who once protected our city, has been long lost.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ turns her head, failing to connect the logic behind Lǐzhèng's statement.

Jiu Niangzi: BUT! But everyone thinks the feather man on the mountain is the Xiángruì! Just, just look at him! How could people not take him as a Xiángruì by his look?

Jiu Niangzi: The former Zhílǐ told me that the feather man looks like a Gōumáng, just like what was depicted in a picture book. *Gōumáng: the God of Spring in ancient Chinese mythology, in charge of agriculture, with wings and claws.*

Jiu Niangzi: A Gōumáng is a confirmed Xiángruì recorded in a book!

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ.

Jiu Niangzi: But this man? Of course, he is not a Xiángruì! He isn't like the Gōumáng nor the Mièméng ... He doesn't even understand the saying of, um, "One can remove the footsteps, but not the path one walketh on."

Lizheng: ...

Lizheng: "One can remove the footsteps, but not the path one walketh on." ... That's fair. One cannot commit wrongdoing without leaving a trace.

Lizheng: However, we can't convict him without definitive evidence, such as witnesses and his wand.

Lizheng: The trace he left is yet to be found.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ squats down in front of Gětiān in a sudden inexplicable movement. Then stares unwaveringly into his eyes as she speaks, as if she is to judge the authenticity of his words and expressions by doing so.

Jiu Niangzi: Feather man. Do you know what is a "real Xiángruì"? Do you know where it is?

Jiu Niangzi: Why did you take people's friends away and accuse me of being the culprit?

But Gětiān seems to have made up his mind to remain silent. He lowers his head, taking a feigned interest in observing the blood dripping from his wounds. An act of passive resistance.

Getian: ...

A drop of blood seeps into his feathers, the moment passes long enough for the girl to organize her words and continue her barrage of questions.

Jiu Niangzi: You, um, your appearance is given by heaven. So you should not act against the nature of your look just because of your personal preference.

Jiu Niangzi: You could have become a much-loved spirit, like in the stories and picture books ... as everyone expects you to be.

Jiu Niangzi: But you ... when you took away that foreign lady's teammates, you didn't care about their feelings. They didn't want to be separated.

Jiu Niangzi: You disappointed people. That's not what a Xiángruì should do.

Lizheng: Alright, Jiǔ Niángzǐ. That's enough.

Lizheng: Take him away.

Jiu Niangzi: I ...

Jiǔ Niángzǐ watches coldly as Gětiān is taken away.

Jiu Niangzi: He didn't tell me anything. Nor did he tell anyone.

Lizheng: I know you're chasing after anything that could be a Xiángruì, but the feather man has clearly claimed that he is not one.

Lizheng: To be honest, judging from his attitude, he has never had the intention to be one.

Jiu Niangzi: I don't understand ... How could he not want to be one?

Lizheng: Not everyone is so interested in the legend of Xiángruì.

Lizheng: The Pèi City did have a good era under the protection of the Xiángruìs. But after all these years, no one can recall that time without the help of mythologies and history books. Even I can't be sure if there is a real Xiángruì.

Lizheng: But, Jiǔ Niángzǐ, you should know that we don't need a Xiángruì anymore.

Jiu Niangzi: We don't need it?

Lizheng: With no Xiángruì, no Divination, we cannot arrive at the Yuān Temple, but this is still an orderly city.

Lizheng: The Dùshuò Festival is as vibrant as ever. You can tell that a Xiángruì is not necessary for a city to prosper.

Jiu Niangzi: Is that so ...

Jiǔ Niángzǐ grasps the small bag she carries with her. The bag is embroidered with a peculiar combination of love poems. Though, she has never really understood the meaning of the words, in some way, they now mirror her own confused mind.

Lizheng: By the way, turns out you can read, can't you?

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm? You know that I can't, Lǐzhèng.

Lizheng: "One can remove the footsteps, but not the path one walketh on."

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, that's not what it seems to be. I heard it from the Daoist countless times, so I remembered it.

Lizheng: Which Daoist? In the city?

Jiǔ Niángzǐ shakes her head to refute Lǐzhèng's assumptions.

Jiu Niangzi: No. It was a Daoist I traveled with before I came to Pèi City. The Daoist said many different things over and over again. I couldn't understand, but I remembered them.

Lizheng: Sounds like you had a distinguished teacher. Since you came here, you've been treating people nice and kindly, exactly the opposite of what Gětiān has done.

Jiu Niangzi: Ah, so his name is Gětiān.

Lizheng: Yes, Gětiān ... You said too many things to him.

Lizheng: He is not the Xiángruì you're looking for.

Lizheng: A real Xiángruì would never be so rude. It is very possible that he is only a ... Yāo that has been living on the mountain for too long.

Her head lowers, seeming to find it difficult to accept such a change in thought.

Jiu Niangzi: But why did he accuse me like that? I-I don't get it. Did I do something wrong?

Lizheng: Because you're the Zhílǐ.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ looks at Lǐzhèng, her face caught between doubt and curiosity.

Having presented his point of view, the old man rubs his beard and laughs, knowingly helpless to influence the girl's reaction.

Lizheng: The former Zhílǐ left because of what he said and did. Now he wants to play the same trick on you.

Lizheng: What's more, when he got here and saw me but not you, he acted quite surprised. You can tell from the details.

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm ...

The thoughts behind her eyes grow more muddled, such deceitful scheming felt too complicated for her to comprehend.

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, and that captured foreign lady, she ...

Lizheng: Don't worry. There are people searching for them now. As for us, we should confirm the details for tomorrow's Fortune Walk and Bridge Leap.

Jiu Niangzi: Right, Bridge Leap, I almost forgot ... If only the broken bridge could be fixed, and we wouldn't need those Festive Animals, nor to jump over the bridge ...

Jiu Niangzi: During Gětiān's silence, I was thinking that ...

Jiu Niangzi: What if I can go to the Yuān Temple and ask Zhíxú the Guardian?

Jiu Niangzi: If the legend of The Divination is real, then whatever the question is, Zhíxú will answer me, right?

Lizheng: I guess so.

The two of them walk indoors, their conversation disappearing from the courtyard under the sound of footsteps on hard stone.

Government Office

Within the pristine government office, two figures exchange information from their past few days so they might agree on their next step course of action.

Lizheng: That is the whole story. Gětiān is now detained in Zhící's dungeon. Jiǔ Niángzǐ is there as well.

Lizheng: Four hours ago, after discussing with the new Zhílǐ, we decided to keep the ceremonies of Fortune Walk and Bridge Leap.

Lizheng: But no colored animals are used this time. The number of animals will be less than those in previous years of Zhíxú.

Lizheng: Here is the list of ceremony members and funds. I've asked people to deliver the copies to all the streets.

Lǐzhèng picks up a stack of papers from the desk and hands them out dutifully.

???: Thank you, Sir.

Lizheng: This is my duty. As for Gětiān, we shall put him on hold untill after the Dùshuò Festival according to the law.

???: One more thing. Have we found the horse and the proof?

Lizheng: Not yet. The horse taking that foreign lady away might still be under the control of Gětiān. There was no trace of them when our people chased them out of the city.

???: I understand, given the road conditions in the morning rain. Looks like we will have to continue with the search after it stops.

???: But I don't think a horse carrying a blind woman can go far enough to escape. I'll lead the search squad myself next time.

Lizheng: Thank you, Fǎcáo.

The imposing figure, with his back to the entryway, habitually presses down on the short sword at his waist, adjusting the position of the blade. Then waves his hand again to show that he doesn't need to concern himself with such matters.

Facao: I'm only doing my job. Where is the Zhílǐ?

Lizheng: Are you referring to Jiǔ Niángzǐ, or the former one?

Facao: The one who went back to her hometown.

Lizheng: We haven't heard anything from her yet. Perhaps it will come after the Dùshuò Festival.

Facao: Noted. Jiǔ Niángzǐ is still green, so please help me take care of the Zhící before the former one comes back.

Lizheng: I will. She is kind-hearted. That's why I recommended her for this position. It will be my responsibility if she makes any mistakes.

Facao: Well, there are so many things to do before the New Year. It's fine, even if she makes a mistake or two. Don't push her too hard.

Lizheng: That's what I thought. If you find any evidence or the two foreigners, please let me know.

Fǎcáo rises nimbly while folding the documents, as he prepares to bid his farewell, he is stopped by Lǐzhèng's raised hand.

Lizheng: Oh, another thing, the New Year's Feast tonight. You're welcome to Jiǔ Niángzǐ's tavern with your relatives.

Facao: The tavern? Are the people around the merchants hub going too?

Lizheng: Yes. She is hosting a feast for the neighbors.

Lizheng: It is the New Year's Eve Vigil, followed by the first day of Dùshuò Festival.

Lizheng: It is an annual tradition at the tavern.

Facao: Shuòrì, the New Year ...

Lizheng: Right, another year of the Zhíxú ...

Lizheng: Hopefully, the Yuān Temple, which worships the Zhíxú, will bring us good news.

Having said his piece, leaving only a moment of silence. The two of them look out the window, toward the eaves of the broken bridge and the temple flickering in the misty rain.

6#1

Hollow Eyed

NS-15

The striped horse with its red mane charges through the pouring rain, carrying Bessmert.

All the way, it runs with wild abandon, as if afraid of possible pursuers behind them, and perhaps to prevent the person on its back from jumping off should it slow down.

Bessmert: Halt ... Halt!

Bessmert: Do you hear me?

The horse runs onward still, even striding several shallow depressions with ease before continuing forward.

Seeing her words taking little effect, Bessmert attempts to slow it down using her prior experience with horses.

Bessmert: *deep breaths*

As she releases her breath, she lets go of the mane and replaces one hand in front of the creature's neck, while the other hand caresses the fur on both sides, adjusting to match the rhythm of its gallop.

Bessmert: Easy ... easy now ...

Bessmert: Good child ...

Bessmert: *deep breaths*

After taking another deep breath, she seizes the opportunity to vault herself off the horse and tumble down in a quick movement.

Bessmert falls into the shallows, just as she intended.

Bessmert: Ugh!

Striped Horse?: *neighs*

Bessmert: Hiss ...

Striped Horse?: *neighs*

The horse stops not far from where she lands and turns back.

Ignoring the accumulated pain of new and old injuries, Bessmert clambers out of the water, but her hands sink into the soft mud along the shallow shore.

Though not as sticky as the swamp, for a while, she finds it impossible to stand.

Striped Horse?: Madam!

Bessmert: What ...

Bessmert: Is it you, Yenisei?

Bessmert: Where are you?

The familiar voice is certainly within earshot, but Bessmert cannot place its direction, no matter how hard she strains.

She struggles to lift herself out of the mud and falls again.

Yenisei: I'm sorry. Are you hurt?

Yenisei: I was so anxious. We must not let them catch us ...

Bessmert: I'm alright. I'm good ... How did you ...

Yenisei: I am talking to you through the water. Please hurry up and get back on me!

Bessmert: You've turned into a striped horse, too?!

Bessmert: Or, is this your arcane skill? ...

Yenisei: I am not a striped horse, Madam. I'm a Lùshǔ! Both of them are arcane creatures, but not the same kind ... And yes, that's my arcane skill.

Yenisei: I can show images and diffuse sounds through water. I cast it once when we passed by the swamp in Tula, remember?

Bessmert: What about the "Lùshǔ"? What are they? Did Gětiān take you away and turn you into this?

That strange term she heard before all this began suddenly reappears in her mind. Bessmert quickly associates it with her current situation.

Yenisei: The rain is making too much noise. I can't hear you or the surroundings ...

Yenisei: Get on my back! I'm not sure how far they are from us.

Bessmert: ...

Bessmert: I don't hear any footsteps from grown men. Come here, child. Help me up.

Yenisei then steps closer and scoops Bessmert out of the sinking shallows.

Bessmert: Thank you. So ... What happened? The situation is getting trickier and trickier.

Yenisei: We made a mistake. Gětiān didn't turn me into a horse. On the contrary, he saved my life.

Bessmert: Then who was it? Who did this to you?

Yenisei: You didn't drink any water last night, did you? But I did, quite a lot. After you went into the room, Jiǔ Niángzǐ and I had a chat downstairs, and she gave me the water.

Yenisei: This is the difference. Gětiān said her arcane skill was cast through liquids like water and liquor.

Bessmert: My poor child ...

Yenisei: I went upstairs after the chat. You must have been too tired to notice me at the time. I stayed in the room but couldn't sleep at all, so I went downstairs again.

Yenisei: That was when I heard someone singing.

Yenisei: That song ... I'd never heard it before, and I had no idea what the lyrics were about. All I remember is that the melody was soft and a bit unusual ...

Yenisei: Then I found that "someone" was a group of wooden dolls. They were small and would melt when they touched liquor.

Yenisei extracts the frightening journey from her mind, trying as best she can to narrate it back in a calm tone.

Yenisei: And there were horses in the yard, also humming the melody. They had red manes and red tails, just like what I look like now.

Yenisei: I didn't know they were Lùshǔs until now. Their stripes glowed under the moon.

Bessmert: But didn't you have a closer look at the Lùshǔ last night?

Yenisei: I had no time to see it clearly, to be honest. Anyway, that chat I had with Jiǔ Niángzǐ was ... quite good. Everything felt so comforting at the time, so I don't understand ...

Bessmert: Then, why are you different from the animals turned from Mr. Jurien and the others? You told me they only have stripes on them, right?

Yenisei: Yes. I have an assumption about that, but I can't verify it now.

Bessmert: What is it?

Yenisei falls into silent reflection for a moment before answering Bessmert.

Yenisei: Remember the river our team found? Perhaps that was the lower course of the main river, and it included Jiǔ Niángzǐ's arcane power because the stream across her yard is near one of its branches. The running water might have diluted the arcane power in there.

Yenisei: Usually, a stream of running water is like an independent settlement. It rejects outsiders by nature. Even I have been rejected more than once.

Yenisei: The striped horses our teammates turned into could be an accident caused by an incomplete arcane skill.

Bessmert: Those other striped horses in the Zhící, are they too ...

Yenisei: Perhaps Jiǔ Niángzǐ had no idea at all that she somehow leaked her arcane skill into the river.

Yenisei: As for the water I had, she must have made it on purpose ...

Both of them sink into a silence made awkward by the revelation.

Bessmert: *sighs* Then, how did Gětiān get involved in all this?

Yenisei: Last night, after he saved me from the wooden dolls ...

The topic of their recollections, only just resumed, is again interrupted, this time by the sudden stopping of the rain. Yenisei looks up as if to confirm it has really ended.

If the rain has stopped for good, this also means they'll need to keep moving to avoid being found.

Yenisei: The rain has stopped.

Yenisei: We need to find shelter, Madam.

Bessmert: No, child. I don't see why he had to take you away. What if I was there with you?

Yenisei: All I know is, he was there to take us out of the danger.

Yenisei: And he's injured now. When we confronted the people at the Zhící, he didn't fight back at all. I think he didn't hurt them for a reason.

Yenisei: If he really meant to help us, we must go save him.

Bessmert: ... Child.

Bessmert: All of a sudden, you seem to trust this creature entirely. Did he do anything else for you?

Bessmert: Based on what we know, Gětiān, Lǐzhèng, and Jiǔ Niángzǐ ... they all seem strange.

Yenisei: Please trust me, Madam. I used to think this way, too. "Maybe he's fooling us with a fake rescue."

Yenisei: But he's not. He even showed me his arcane skill to win my trust. Yes, he read my bones.

Bessmert: ...!

Yenisei: Can you imagine that? He gained information by reading my bones, and then he actually told me something I didn't even know about myself.

6#1

See What I See

NS-16

Yenisei: Let me go! Where are you taking me?!

Yenisei: You ...

???: If I let go, you will fall, and death will be your end.

???: Hold your life dear. You are a lot more vulnerable than you can imagine.

Yenisei: Quit threatening me. It's a river down there.

???: Yes. But you don't know how shallow it is. Even a lantern can't float on it!

???: It's dying, unlike the other branches you saw outside the city.

Yenisei: So what? Does that explain why you captured me?

Yenisei: Fine. The river is dying; I'm held by a bird man in mid-air; I'll fall and die if I struggle. There's nothing I can do.

???: ...

???: Yes. It's a rare wisdom for a girl of your age to know her limits.

Yenisei: ...

???: But I am not a bird man. I'm a Yāo.

???: My name is Gětiān.

Yenisei gives up on her midair struggle, pondering over his name and identity.

Yenisei: You can use arcane skills. You're an arcanist.

Getian: If you say so, then it is so.

Getian: We have gone for miles. I will leave you here. Beyond the ford, you will see the steppe.

Gětiān slows down, just as he said he would, and after a moment, he gently places Yenisei on the ground.

Given her situation, she had not anticipated such gentle treatment.

Yenisei: I don't understand. What on earth is your purpose?

Yenisei: Why did you turn humans into horses? I believe you can commit much worse crimes if you want to.

Yenisei: Are you doing it for fun?

Gětiān stops to the side of a curved tree growing like a bridge over the vines of a shallow stream, face heavy with a look of contemplation.

Getian: The more you ask, the more mistakes you make.

Yenisei: There's no such thing as a wrong question.

Getian: I will answer one of the questions, regarding ... why I turned people into horses.

Getian: The answer is, I didn't do it. Neither did I have that intention.

Yenisei: Hah, interesting. Who did it then?

Getian: The lady owner of the tavern.

Yenisei: Jiǔ Niángzǐ?

Getian: Precisely.

Yenisei shakes her head, not believing his words.

Yenisei: If that's the case, why did you leave Madam Bessmert there alone? Do you really think I would buy your nonsense after I saw you take my teammates away?

Getian: You saw the "horse" in the yard, with the red tail and the red mane. Did you not?

Yenisei: Yes, I saw ...

Getian: It's not a "horse." It's a Lùshǔ, or at least, it looks like one.

Yenisei: Lùshǔ ... I have never heard of it before. It sounds like an arcane creature native to the East.

Gětiān doesn't respond. He only continues to contribute yet more astonishing information.

Getian: It is a Lùshǔ, and also Jiǔ Niángzǐ herself.

Yenisei: What? That thing is Jiǔ Niángzǐ?!

Getian: What you saw tonight was not real Lùshǔ. Those "horses" merely resembled half of them.

Getian: I speak of the fact that Jiǔ Niángzǐ might be a Lùshǔ, a kind of Yāo, or, as you would put it, an arcane creature.

Yenisei: *sighs* Your words sound even more complicated than those in the city.

Yenisei: Is it because you are also an arcane creature like the Lùshǔ? Or, you have a thing only the pure-blooded can understand?

Getian: We are nothing alike. Lùshǔs are Xiángruìs, born with red manes and white faces, covered with tiger's markings.

Getian: In the books, Lùshǔs are capable of casting an arcane skill named The Shape of Will. It could be the same skill that Jiǔ Niángzǐ uses to turn others into Lùshǔs.

Getian: Do you understand?

Yenisei: Yes ... I'll try.

Getian: The Shape of Will is a dangerous and secret skill, as written in the books. The Lùshǔs use it to transform blood into fire and stone into gold.

Yenisei: So ... it's like alchemy?

Getian: I'm unfamiliar with what you said, but ...

Getian: Jiǔ Niángzǐ's power seems to be restricted. She cannot fully transform into a Lùshǔ like a Yāo could, nor does she possess great power. She's closer to a Half Yāo.

Getian: Unlike other Lùshǔs, she requires a certain medium to cast her skill, The Shape of Will. This is also why people did not recognize her. She's harder to identify.

Yenisei: Jiǔ Niángzǐ ... "Half Yāo" ... Is that another name for the mixed-blood?

Yenisei: Anyway, even if you're telling the truth, how did you know that?

Getian: It is within my bloodline. Like you find your direction through the water, I read people through their bones.

Yenisei: ...! How did you know my ...

Yenisei: Wait, you mean you can read people through their bones? That makes no sense. What can one's physical condition tell you?

Getian: Many. Many stories, many sounds. Even if I was never there with them.

Getian: Such as you. The markings on your bones resemble an open net, yet it captures nothing. You are away from the waterless land where you once lived, and to this day you're still wandering.

Yenisei: What ...

The girl's eyes widen with astonished disbelief.

Getian: You will travel far many times in life and turn homeward, like the migratory birds.

Getian: Until you find your lake.

Yenisei: What on earth are you talking about ...

Getian: Have I mistaken anything? I should hope not.

Getian: Forgive me. I have long since stopped reading others' bones and put them into words.

Getian: Perhaps I did not tell it in the most precise way, but it should be generally accurate.

Yenisei: Alright, stop.

Getian: Hmm?

Yenisei: I need ...

Yenisei: I need some time to digest your words ...

A bizarre spectral sound cuts off Yenisei's reply.

Getian: Careful!

Strange creatures that resemble balls dragging long tails suddenly leap out from the trees behind the two of them.

They shriek and charge towards Yenisei, who is most evidently their target.

Zhuye the Monster: Squeak!

Zhuye the Monster: Squeak! Squeak! Squeak!

Yenisei: Ugh!

Yenisei: These things again ... They already attacked me once in the street!

Zhuye the Monster: Squeak!!

Yenisei: *sighs* These stupid birds!

Following closely behind is a mysterious creature markedly different from the other feathered balls.

Yenisei: This one is shining bright! Get out of my way, out!

It is indeed exceptionally bright and long, illuminating the shallow stream in front of them on both sides.

Gětiān stares in the direction the scattered Zhúyè ran off, his mind burdened with thought.

Getian: Have you drunk the liquor ... offered by Jiǔ Niángzǐ?

Yenisei: No, but I had the water from her. Why?

Getian: These Zhúyè might be attracted here by the scent of liquor. They feed on the flowers of Zhúyè, which can be used to make liquor and smell of lees.

Getian: They could be here because they smelt the liquor. But you only had the water. What else could attract them?

Yenisei thinks back to the preceding events.

Yenisei: If they were attracted by the scent of liquor, I think it was the wooden dolls' fault. They soaked themselves in the liquor before they attacked me. I might have gotten their scent during the battle.

Getian: The scent of liquor stains is not strong enough to attract them here. It would have taken a proper consumption of liquor for them to notice.

Getian: I worry that liquor is the medium for her transformation skill, but that is only my speculation. If the water you drank also exerts the same effect on you ...

As though his words hold the power of execution, the change happens the very moment he speaks.

Yenisei: Emm ...

Getian: What? You ...

Yenisei kneels down and her body transforms, just as her companions transformed on the steppes before her.

Getian: How so ...!

Although Gětiān had already anticipated this moment, he cannot help but be startled by this strange process and flaps his wings involuntarily.

His instincts tell him to flee.

Night falls. The rain has stopped, and the riverbank is moist and soft.

Făcáo leads his team in search of the red-haired horse's trail, finally arriving at the edge of the river.

The exact spot where Gětiān and Yenisei stayed the night before.

Guard: ...

Facao: Find anything?

Guard: Someone was here. Seems like a horse, with a female, tall and thin.

Facao: Not a horse, but a foal. Look carefully. The footsteps are smaller and shallower than a horse's.

Facao: Where are the ends of the tracks?

Guard: The river beach ahead. The tracks stopped three meters away. We couldn't tell where they went.

Facao: That can't be.

Fǎcáo strides over to inspect the traces near where the trail of footprints ends.

Guard: It rained a couple of times. The rain could have washed away the footprints.

Facao: If that's the case, there shouldn't be other tracks here.

Facao: Like this. A bird's claw marks at the edge of the rotten wood.

Facao: It was a bird of prey. And judging from the size and the sharpness, it's quite strong.

Guard: It's true ...

Guard: Hey, I found another two sets of footprints!

Guard: They are shallow and narrow, possibly from the same person, a young woman.

Facao: The wood lies on the ground near the river. It's not a good spot for birds of prey to roost on.

Facao: What stopped here was something even bigger.

Facao: A young woman met a huge bird of prey here, yet there is no bloodstain at all.

Facao: Perhaps the truth behind the foreign merchant's disappearance is different from the feather man's statement.

Facao: We need to go back to the Zhící.

On the steppes, a Lùshǔ stands in place of a girl. The fright of this transformation sends Gětiān up into the air.

Lushu: *neighs*

Getian: Too late.

Getian: So it seems her tea can also transform people. I must report this to the authorities.

Getian: Stay here.

Yenisei: No, no. You must not leave!

Getian: You ... can speak through the water?

Yenisei: You know what my arcane skill can do! But I can't maintain it for long. I spent too much energy fighting the Zhúyès ...

Getian: I must take leave.

Yenisei: Where are you going? You need to save Madam Bessmert!

Yenisei: Please, please, I'm begging you! Please save her. She can't see, and she's still alone in the tavern. She must be in great danger now ...

Getian: I have thought about it, given that my wand was also left in that tavern. But should I return, Jiǔ Niángzǐ might be alerted.

Getian: I sense kindness in that girl. She hasn't done anything evil except for turning people into Lùshǔs. Your friend should be safe with her for the moment.

Getian: The more urgent matter is to spread the word before she further repeats her mistake.

Getian: I must go find someone to handle this properly.

Yenisei: Please take me with you.

Yenisei: They believe you are the one behind the missing persons cases now. You'll be turning yourself in if you go alone.

Gětiān is startled, having never thought such an outcome might occur.

Getian: I see. The world outside the mountains is indeed not meant for me to step into.

Yenisei: But you are already involved. Besides, we gave Lǐzhèng a drawing of you when I was not clear of the truth ...

Getian: No matter. I will reason with him.

Yenisei: Even so, you will need me there. Look at my arcane skill. It will be the best proof, right?

Yenisei: So they will know that Jiǔ Niángzǐ is the real culprit who turned the people into horses, I mean, "Lùshǔs."

Getian: Is that really needed?

Yenisei: You need to know that you are a suspect! Even though I know you are innocent, you need something absolutely persuasive to prove it.

Yenisei: All in all, you must take me with you. My arcane skill will vindicate you.

6#1

Jade or Stone

NS-17

Street, Inside the City - Night

Only vagrants and outsiders wander the streets on the eve of the Dùshuò Festival.

In front of each threshold, sparking fires burn below colorful decorations laid out in the dark night, peering out at each other from across sandy gravel roads that have not yet dried from the rain.

Bessmert and Yenisei continue their advance toward the Zhící in the quiet, gentle light.

Bessmert: This place ...

Bessmert: ... looks so different than it does in the daytime. It's so quiet and empty.

Bessmert: As if it's waiting for us.

Yenisei stops to cast her reflection into a puddle of water, attempting to comfort Bessmert.

Yenisei: It's nighttime now. They have lit the braziers. There is cloth of different colors around them.

Yenisei: Remember our New Years? We put up tar barrels and made festive fires. There were also decorations on the houses.

Bessmert: Yes, I remember that.

Bessmert: Perhaps people here also stay with their families at this time of year, like we do on New Year's Eve.

Bessmert: A heartwarming custom.

Yenisei: Yeah ...

Bessmert: Shush, quiet.

Bessmert stops to listen carefully to the sound. A moment later, a line of night patrolmen pass by from the corner ahead.

They march at ease without stopping, clearly ready for their shift change and the chance to get home.

It isn't until they disappear completely that Yenisei's figure reappears in the puddle.

Yenisei: The guards here are more reliable than ours in the empire. At least they don't get drunk on New Year's Eve.

Yenisei: Madam, we are close to the Zhící.

Bessmert: We didn't prepare anything other than these bottles. Don't cast any skills for now. You need to rest. We don't know what's ahead of us ...

Bessmert: Hold on. I heard something.

Unlike the neat footsteps of the previous patrol, the distant sound they hear this time is of slower and wearier footsteps.

The woman and the Lùshǔ hurriedly dart into the shadow of the nearby eaves.

Bessmert: Staggering footsteps, almost limping. Sounds like this person just tripped and fell, or drunk.

Yenisei follows the sound described by Bessmert and looks around.

Yenisei: Jiǔ Niángzǐ? What is she doing here?

Not far from them, Jiǔ Niángzǐ hobbles along. She takes one step, then pauses, two steps, then pauses, and finally stops as she prepares to turn down a narrow alley.

She looks completely broken down, as though she has just been in a fight, or perhaps she's just drunk.

Jiu Niangzi: Why ...

They can hear her talking to herself in the darkness, her voice echoing intermittently against the silently festive street.

Jiu Niangzi: Why ... no answers for me ...

Jiu Niangzi: How long do I have to wait ... before I ...

Yenisei: What is she saying? I don't understand at all. Madam, what about you ...

Bessmert: Shh.

Jiu Niangzi: *sobbing*

They cannot see whether she's crying or not, but there is a soft sobbing that comes out like a whisper.

Even so, she clenches her fists, as if tightly gripping something.

Jiu Niangzi: Is this ...

Jiu Niangzi: ... a mistake?

Jiu Niangzi: ...

Amid her silent sobbing, Jiǔ Niángzǐ relaxes her hand. A long object falls from it and into a puddle on the ground.

Yenisei: Oh ... She dropped something and left.

Bessmert: Where did she go?

Yenisei: I don't know if she's going to the tavern, but she has left the port. That's for sure. We should go find out what she dropped.

Yenisei's figure disappears from the puddle. She takes two steps, turns around and bites on Bessmert's hem, half dragging, half guiding her toward the corner of the alley's entrance, where the light and darkness intersect.

Approaching the water, she finally lets go of Bessmert and goes around to the other side. Yenisei then lowers her head as though to drink from the puddle, and deftly removes a piece of wood from it.

She shakes the water off the wooden slab and leans toward Bessmert's hand until her friend can grasp it.

Bessmert: It is ... a wooden chip. Rough surface, and some carvings on it. Is this an inscribed text?

Yenisei: Maybe. Please hold it. I'll check the other side.

Yenisei: Starting from the round end, there is a ... mmm ... a person, I guess, at the top; then there is another person holding a bowl in the middle ...

Yenisei: Hmm ...

Bessmert: A person holding a bowl in the middle, and ... and then?

Yenisei: Then there is a striped ... horse? At the bottom?

Yenisei: What does it mean?

Bessmert: A striped horse ...

Bessmert: Gětiān once said that a Lùshǔ has a red mane and the markings of a tiger.

Yenisei: You mean this is a Lùshǔ? But it has no colors.

Yenisei: Even if it is a Lùshǔ, why was she crying?

Yenisei: From my perspective, Jiǔ Niángzǐ is not a bad person. I think she did all these things for a reason—some kind of burden only known to herself.

Bessmert: Burden?

Yenisei: I'm only guessing. Since we didn't catch her words clearly, there is no conclusion, Madam.

That being said, the two of them fall into a shared silence. Since entering the city, the dark cloud of their uncertain future has followed them like a shadow.

Bessmert: Well, there's no easy answer to any question here. We should meet with Mr. Gětiān before making any further arrangements.

Yenisei: Sure.

The woman and the Lùshǔ walk forward at pace.

The two increase their speed, arriving outside the gray walls of the Zhící courtyard before they might be discovered by another team of night patrollers.

The streets in this area are built with high walls surrounding their homes on all sides, so that people walking by can see nothing but stacked bricks.

Bessmert: Stop here. I hear ...

It is at this moment that Gětiān flies over the Zhící courtyard's walls.

His wings flutter lighter—lighter than the previous few times, and he has no intention of stopping until he notices the figure at the foot of the wall.

Bessmert: ...!

Bessmert: Mr. Gětiān?

Or perhaps, he had no intention of staying until he heard Bessmert's voice.

Getian: It's you?

Gětiān perches on a tree by the roadside, tightly clutching branches bearing leaves that have only just begun to wither. The tree's shadow sways. But he goes silent, only stopping as he recognizes the two figures below.

The ground nearby is flat and long dried. Without a puddle, Yenisei can only grab hold of Bessmert's hem and tug on it lightly to confirm her guess.

Bessmert, though, quickly understands. She listens to the sound and walks forward and to one side, eagerly reaching around beneath the tree.

Bessmert: Mr. Gětiān ...

Getian: Why are you here?

Bessmert: Did they let you go? Have you seen Jiǔ Niángzǐ? She was on the street just now ...

Getian: Whatever speculation you are making, I am leaving.

Bessmert: Leaving? Are you going after her?

Getian: No. I was not meant to be here in the first place. It's only natural that I should return to the mountain.

Bessmert: Return? But we're not done with Jiǔ Niángzǐ yet. Yenisei and the others are still in the shape of Lùshǔ ...

Bessmert: She was turned into a Lùshǔ in front of you. Are you going to just let her be?

Getian: She has told you everything.

Bessmert: Yes, she did! Now you're the only one who can persuade others to go after Jiǔ Niángzǐ ... We are foreigners here. People won't listen to us.

Getian: I am left with no other options. Today, at the Zhící, none of us would have gotten away if I hadn't surrendered.

This is a fact that, as an observer of the entire scene, Yenisei cannot deny.

Getian: They will only see me as a greater threat if I insist on raising doubts about her.

Getian: They have known her for a long time but know nothing about me. My words have no greater effect than yours, for I'm also ...

Getian: A foreigner here.

His voice is light, but as gloomy as the night.

Bessmert: Still, you're going to just give it all up before exhausting every possible way to end this?

A wave of swaying tree shadows causes Gětiān to fly up on alert. He seems to have finally made up his mind to leave.

Getian: You need not prick my pride. Gětiāns and Mièmèngs are never meant to get involved in this.

Before a response is issued, the sound of rhythmic footsteps sounds, one after another.

Whether it is the patrol or some other city personnel, it is enough to immediately alert the vigilant trio.

Yenisei: ...!

Gětiān though, does not leave. His actions are seemingly not in line with his tongue.

Getian: There are people coming. You ...

???: I knew it.

A bold and imposing voice sounds out from the spot the footsteps had been moving toward.

Facao: You two are in it together. The merchant identity was only an excuse you made up to enter the city.

Facao: Isn't that so?

Bessmert: No, please listen to me ...

Facao: The stories you told Lǐzhèng made no sense at all. How dare you come back like you did nothing and break into the jail?!

Getian: You go first.

Bessmert: Mr. Gětiān!

Bessmert intuits that she shouldn't just run away. At that moment, the only one who can help her confirm her assumption is Gětiān.

The one being sought for help does not make a sound. He dives from the tree, spreading his wings to cast an immense shadow over the scene.

He flies between the patrol and Bessmert, turning his back to them, then spreads his wings even wider until they completely block the view of those behind him.

At this moment, he truly seems like a bird of prey.

Getian: Lùshǔs are fleet-footed creatures. Get on her back and leave. I will join you shortly.

Getian: Go!

Facao: Don't you run! Catch them!

Thanks to Gětiān's cover, the two successfully run from the neighborhood and arrive at the shallow shore on the city outskirts, where Yenisei has now stopped twice before.

At this moment, the night seems to have become even darker, without a single star to light the sky, and only faint moonlight trails scattered across the riverbank.

Yenisei: It's been quite a while. Is he ...

Yenisei cannot help but think of Gětiān's experience at the Zhící that same morning.

Bessmert: Have faith in him, child. He is able to defend himself, since he managed to escape without others' help.

Bessmert: I believe ...

Bessmert: I believe he is not aggressive. He left his wand behind when he tried to save you.

A long period of waiting, pregnant with anxiety, is finally broken by the sound of flapping wings.

Bessmert: ...!

Yenisei: Madam!

Gětiān crosses over them and stops along the twisted vines, folding his wings and tightly gripping the edges of the tree with his talons.

The garment on his head must have split during his fight, and now fully reveals his previously covered expression, one both baffled and tense.

Bessmert: You're here!

Bessmert: You seem fine. Do you still intend to leave? Or, have you changed your mind?

Bessmert follows the sound of movement, turning her head toward where Gětiān landed.

Getian: No. I'm here for one last thing.

Getian: When I was imprisoned in Zhící, I heard that Jiǔ Niángzǐ would hold a banquet at the tavern tonight, and the Fǎcáo was also invited.

Getian: I'll take the opportunity and get those half Lùshǔs out of there.

Bessmert: Please wait a second, Sir.

Getian: Yes?

Bessmert: We're not going anywhere. We must release them from the arcane skill and bring them back.

Getian: If you don't flee tonight, I'm afraid there will be no better chance for you to leave.

Getian: Though her true intention is beyond my speculation, I fear the consequences of her action will be severe.

Bessmert: You know full well the consequences.

Getian: Mm? Certainly.

Bessmert: But you won't help us stop her.

Getian: That is not my problem to address. I have done my part.

Bessmert: Then why did you help us get rid of the soldiers and offer to help again?

This question surprises Gětiān. He had never thought about it until that moment. He lifts his wings, forming a posture similar to cupping his face, sinking into contemplation.

After a moment, he conjures up an explanation.

Getian: It doesn't suggest my further involvement in this matter.

Bessmert: You are contradicting your own words, Sir.

Gětiān lowers his head and looks towards the drying earth near the embankment out across the river's calm surface.

Getian: Very well. I will put it differently. Look at the street. It is empty tonight.

Getian: There was a time when people sent lanterns down the river on New Year's Eve. Even the simplest lantern would glow like the moon on the water.

Getian: Those lanterns, carrying people's wishes, floated down the river. The further they went, the more wishes were granted.

Getian: Some would cast arcane skills on their lanterns to keep them from getting wet. But most of the lanterns still disappeared in the depths of the mountains or at the waterfalls.

Getian: I used to look down at the city from the mountain top, watching those lanterns float down the streams and merge into a light belt in the dark.

Getian: They were more brilliant and vibrant than the bonfires that were lit up all night in this city.

Bessmert: ...

The Lùshǔ follows Gětiān's gaze and looks towards the river, only to see the bare and narrowing "river" looking more and more like a stream in her eyes.

This sad reality of the present makes it difficult to imagine the scene described in Gětiān's words, despite the nostalgia overflowing from his tone.

Bessmert feels it too, but the safety of her companions remains a constant concern in her mind.

Bessmert: I'm sorry. I don't understand what you mean. Time is against us ...

Getian: Now, the river has dried up, and the water no longer has vitality. Rainfall is getting scarce, accelerating the dying process.

Getian: What was given does not compensate for what was lost. So, people no longer show up by the river and send their wishes at night.

Getian: And I have lost my opportunity to watch the light belt.

Getian: Even so, to this day, I haven't fully understood why I was impelled to leave the mountain. I once thought I couldn't bear the sight of those humans being turned into other creatures.

Bessmert: And now you think it's no longer worth the effort to put things back in order?

Getian: Yes. You people are no more than passengers in my life, drifting past me like those lanterns in the river.

Getian: What's more, what is my purpose here if the Gods of Shètí they serve don't intend to intervene?

Gětiān's words are so full of perplexity that they are almost painful. He poses questions like cutting meat to feed a tiger, knowing that there will be no reward after throwing them out, but still he insists.

Yenisei, who has been silent on one side for a long time, seems to understand his feelings. And so she continues to remain silent, only looking at the pitch-black surface of the river.

The river too looks back with its own quieting babble.

Getian: The lights in the river are gone, and there will be no more in the future.

Yenisei gazes at her reflection of Lùshǔ.

It isn't until Gětiān says "there will be no more" that she suddenly lifts her hooves and steps into the silent river.

Getian: Mm? What is she doing?

Of course, Bessmert can also hear the sound of her entering the water, but she only shakes her head.

She knows what the girl is going to do. The moment has arrived for her to offer her assistance.

Getian: Even shallow water could also be dangerous. She ...

Bessmert: Trust her. She knows what she's doing.

The water begins to engulf half of Yenisei's body. At the same time, her song begins.

Getian: What is this?

Colorful dots of light suddenly ignited in the narrow river in front of them, burning like intense flames along the water's surface.

Then, the dots of light meandered to the soft riverbank, drifting with the song, like travelers on the long river, journeying without end.

The place where the light passes through now shines brighter than all the decorations in the city streets, more than many years worth of river lanterns that had passed through the mountains.

Bessmert: There are river lanterns, yes? I can't see them, but I can feel the light.

Bessmert: Are you appreciating them with your own eyes?

Getian: I ... don't ...

Faced with such a scene, Gětiān is struck dumb. He can sense Yenisei's arcanist origins in her bones, but he cannot even begin to imagine what is happening at this moment.

Bessmert: Mr. Gětiān ...

Bessmert: The fact is ... you've seen too many people and grown attached to too many things since you left the mountain.

Bessmert: They float in your mind, glistening like the river lanterns.

Bessmert: And you're saddened by the idea that they will be gone one day, like the lanterns drifting away from your sight.

Getian: ...!

Bessmert: But have you thought that those bright, agile, and hope-rising flakes of light would gleam once again?

Bessmert: The path of destiny is not always a dead end.

Getian: ...

Bessmert: It's too soon to give up, Mr. Gětiān.

Bessmert: Here ... It is your wand. Put it away, and please give this another thought.

6#1

New Year's Eve

NS-18

In the tavern courtyard at night, the sky is still gloomy with the promise of rain yet to fall, and mist shrouds the heads of all present.

But the festive atmosphere of the banquet seems unaffected, and the damp mist is easily dispersed by the clamor and high spirits.

Jiu Niangzi: ...

Citizen I: Oh, Jiǔ Niángzǐ, you are welcoming us at the door this year.

Jiu Niangzi: Because Lǐzhèng said ... Oh, welcome, guys! You're all here.

Citizen I: What's going on? You seem absent-minded.

Citizen I: Here, Zhúyè flower seeds. I know this is the only flower you would use to make liquor.

Citizen I: And here are two festoons with auspicious deer patterns. Not a fancy kind, but I made the pattern myself. Put it on the wall if you want. It would look as lovely as the horse paper-cutouts you gave me last year.

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, dear, this is too much. I'll hang them up right away!

Jiu Niangzi: Thank you so much!

Citizen I: Don't worry! To be honest, I didn't see that you would be welcoming us at the door. I thought I could sneak in and empty the jars before you showed up.

Most had intended to spend the festival at home, but now they gather here at the generous invitation of Jiǔ Niángzǐ. The golden colors of the courtyard displayed for all to see, punctuated by the delicacies and fine liquor on offer.

Almost every corner is filled with people, who scattered about like sand in the desert, with status and age set aside and all notions of formality cast to the wind.

Jiu Niangzi: One, two, three, four ...

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ.

Jiu Niangzi: Seven, eight, nine ... Huh, hmm?

Lizheng: Everyone is here.

Jiu Niangzi: I'm not sure about that. I haven't counted them up yet.

Lizheng: That might be Fǎcáo. His family is here, without him.

Jiu Niangzi: Is he still patrolling? This late? Is he still looking for the foreign ladies?

Lizheng: Perhaps. But it is not polite to keep other guests waiting.

Jiu Niangzi: I see ... Then, let's start the party first. I'll save him his liquor.

Lizheng: Alright, everyone!

Lizheng: The hostess has a toast to make. Please pay attention.

Jiu Niangzi: Thank you.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ stands up above the crowd, hoping that everyone can see her.

Although her mind begins blank, some heartfelt words bubble up, brought to the fore by the encouraging gazes below.

Jiu Niangzi: A-ahem! Everyone here knows that I can't read and can't say some sweet words like toasting ...

Citizen V: Just say whatever you want!

Citizen IV: Don't interrupt her, you imbecile!

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, alright? Well, haha, where was I ...

Lizheng: A toast.

Jiu Niangzi: Right. A toast! But I can't do it myself, so I copied a line from the book at the place where I work now. I like how it sounds!

Jiu Niangzi: "I bid thee all to drink and be merry, do not stay thy hand from thine cup."

Jiu Niangzi: Hope I didn't pronounce it wrong. It means ... people should drink, and drink more, so you shouldn't say no to it!

Citizen III: Is that so?

Jiu Niangzi: Well, whatever! Anyhow ...

Without waiting for everyone present to react, she looks up and drinks her bowl dry in a single gulp.

Her bowl is now slightly tilted, indicating that it has been emptied. Jiǔ Niángzǐ's gaze glides over each face, one by one, and finally she laughs with glee.

Jiu Niangzi: Bottoms up, and fill your cups. Cheers!

Soon, the cry of "cheers" begins to echo through the courtyard, one after another, rising wave by wave, until even the festoons on the eaves are shaking.

Crowd: Cheers!

Jiu Niangzi: You've always been nice and warm to me since I came here. I can't do anything in return but host this feast.

Jiu Niangzi: Hope you enjoy the liquor and the dinner. I wish you a Peaceful New Year's Eve. May all of your wishes come true in the coming Shuòrì.

Jiu Niangzi: Er, Lǐzhèng, do you have anything else to say?

Lizheng: A "Peaceful New Year's Eve" would be enough.

Citizen V: Peaceful New Year's Eve ...

Citizen II: Peaceful New Year's Eve!

Citizen III: Peaceful New Year's Eve.

Lǐzhèng sits among them, like a kindly old man from their neighborhood, rather than an imposing governor.

The crowd loosens up once again shortly after he finishes speaking, the sound of clinking cups and tapping chopsticks continuing to rise and fall.

Citizen IV: You did a good job with the toast, Jiǔ Niángzǐ. Looks like you've learned something from those love poems. You must have read them unconsciously after you stuck them on the wall ...

Citizen I: Oh, please, that custom is no longer popular in our neighborhood!

Citizen I: I'd rather transfer the poem onto a kerchief and make a purse out of it, just like Jiǔ Niángzǐ did. It draws so much attention on the street!

Jiu Niangzi: Actually, I still can't read what they write on the purse. But the characters seem beautiful!

Citizen V: What about the one you recited during the toast? You sounded really fluent. Who taught that to you?

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, haha, that's from the former Zhílǐ, the one who went back to her hometown. She taught me that.

Citizen III: Speaking of her, is she going to come back?

Jiu Niangzi: I didn't know any better ... But by now, she should be at home, having New Year's Eve dinner.

Citizen I: Did you hear from her? If she doesn't come back, you'll have to work as the official Zhílǐ. Who will take care of the tavern by then?

Citizen I: The tavern has never had a reliable owner before you. It would have still been run down if you hadn't taken over it.

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ is kind and warm-hearted. Such a girl of integrity can perform well in both running a tavern and being a Zhílǐ.

Citizen I: You have a high regard for her, Lǐzhèng. Are you telling the truth or showing partiality?

Lizheng: The truth, of course. What she said in the Zhící a few hours ago is still vivid in my mind.

Lizheng: I once again realized that it's never too late to learn.

Jiu Niangzi: No, no, no, I'm not as good as you say.

Citizen I: What did she say?

Lizheng: Things like "One can remove the footsteps, but not the path one walketh on," "Act not against the nature of thy flesh, for through it all things were made." ... She made it sound easy.

The crowd erupts in a series of alarmed cries.

Citizen V: Really?

Lizheng: Absolutely. She is indeed illiterate, but she keeps learning and interprets the classic sayings in her own way.

Lizheng: Even if there were other scholars, they would be convinced by her powerful speech. Sadly, the one she confronted was not a human but a Yāo.

Citizen I: Confronted a Yāo in the Zhící ... Was that the feather man?

Lizheng: She thought the feather man was Xiángruì and asked him some questions.

Citizen V: You actually asked him questions?! He could have turned you into another striped horse!

Jiu Niangzi: Um, I didn't think of that back then ... This is the first time I've ever been so close to a Yāo. He looks so similar to the ones in the books! So I ...

Facao: Jiǔ Niángzǐ ...

Facao: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, where are you?

The rapid sound of footsteps approaches, and their leader's figure steps into the tavern in several broad and forceful steps.

The abrupt sound severs the excitement in the courtyard.

Jiu Niangzi: Wh-what happened?

Citizen I: What is ...?

Facao: Where is Jiǔ Niángzǐ?

Jiu Niangzi: Here, I'm here! What's happening?

Facao: Turns out those foreign ladies have been in league with Gětiān the whole time. They helped him break out of jail and hid themselves in the wild with their arcane skills.

Facao: I'm sure it will rain again soon and it will be dangerous to stay in the wild. By then, they will come to you.

Facao: Because you are the feather man's target.

In the courtyard, the crowd's gaze follows Fǎcáo closely, while Fǎcáo's own eyes are fixed on Jiǔ Niángzǐ. They realize now that some word of resistance is on her tongue.

Lizheng: What ... Jiǔ Niángzǐ, you ...

Lizheng: You must leave here. You can't stay in the tavern.

Jiu Niangzi: But it's-it's my tavern! Why am I leaving my own place?

Facao: You are in danger. Since Gětiān was able to break out of jail, he'll for sure be able to break into the Zhící. For your safety, I will have my soldiers escort you to the government office.

Facao: That's the only safe place now.

Jiu Niangzi: No, I'm not leaving. He is neither a Xiángruì nor a strong Yāo ...

Jiu Niangzi: Why are we afraid of him?

The sound of wings cutting through the air overlaps the end of Jiǔ Niángzǐ's question.

The new arrival spreads his wings, like a dark cloud blanketing the courtyard's colorful decorations and dazzling lights.

Citizen III: Watch out!

Citizen I: Waaah!

Getian: She's right.

Getian: You need not fear me. This lady owner of the tavern is the bigger concern here.

Facao: Formation One!

The well-trained guards surround the tavern, and the sound of running, trampling feet echoes through the courtyard.

Facao: I knew you would come for her.

Facao: Where are your accomplices? Are you the vanguard of the team?

Getian: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, it's not too late for you to stop.

Getian: No more turning people into a Lùshǔ. Too many people have gone missing because of you.

This information, unknown present, hits like a stone cast into water.

Questions and whispers begin to circulate through the crowd like ripples in a pond.

Citizen V: Turn people into a Lùshǔ? But the wanted poster says those are striped horses.

Citizen IV: What is he talking about?

Jiǔ Niángzǐ looks up into the air and stares straight at the looming figure of Gětiān above her.

Jiu Niangzi: What are you talking about?

Jiu Niangzi: You know nothing about Lùshǔs. Besides, what do I have to do with the missing people?

Citizen I: He's talking nonsense, right, Jiǔ Niángzǐ?

Facao: Save the talk.

Facao: Catch him first.

6#1

A Wish Come True

NS-19

The uninvited guest is not willing to attack, even in his own defense. So a one-sided battle ensues. It is only natural that the side resigned to only evading will eventually lose.

Facao: Surrender, and dispel your arcane skill. Turn the victims back to who they were.

At this moment, Bessmert and Yenisei rush to the edge of the encirclement. The communication arcane skill that Gětiān cast on them earlier is quietly translating the words for people.

Facao: We will put an end to it before the Shuòrì.

Getian: But I don't possess the power to transform people from one shape to another, and thus, cannot turn them back.

Getian: You're asking the wrong one.

Gětiān struggles to hold on and rests on the eaves, still looking directly at Jiǔ Niángzǐ with some hidden meaning.

But Jiǔ Niángzǐ shows no hint of understanding, simply looking back with a placid anger. Her look is so forceful that it is almost a glare.

Jiu Niangzi: Why do you have to blame this on me? I've never met those missing people. And I have no idea what you're talking about!

Jiu Niangzi: Is-is this because ... Did you have a grudge against me or something?

Getian: Nothing of that sort. I'm here only to prevent an unwanted escalation.

Getian: I could have just walked away, and there's nothing you can do. I could have gone to other mountains, and life would have continued as it has always been. But for those who have been turned into half Lùshǔs ...

Getian: No one can get them out of this trouble.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ stands stunned before him. After a moment, she struggles out an accusatory remark, but her voice trembles slightly.

Jiu Niangzi: "Been turned into half Lùshǔs"? Are you saying that the animals in my backyard, and those in the Zhící ...

Jiu Niangzi: Are they all the missing people?

Jiu Niangzi: But, but I thought they were just Lùshǔs. The first time I saw them, it was clear that we were alike. We're just some ...

Jiu Niangzi: ... half divine beasts.

The crowd is thrown into a commotion. She turns a deaf ear to them and once again stares blankly at Gětiān.

Jiu Niangzi: So they must not be humans! I've done nothing to-to transform them!

Jiu Niangzi: I'm just taking good care of them, so that they can tell me where they're from, and if they can ... take me home.

Her trembling words usher in a silence. Gětiān, who knows she has already begun to waver, can only sigh. It seems he is starting to see the whole picture for what it is.

Getian: ...

Getian: "The Niǔyáng Mountain shelters the beasts. The beasts have white heads, red tails, the bodies of horses, and the markings of tigers. When they neigh, the sound becomes music. The name is Lùshǔ."

Getian: The "striped horses" you keep in the yard are half Lùshǔs. They look like what's told in the tales, and they cry like humming songs in the moonlight.

Getian: And the wooden dolls infuse your arcane skill, The Shape of Will, into the liquor, which turns people into Lùshǔs, or, half Lùshǔs. As for the dolls, they were once soaked in the water of Pèilín River, were they not?

Jiu Niangzi: The stream runs through the backyard ...

Jiu Niangzi: No, no way! They went there just for fun or a bath! They should not ... should not ...

Beyond the encirclement formed by patrolling troops, Bessmert judges the course of events through the sound of people's voices.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ falls silent. The seeds of suspicion have been planted, and it is now time for witnesses to take the stand.

Striped Horse?: *neighs*

Hidden in the crowd, Yenisei crashes into the soldiers on both sides of her.

Sharp swords and spears brush over her Lùshǔ skin, but she seems completely unfazed, charging straight toward the direction of the water jar.

Facao: What ... Who let it in?

Facao: Catch it!

The water leaking from the jar creates puddles in the crevices of the courtyard. Although it isn't much, it is still enough to buy some time.

Yenisei: Wait!

Lizheng: It's you?!

Lǐzhèng immediately looks up at Gětiān, as though wishing to catch a glimpse of the arcane skill cast from his still figure, only to find nothing there.

Facao: The markings of a tiger and a red mane ... Exactly what the feather man said. But its reflection is a woman.

A gasp sounds out from the crowd.

Citizen I: Oh my, that reflection. Is that the foreign lady from the street earlier?

Jiǔ Niángzǐ also casts a bewildered gaze toward Yenisei.

Jiu Niangzi: You-you are a Lùshǔ. You're a real Lùshǔ now. This ... is what a Lùshǔ should be.

Jiu Niangzi: But, but why are you still here?

Yenisei: I don't see what you mean, Ms. Jiǔ Niángzǐ.

Jiu Niangzi: You're hurt. And you shouldn't be here. It's not right.

She lightly taps the pool of water with her hand, as if soothing the invisible reflection of herself.

Jiu Niangzi: I thought you were able to recognize your teammates and had already left here.

Yenisei: Wait, what ... GOSH!

Yenisei: I ... I get it!

Even Yenisei's reflection in the water ripples in response to this sudden realization.

Yenisei: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, you turned me into a Lùshǔ because you thought that would help me find my teammates, didn't you? Last night, you said you would help me, so this is how you ...

Yenisei: But I was not asking for help! I was only being emotional or pouring out my troubles. Anyway, I was not asking for anything from you.

Yenisei: From the talk, I could feel the sincerity from the bottom of your heart. It was too real to be fake.

Yenisei: I understand you were trying to help, and that was enough.

Jiu Niangzi: But-but I don't understand!

Jiu Niangzi: The Daoist said, "The one who can protect and benefit the people shall be a Xiángruì." If you can, but you don't, that would be wrong.

Jiu Niangzi: I've done a terrible job. I'm not that majestic, nor do I look like any Xiángruìs in the book ... I can't even turn into a real Lùshǔ! How is that enough?

She shakes her head and takes two steps back, until she can retreat no longer and collides with a motionless patrol guard.

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, I think you need to tell us everything.

Lǐzhèng, who has been standing nearby, now speaks, his tone intensifying as he goes on.

Lizheng: Have you ever transformed people into Lùshǔs?

Jiǔ Niángzǐ turns her head, only to find that everyone's gaze has now shifted toward her, needling her with probing eyes.

Lizheng: Answer us!

Jiu Niangzi: I-I swear, I was trying to help ...

Jiu Niangzi: ... to help everyone get what they want. Just like the former Zhílǐ—she wanted to go back to her hometown, so I offered her a drink and sent her back.

Facao: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, do you understand what you are saying?

Jiu Niangzi: I understand every word I say!!

Her reaction says more than any confession.

Every sentence. Every sentence is a declaration—every sentence is an interrogation.

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, what have you done?

Getian: You should have asked this a lot earlier.

Lizheng: What did you do to the Zhílǐ?!

Jiu Niangzi: I ...

With Lǐzhèng, who had always trusted her, turning on her in anger, Jiǔ Niángzǐ's reaction is to grab her own arm tightly as if for protection.

She wants to step back again, to keep herself away from the intense emotion, but there is nowhere left for her to go.

All she can do now is answer.

Jiu Niangzi: She-she came to my tavern and complained that you didn't understand her at all, and that she was considering going back to her hometown.

Jiu Niangzi: But it seemed far away from Pèi City. She looked sad and tired, and didn't know what to do.

Lizheng: So, so you ...

Jiu Niangzi: I must grant her wish, mustn't I?

Jiu Niangzi: The Daoist said, a Lùshǔ can easily go a thousand miles within a day. If they start running, go faster, that will be over ten thousand miles.

Jiu Niangzi: If that's how I can help her, I should definitely do that!

Lizheng: You ...

Jiǔ Niángzǐ lowers her eyes, trying to find more suitable words for her confession, but in the end, only a knot of confused sadness fills her throat.

Jiu Niangzi: Just like-like now. If the Pèilín River dries out, you have nowhere to go ...

Jiu Niangzi: Just turn into Lùshǔs, and then you won't suffer. Lùshǔs can go anywhere they want. To the north, to the south, wherever they want.

Jiu Niangzi: I can grant your wish differently, even if I can't recover the river from drought. I was thinking going away freely might be a good choice. But, in the end ...

Jiu Niangzi: But, in the end, in the end, what I'm doing is ... wrong?

For a moment, almost everyone is at a loss for how to deal with this revelation. Every sentence seems to them to be absurdly wrong, but the tone with which she speaks is completely sincere.

Yet no matter what explanation she might offer, it only reveals that the true culprit of the disappearances was in fact Jiǔ Niángzǐ herself.

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, you ...

No one familiar with Jiǔ Niángzǐ anticipated this moment. That on the eve of the festival, a time of joy and reunion, they had to come to grips with a colossal disaster caused by such a simple act of childishness.

Jiu Niangzi: But if not by doing this, then ... what else can I do?

This matter is too chilling and heartbreaking for an early spring night.

Yenisei, who has remained silent for a long time, takes a step forward.

Yenisei: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, remember what you said to me last night?

Yenisei: Liquor has many different names, but they are still "liquor."

Yenisei: You can put on many different clothes, but you will still be the same Jiǔ Niángzǐ.

Yenisei: Likewise, whether you turn me into a horse, a donkey, or a Lùshǔ, I will still be the same Yenisei.

Yenisei: You don't have to force yourself to become the people's Xiángruì. I think it's only an unreachable symbol.

Yenisei: What matters is that the Jiǔ Niángzǐ I know would do whatever she could to help others. That's just what a Xiángruì does, as far as I know. Even though some results turned out to be not so satisfying, your sincerity is as valuable as the Xiángruì itself.

Yenisei: So now, you just need to turn us all back.

Getian: Yes. So turn back, when no path lies before you. It's never too late to return.

Seeing Lǐzhèng, who has been silent for a while now, nodding, Jiǔ Niángzǐ's worried expression begins to stifle a few beams of hope.

Jiu Niangzi: I-I will. I will do my best!

Jiǔ Niángzǐ turns around and whistles. Immediately after, the sound of wooden footsteps follows and gradually echoes around the courtyard. They circle in and silently jump around her.

Jiu Niangzi: Alright! You can talk now. It's okay ...

Wooden Doll: **They, trapped you.**

Wooden Doll: **We, save you.**

Jiu Niangzi: What?

Lizheng: These handicrafts are able to talk ...

Lizheng: How could you be manipulated by them, Jiǔ Niángzǐ.

Wooden Dolls: **Save you. Save you!**

Jiu Niangzi: No-no! You're getting it wrong! Don't save me!

Jiu Niangzi: Lǐzhèng, I'm not manipulated! They're just wood! Well, they're indeed my friends ... No, no, no, that's not for now ...

Jiu Niangzi: They just talk like that! That's not what they mean!

The elder's patience teeters now on the verge of exhaustion, yet his responsibilities force him to stay calm and wait patiently for the end of this farce.

Lizheng: This shall be the last time I put my trust in you. Ask them how to transform people back.

Lizheng: But if you can't ...

Jiǔ Niángzǐ knows that there can be no "can't" allowed at this juncture.

She turns her head to look at the patrolmen surrounding the entire courtyard, and the locals with their fearful faces. Finally, she shakes her head to clear her mind of any unnecessary emotions and focuses on just one thing.

Jiu Niangzi: You-you heard him. Now, please tell me how to turn them back into humans, will you?

Jiu Niangzi: If it requires liquor, I'll get it for you ...

Wooden Doll: **Way. No way. Once turned, no turning back.**

Wooden Doll: **The white-haired Daoist. The yellow drawing, on forehead. You forgot.**

Jiu Niangzi: The Daoist? I didn't forget anything! And you ...

Jiu Niangzi: I see. You must be messing with me, because I treated you badly this morning. This is your revenge, right? It's not the time for it. I really need you to ...

Wooden Doll: **No way.**

Jiu Niangzi: No, no! There must be a way! I must-I must be able to dispel my own craft ...

At the end of her somewhat lackluster speech, her voice weakens to a whimper—an acknowledgment that there is no way out.

Facao: You must come to the Zhící with me, Jiǔ Niángzǐ. We'll see what we can do.

He signals to the patrol soldiers to come forward and take her away. At this moment, Jiǔ Niángzǐ no longer seems willing to cooperate and instead takes another step back.

Jiu Niangzi: I'm sorry. I'm sorry. But I must fix it. I can fix it! This is all because of me. I need to ...

She makes a ritual gesture, attempting one final desperate act of self-salvation.

Jiu Niangzi: I, um, I will think carefully, think of what I did before ...

Jiu Niangzi: I can do it. I can do it without them ...

Wooden Doll: **No. It hurts. Very. Writhing pain.**

Jiu Niangzi: Urgh!!

A dim light emanates from her forehead, like moonlight or the silver stripes on the Lùshǔ's skin in the dead of night.

Wooden Dolls: **Save you! We save you!**

Wooden Dolls: **SAVE YOU!**

The sound of more wooden dolls leaping wildly rings out. They emerge from various corners of the courtyard, breaking through the encirclement of patrol soldiers and locals with unexpected force, heading straight toward Jiǔ Niángzǐ.

The miniature wooden creations begin to grow rapidly in a twisted transformation before Jiǔ Niángzǐ, who is now overwhelmed by a sudden burst of pain.

They shift from a human form into strange, enormous beasts. To this point, everything has proceeded almost exactly like the prophecy.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ sits slumped in the debris of the wooden dolls smashed through everyone's joint efforts, the pain fading from her face leaves only a desperate look of despair.

She holds the fragments of wood, helpless—as though she were that weak and panicked girl in the bustling marketplace once more.

Jiu Niangzi: Seems what they said is true. I can't do it.

Jiu Niangzi: I just want everything to be back to normal. Is that too much?

Getian: There should have been ways to undo it. But now even I am confounded.

Getian: Your pain is real. Then ...

Bessmert: ...

Beside the broken water jar, Yenisei looks toward Bessmert, who seems to feel something and gently breaks free from the stupefied patrol soldiers.

This static courtyard is like a frozen scene, and Bessmert is the only actor walking freely on stage.

Not being able to see the danger gives her an unworldly calm.

Bessmert: You said you "can't do it," not that you "don't want to." Right?

Bessmert: The arcane skill with conditions cannot be taken back once it is cast.

Bessmert: Just like the irretrievable curses and vows in Siberian shamanism.

Getian: I can see some markings on this girl's skull, like an unknown seal. I've been speculating about what caused the limitation of her power.

Getian: This may be the reason why she is in pain. A seal powerful enough to change one's marking on the bones is not to be easily broken.

Jiu Niangzi: Skull ...?

Jiǔ Niángzǐ raises her hand and touches her forehead.

The yellow drawing upon it should have been swept away by this sudden movement, forming a colorful mark, or something else, but it doesn't.

Jiu Niangzi: I don't know what you're talking about ...

Her exploration bearing no fruit, Jiǔ Niángzǐ wearily withdraws her hand and gives up her investigation.

Jiu Niangzi: I can't. I can turn them into Lùshǔs, but not the opposite way.

Jiu Niangzi: Maybe-maybe I can't be a Xiángruì at all. I'm not qualified.

At this point, the story has entered an unsolvable impasse.

Bessmert: Alright. There's one more question that seems to be overlooked by us all.

Bessmert: How many people have drunk Jiǔ Niángzǐ's liquor ...

Bessmert: ... in the merry festival spirit?

6#1

Farewell to the Past

NS-20

When the voice of this outsider fades, the fated hour also arrives. Those among the crowd who drank the liquor undergo a transformation amidst chaotic screams, as each and every one of them becomes a Lùshǔ.

As Jiǔ Niángzǐ watches this irreversible scene, she is unaware that tears are already flowing down her face.

She has made no progress at all. Everything is no different now than it was a few years ago, when she was even more reckless and naive.

Jiu Niangzi: The Daoist told me that my mother was the ninth Lùshǔ from the very beginning of time.

Jiu Niangzi: Great, though, distant.

Jiu Niangzi: After all, except for the moment she turned from a human into a Yāo when she was leaving ...

Jiu Niangzi: I don't quite remember her.

Daoist: Your mother was the Xiángruì, the people's guardian.

Jiu Niangzi (Child): What is a Xiángruì?

Daoist: The spirit of auspiciousness, the great Yāo who protects and benefits people, like your mother once did.

Daoist: But a Xiángruì is not supposed to have any personal feelings. She fell because of you, because of the personal feeling. Remember that.

Jiu Niangzi (Child): What is a "personal feeling"?

Daoist: It's something she shouldn't have had, for you, either.

Daoist: But you shall keep to the path she left.

Jiu Niangzi (Child): What path?

Jiu Niangzi (Child): Is it like the dirt path we're walking on, or, or the stone path around the house?

Daoist: Neither.

Daoist: Stay in this city. Be their guardian. Be a Xiángruì.

Daoist: You shall understand when the day comes.

Jiu Niangzi: The Daoist brought me here, and left me here.

Jiu Niangzi: That's exactly what my mother, the former Xiángruì, did to me as well. So I took departure as the price of living in the human world.

Jiu Niangzi: Before I came into Pèi City, the Daoist guaranteed me that ...

Jiu Niangzi: "Be a Xiángruì, and then you will understand her."

Jiu Niangzi: How alluring was that! That's why I chose to stay here.

Jiu Niangzi: At first, I couldn't stop thinking about what the Daoist said, but I had no idea how.

Jiu Niangzi: Because I was never taught how by anyone.

Jiu Niangzi: I didn't have any other choice, so ...

Jiu Niangzi: So I started to recall my mother by piecing together the scattered words and descriptions from books and legends, to recall what a Xiángruì is.

Jiu Niangzi: I tried to be her, tried to replace her.

Jiu Niangzi: Just to meet her, once again.

Jiu Niangzi: If I got to meet her, I would ask her, "What was on your mind?"

Jiu Niangzi: If only you could see me doing such a great job as a Xiángruì, would you feel even the slightest twinge of guilt? For deserting me, for leaving me alone.

Jiu Niangzi: Well.

Jiu Niangzi: Looks like I've neither truly understood her, nor a Xiángruì.

Between the two people standing in the courtyard walkway in the silent rain, a decision is made.

Facao: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, are you really going to ...

As someone who has always been steadfast in his will, he rarely hesitates. He doesn't know which words to use to emphasize the danger of this matter to the person in front of him, or whether all words are powerless before her final choice.

And so, ultimately, he remains silent.

Jiu Niangzi: It's fine. I know there's no one who could jump over it. In order to stop me, Lǐzhèng even told me some stories, and they were ... not very suitable for children.

Jiu Niangzi: But I have to, because there is no other way ...

Jiu Niangzi: Only The Divination.

Jiu Niangzi: Well, you can't talk about Shuòrì without The Divination, right?

Jiu Niangzi: ...

Jiu Niangzi: Thank you for letting me go. You even brought me the clothes. But the Zhílǐ is not here. I'm not sure if I'm wearing it right ...

Jiu Niangzi: But it's ok. Even if it's wrong, it still looks new and colorful.

She pats the hem of her skirt aimlessly, then folds the cuffs, and finally folds back the silk drapes once more. When she cannot find anything else to fix, her farewell rises to the tip of her tongue.

Jiu Niangzi: Thank you. Thank you so very much. I-er, I ...

Jiu Niangzi: I'm leaving, then.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ steps back and places her hands beneath her forehead, palm to back. She bows farewell to Fǎcáo in the hallway and the Lùshǔ turned from Lǐzhèng.

A gesture of gratitude and an apology. She has never performed such a ritual before—this will be the first and last time.

Facao: Perhaps we will find another way. You don't have to ...

He doesn't finish. Because anything he wants to say would be untrue, an example of unwarranted comfort from a survivor toward their aggressor.

And so, Jiǔ Niángzǐ says nothing. She shakes her head as if she hadn't even heard his proposal, retreating into the rain, and then turns around and walks towards the outside of the Zhící.

Her footsteps have never been so relaxed before, with each step becoming faster and faster, almost evolving into a sprint toward the end.

She runs toward the outside of the city, but not to escape.

Broken Bridge, Outside the City

The rain has not stopped since the previous night.

Outside the city, Bessmert and Yenisei stand at the end of the broken bridge, gazing at the misty bank opposite to them.

Gětiān is perched on the tree above their heads. He has been here all along, arriving earlier than the others.

Bessmert: Mr. Gětiān, we ...

Bessmert: We are left with only one option, which is to stand here and pray for her, correct?

Bessmert: Pray that the Ask and Acquire, or The Divination, will answer us and give us what we want in a flash.

Bessmert: But is it really possible?

Getian: ...

Getian: I think not. We should go.

Bessmert listens to the advancing footsteps around her, emanating from all those who are walking toward the broken bridge, still remembering the auspicious significance of this New Year's Day.

At first, she tries to distinguish the voices that might be Fǎcáo and the others, but as the rain grows heavier and louder, she finally gives up.

Bessmert: I heard today is a special day for the locals, known as "Suìzhāochūn."

Bessmert: Mr. Gětiān, what is Suìzhāochūn?

Bessmert holds her wet fringe to one side, and tilts the oiled umbrella towards Yenisei.

The Lùshǔ silently approaches and leans against her tightly.

Getian: It comes from an ancient proverb, "Bǎizǎi Nánféng Suìzhāochūn."

Getian: It's the first day of a new year and the first day of spring.

Getian: Lìchūn, the beginning of spring, corresponds to the lower trigram of Kǎn in the direction of Gèn. It is the season of life.

Getian: A time when the weather is clear and Yáng fills the air.

Bessmert: They are pleasing to the ears.

Bessmert: But I don't know what to make of it when all these are put together.

Getian: Lìchūn is one of the 24 solar terms. It signifies the beginning of spring.

Getian: Suìzhāochūn is how people would call it when the first day of the Dùshuò Festival and the first day of spring happen to be the same day. It is a once-in-a-century good sign.

Bessmert: Indeed. It's also the first day of a new year. I like the coincidence.

Getian: Do you still find it equally pleasing if your teammates are not coming back?

Bessmert: Then, I will take them home as they are now and see what I can do.

Getian: ...

Bessmert: I know the words are hidden behind your silence, but this is the best option for now.

Bessmert: After all, as you just said, prayers are not enough to bring them back.

Getian: They could, for a time.

Bessmert: But that's only what happened in the past, as you just said. Good days only exist in our memories.

Getian: That was before the flood. The aftermath of that disaster lasted longer than I thought.

Getian: I was so wrong to think it was over.

Bessmert looks up. A drop of rain falls right onto the fabric she uses to cover her eyes. Then more falls, and more, gradually wetting the entire weaved surface.

She listens without intending any comment.

Getian: It all began with the unstoppable flood. At first, it was just a few unusual tides that no one noticed.

Getian: Then the flood came, followed by the destruction of the bridge.

Getian: The temple on the mountain thus lost its connection to its pilgrims. The prayers were no longer answered.

Getian: I do not understand what caused all these things. My people left the mountain to help with the situation, but they never came back.

Getian: And now ...

Getian: Even this river beneath us is gone, just like the Yuān Temple, forever lost in the fog.

Getian: ...

Behind them, the city residents gradually approach and carve words of divination onto the wooden sticks in their hands, just as they had in previous years.

They are prepared for the fact that there may not be an answer to their questions, but they know nothing of the reason why.

Bessmert feels the weight of the growing crowd. They gather and write in the rain, working tirelessly for a long time.

Is it the eternal fate of humans and arcanists to act upon desires they know cannot be realized?

Getian: It's useless. The god won't hear us, nor will It see us.

Bessmert: Please know that I don't mean to offend you with this question.

Getian: Please.

Bessmert: Can't you take those people to the other end of the bridge?

Bessmert: If the condition of The Divination is to go across the broken bridge ...

Getian: Though we are both outsiders in this place, you're more naive than I am.

Bessmert: Emm ...?

Getian: One can only meet the condition by going over the bridge oneself, even if the price is their life.

Getian: You might think it's cruel. But what good would it do if people were easily given what they asked for without paying a price?

Getian: Wouldn't it make others' suffering a joke?

Bessmert: ...

Gětiān lowers his head to look at Bessmert and the quiet Yenisei beside him, thinking that they perhaps do not believe his words.

He rarely needs to say so much to others in such a short space of time. But since he has already started, he might as well finish.

Getian: You don't believe me.

Bessmert: I'm ... trying to understand.

Getian: It's all the same. I can take you to the other side of the bridge, but you must not be disappointed if it ends up fruitless.

Bessmert: Pardon?

Getian: I can take you there.

Bessmert: Why? Why the change of mind?

Getian: Mm? Haven't I mentioned it before?

Bessmert: Mentioned what?

Getian: Your bones. Among all the others, you are the only one for whom I do not recognize the markings on your bones.

6#1

Another Way Out

NS-21

This new discovery swiftly draws Bessmert's attention away from the broken bridge.

Bessmert: Mm? What is that supposed to mean?

Getian: Judging from the fact that you have unreadable bones, you're certainly neither a Yāo, nor a human. A grumkin? No.

Bessmert: Oh, I'm also an arcanist.

Getian: My instinct told me that I should flee to the end of the world the moment I saw you.

Bessmert: You did run away, along with my poor teammates, who were turned into Lùshǔs.

Getian: ...

Getian: I could not have imagined being around someone with unreadable bones.

Getian: Turns out it wasn't as strange as I thought it would be.

Bessmert: Not much difference, you mean? Like the people here believe that there's no difference between humans and arcanists, which makes me very surprised.

Getian: Based on the bones I've seen, they are different. It's just that ...

Bessmert: Doesn't make a difference, right?

Bessmert: We are the same when we desire something.

Bessmert turns her face toward where the people are moving.

She holds her face as if firmly staring at something, despite her lack of sight.

Bessmert: I wasn't questioning you or the temple when I asked you about flying to the other side.

Bessmert: I wasn't even questioning the strange condition of this arcane skill.

Getian: What do you mean?

Bessmert: I was ... running out of options, I guess.

Bessmert: It was just some futile effort I made when I realized this was a dead end, but I have no idea how it got to this point.

Bessmert makes her decision. She lifts the oiled umbrella and sticks it between the branches above her head. Walking out from beneath its cover, heading toward the people carving sticks in the rain.

Yenisei does not stop either. She follows behind Bessmert—just as she has been doing since their departure.

Getian: Where are you going?

Bessmert: I have questions to ask.

Getian: Even if there're no answers?

Bessmert: Yes. I think ... it is the same for all these people.

Bessmert: They keep asking, even though they hear no answers.

Bessmert walks forward, almost reaching the broken bridge, until Yenisei grabs her sleeve.

Bessmert: It's okay. I know what you're going to say.

Yenisei reveals her image in the rain. The surface of the water is lightly pattered by raindrops, and her face is rippled by their falling.

Fortunately, her heart is no longer swaying like her reflection.

Yenisei: How are you going to do it? We don't have any wooden chips like that.

Bessmert: I will use my finger, mud, and water, on the ground.

Bessmert: You can ask, too, whatever means you use.

Yenisei: What I want to know ...

Bessmert crouches down and pokes her index finger into the soft mud, writing a few Cyrillic letters. Then, others, and then still more.

By the time she finishes writing the entire question, the first letters have already been eaten by the heavy rain, like seawater washing away etchings on a beach.

Bessmert: Child, what's your question? Say it if you like.

Yenisei: I think I will write it down.

Yenisei doesn't believe that doing so will have any purpose. But she cannot refuse Bessmert.

As she gazes at her face in the pool of water, she once again activates her arcane skill and asks the question that has been waiting in her heart.

The red-haired girl suddenly disappears from the pool of water in front of her. Instead, a line of Cyrillic letters composed of warm-colored dots appears on the clear water's surface.

The girl looks at the water and realizes that the line of words doesn't even need to be fully legible.

Rain pounds and waves rise. The water trembles with her question.

"Where is my water?"

The sudden emergence of more animal footsteps prevents Yenisei from becoming lost in deeper thought.

The red-haired girl reappears in the water, her tone as unsparing as usual.

Yenisei: Are they still going to carry out the Fortune Walk?

Yenisei turns around.

These animals, neither Lùshǔs nor striped horses, have left the city's unattended Zhící and coincidentally arrived here.

They are stood there naked and tired, unadorned in any festive decorations.

The ribbons and flowers Yenisei had seen on that first day in the bustling market have disappeared. Not suitable for the present situation, after all.

Yenisei: ...

Yenisei: They are ... carrying wooden chips in their mouths ...

Bessmert: They're all here, right?

Yenisei: Yes.

Yenisei: With the wooden chips. They are here for The Divination.

Yenisei: But the chips are empty.

Bessmert: They will have to ask in their minds.

Yenisei: What would you like me to do?

Bessmert: ...

Bessmert: You can ...

Bessmert: You can be their mouths, hands, and eyes.

Bessmert: You can also do nothing.

Bessmert: Just like the good sir waiting behind us.

Gětiān remains in the tree and thus sees everything.

His wings have become damp and heavy from the rain, and the cloth on his head is soaked, pressing down heavily as if dragging him back down to the ground, back into the mud, back to the place where the world began.

He doesn't move, silently taking stock of everything that happened under that tree.

Yenisei: I see. If they are here for The Divination ...

Yenisei: I will help.

There are many puddles on the uneven ground. After a brief flicker of light, faces begin to appear in the water.

They fade again one by one, forming in long or short sentences. Though Yenisei cannot understand them. This is all she can do.

She continues to look for a while, then forces herself to turn around and search for Bessmert.

Yenisei: Madam, after we go back ...

Bessmert smiles, shakes her head gently, and halts the girl's words.

Bessmert turns around, seeming to be facing Gětiān's direction, back to the city gates from which everyone came.

She can sense a steady stream of energy flowing toward some destination.

Bessmert: You're wrong. "It" can hear us.

Gětiān is in the tree, shaking off his wings like a swallow—shaking off the reasons for making him feel so excessively damp.

He knows that Bessmert must not be talking to him, as the blind arcanist continues to work in vain.

But then he is wrong yet again.

Getian: Who is ... that?

The sound everyone present can hear becomes louder and louder against the breaking silence, accompanied now by nothing but the patter of the rain, to the point where they all turn back in response—

All they see is a red dress swiftly passing over them all.

It is Jiǔ Niángzǐ.

Both those familiar and unfamiliar with her quickly realize her identity, despite the change.

Why did she do it? Did she really jump over the broken bridge? What could possibly have happened to her after doing so?

A myriad of questions hovers in the minds of the confounded witnesses.

Yenisei: ...!

Bessmert: It was her. The noise I heard ... It was Jiǔ Niángzǐ, right?

Bessmert: It was an unusual disturbance when she jumped over the bridge.

Citizen I: That-that was Jiǔ Niángzǐ?

Citizen I: Mr. Liǔ, did you see that??

Citizen III: Yes! That's her, that's really her. High heaven, she did it, she jumped over!

In shock, someone hurriedly pokes their head toward the opposite bank of the broken bridge, but stops and withdraws at the cliff's edge.

They are seeking a definite answer, but fear the steepness and height of the cliff. Naturally, they never imagined someone might cross it—

Citizen I: This ... That ...

Yenisei: That's right. It's Jiǔ Niángzǐ ... I saw her turn into a Lùshǔ ... Madam, she turned into a real Lùshǔ!

Citizen I: *sobs* The people are back, and the river ...

Citizen V: The river! Ah, the Pèilín River is rising!

Beneath the cliff no longer lies a canyon or a low river, but a constantly rising torrent.

Citizen V: Wait, I can talk! My body is ... What's happening?!

The people finally react.

They look at each other excitedly, a red light illuminating their faces like the dazzling courtyard fires beneath the festival walkways—or the strip of light that appeared on the river before.

Their divine wishes have been granted.

Yenisei: Wait. I ...

Yenisei: My body is back?

Yenisei almost leaps into the air to embrace Bessmert.

Yenisei: Jiǔ Niángzǐ ... She jumped over the bridge! She jumped over ... in the human form!

Yenisei: She didn't fall! I'm not sure if I saw it clearly ... I think, for an instant, she turned into a real Lùshǔ.

Yenisei: Is this the power of The Divination, the magic of "Ask and Acquire"?

Yenisei: Oh, wait! The people in the city have come back, so maybe ...

A voice now long unheard also sounds from beside them.

Krolik: What ... the?

Krolik: Ugh, what's going on? Ah! My head hurts ...

Yenisei: Mr. Krolik!

In the crowd, all the companions they once had lost are now returned to them.

Jurien: Oh, dear ... I had the strangest dream ...

Yenisei: And Mr. Jurien, everyone!

Yenisei: They are over there! Madam, let's go see them!

Without waiting for an answer, Yenisei waves from a distance and immediately runs toward them.

Yenisei: Here! We are here ...

Bessmert: Bǎizǎi Nánféng Suìzhāochūn.

Bessmert: It's indeed a rare occasion.

6#1

Ask and Acquire

NS-22

Street, Inside the City

Storyteller: Previously, we were at ...

Citizen VI: Lùshǔ the Xiángruì came to the human world to go through the god's test, but she repented!

Storyteller: Exactly. She had been troubled by the repentance until the New Year's Eve. That night, her tutor straightened her out, and she was very grateful. After that, she bid him goodbye and went to the broken bridge alone.

Storyteller: However, ladies and gentlemen, the Shuòrì this year happened to be the beginning of spring. Such a coincidence happens only once every 100 years. On this peculiar day, the thunderstorm was raging, and all the strangest things happened!

Storyteller: The cliff was shrouded in confusing fog, and below was a bottomless abyss! No one had ever jumped over the bridge successfully, yet the Lùshǔ decided to make an attempt, for the sake of the people who believed in her! She was determined to retrieve the tortoise shell divination ...

Citizen VI: That's not it! She used the wooden chip! Not the tortoise shell!

Storyteller: Emm ...

Citizen II: You've told this story for many times, and still getting it wrong? You have to admit you're not young anymore.

Storyteller: Well, there is no such thing as a perfect story. Adaptations are always allowed, right? Please pretend you didn't hear me and forget about it ...

Citizen VII: Give me a break. He's telling that story again? I thought he'd be done with it after last time. I even bought a ticket!

Citizen V: "Last time"? When, last year? Did you sleep for a whole year?

Storyteller: I hear you, gentleman in blue.

Citizen VII: Now he's listening ...

Storyteller: You know, you're part of the story, just like me.

Citizen VII: Me? What do you mean?

Storyteller: Listen and you'll know. So the Lùshǔ jumped over the bridge, awakened the Yuān Temple, and revived the Pèilín River. As a result, more and more people come to the Pèi City at festivals, so I start telling stories again.

Storyteller: As for you ...

Storyteller: The Lùshǔ took over your tavern and turned you into her kind because you were an unscrupulous profiteer. You gave short weight to the people. That caused the decline of your business, yet you blamed it on the poor harvest.

Storyteller: But I think the Lùshǔ saved you from the plight! She ran the tavern for you, and you had a good sleep during that time. In a word, you did nothing good, but things ended up well for you!

Citizen VI: What? No way!

Citizen VI: I want that, too. If only somebody could finish my essay when I fall asleep!

Storyteller: Already writing a political essay at this age? You have a promising future, young man ...

Storyteller: But I think you should go home now and get some sleep. You need to rest well, so you can continue with your studies tomorrow.

Storyteller: After all, the essay matters much more than the story, right?

Amidst the festive hustle and bustle, a farewell brews in front of the city gates.

This is the place from which people come, and people go.

Bessmert: I have so many things to write about this time, enough for me to write a travel note.

Bessmert: What should I call it? Travel in the East? Journey to Pèi City?

Yenisei: Neither of them sounds good.

Yenisei: There are already too many Travels and Journeys. I think you are different from those authors, Madam, so ...

Gětiān escorts the group to a spot near the city gate, where the road splits into two. On one side lies the road up the mountain, and on the other lies the road down.

He slowly descends to the ground, standing still, stiff and slightly uncomfortable.

The human companions of the two arcanists retreat in caution and fear from the strange bird creature.

Getian: Indeed. Unlike others, the two of you have experienced it in its entirety.

Yenisei: What do you mean?

Getian: There was a beginning, and now here is an end. Forget not where you came from at the end —this is entirety.

Getian: Thus, happiness is found.

Bessmert: I'm sorry that I still don't understand your riddles.

Getian: That's no matter.

Krolik: Emm ... Sorry to interrupt you. Can we go? I really want to go home right away ...

Bessmert: Ah, then we shall ...

Getian: Please wait. There's one more thing.

Bessmert: Certainly, please.

Getian: The questions you asked—have you had the answers?

Yenisei: ...

Bessmert: I'm not sure.

Getian: What do you mean?

Bessmert: When Jiǔ Niángzǐ jumped over the bridge, Yenisei saw a pattern being formed where I wrote my question.

Bessmert: We didn't understand it. It didn't bother us either, perhaps because there was no answer to my question ...

Getian: A question is asked, and a divination is made. What you saw might be a Hexagram, not the interpretation of it.

Getian: Do you still remember what it looks like?

Yenisei thinks for a moment and uses a rock hammer handle to draw crooked and twisted lines in the sand, with occasional breaks in the middle of them.

Yenisei: It changed a little ... and ended up like this.

Getian: The Hexagram of Water and Fire.

Getian: I'd assume this belongs to an elderly person. What about yours?

Yenisei is stunned for a moment, then draws a few more lines. By the end of it, her offering is already rather messy, so much so that she stretches out a section of it.

Fortunately, Gětiān can still read it.

Getian: This is ... Xū, the Hexagram of waiting. Though I don't know what could be derived from it ...

Getian: The interpretation is simple. Above is Water, the stranding dragon, advising patience. Below is uprightness, which means you will smooth away the obstacles.

Yenisei: Which means ...?

Getian: You will find your water. All you need to do is wait.

Yenisei: Yes, thank you. I didn't know that.

Getian: As for your Hexagram ...

Getian: You have gone across the river. A decision has been made.

Bessmert: I see.

Yenisei: Turns out The Divination doesn't help at all.

Getian: It does, if you believe in it.

Bessmert: No. I know what you mean.

Bessmert: It is exactly how I expected it to be. Thank you, Mr. Gětiān.

Getian: No need.

Bessmert: And what about you? Have you learned your answer?

Getian: It told me to let things be.

Getian: Since I have left the mountain ... I should follow what's inside my mind.

Gětiān turns his head and points his wings toward the path up the mountain.

Getian: I remember that at the end of the Pèilín River, where the lanterns float, stands a great building.

Getian: It might be real or illusional. I have seen it many times, yet I have never thought of going there.

The two of them look in the direction pointed out by Gětiān, only seeing the jungle into which Jiǔ Niángzǐ disappeared, and nothing more.

Yenisei: There's nothing there.

Getian: I will go anyway.

Yenisei: ...

Yenisei: Then ...

Yenisei: What about Jiǔ Niángzǐ? She jumped over the bridge. Is she never coming back?

Gětiān doesn't answer, he only shakes his head. All Yenisei can do is glance over to Gětiān filled with unspoken inquiries.

Bessmert turns toward the distant cliffs and jungle, standing without speaking for a long while.

Until at last she breaks her silence.

Bessmert: Perhaps ...

Bessmert: Perhaps we will meet again one day.

6#1

We Will Meet Again

NS-23

The party journeys along the river for a long time, but the night never falls.

Most of them are in a hurry to leave—the same desire as before, but now much stronger than ever before, more than enough to bring the long-awaited harmony of a common purpose to the team.

And no one dares mention their experiences for the rest of the trip.

Krolik: Let's make camp after we get out of the forest. What do you say?

Bessmert: I'm fine with it. How are you feeling, Mr. Jurien?

Jurien: I'm fine with that.

Yenisei: ...

A few still harbor a lingering curiosity, one they endure for a long time, and until unable to resist, they turn around to see if the ancient city on the mountainside is still in sight.

But while this is not a story where those who look back might turn into pillars of salt, there remains no trace of the strange city that should have still been in view.

And as they walk onward, the revived river known as the Pèilín too has changed its appearance.

Yenisei: ...!

Yenisei: Madam, the river ...

The once-wide river invisibly splits into slender tributaries behind them, spread out across the lush spring meadows like a rope net.

Even if they wanted to find it, they might never distinguish the one that would lead them back.

Bessmert: What is it?

Team Member II: The compass is working!

Team Member II: Great!

Their fellow traveler excitedly raises his hands, briefly blocking Yenisei's gaze from Bessmert.

The girl takes advantage of the situation and withdraws the words she cannot say. She only gently shakes her head.

Yenisei: Nothing. Let's move.

Yenisei: The compass is working, which means we can rely on the map again.

Bessmert: Oh, that's good. As for the book I'm going to write ...

Yenisei: Yes? Have you decided the title?

Bessmert: Yes. I will call it ...

Bessmert: "Notes on Shuòrì."

Yenisei: Notes on Shuòrì ...

Yenisei: Yes, that's the title.

She flips over a page and continues reading.

Yenisei: "The title is actually not a good choice for a book on geographical discoveries."

Yenisei: "On one hand, there is no doubt that 'Shuòrì' is a difficult word for the target readers of this book."

Yenisei: "On the other hand, the word 'Notes,' in most cases, is used to describe the collections of informal essays. They usually record the daily talks of professional writers, and thus include a variety of ideas and inspirations."

Yenisei: "As a geographer, however, I don't possess enough knowledge of literature to write the real 'Notes,' nor does the assistant who takes dictations from me, unfortunately ..."

Yenisei: Haha ...

Yenisei: "Even so, we have decided to use these words for the title. Postscript: The title has also been included in the first draft we sent to the editors of Motherland Documentary and the Department of Publication Review."

Yenisei: The next page is missing. Let me see ...

Yenisei: Oh, found it.

Yenisei: "June 4, sunny. I never knew the journey back to Omsk would take so long. My assistant and I set off from Yekaterinburg last year, and we didn't arrive until now ..."

Yenisei: "In Omsk, we met the governor again. I left him some drafts of this book in return for the help from the local Scientific Research Association."

Yenisei: "Those drafts have recorded the steppe ecosystem around the Om River in detail. For example, before we arrived in Omsk, we followed a herd of sheep across the river. The wool on their tails was apparently matted."

Yenisei: "I recorded this detail because the way they crossed the water was almost a miracle. It is known to all that sheep can be easily drowned because their thick wool holds them back in water."

Yenisei: "Yet things seemed different for those sheep. They had been trained by the local herders and were able to cross the river swiftly, as if they were only several balls of cotton floating on the water ..."

Ms. Radio: "... When they came to the shore, I noticed that their hooves were in the shape of a round cake with one slice missing."

Vertin: Hmm ...

Ms. Radio: "They climbed out of the water with their little cake hooves, shook themselves dry, and continued on to the next pasture, never hesitant to go forward, never looking back."

Ms. Radio: "Seeing all these, I hope I will be as determined as these sheep in my future journey ..."

Ms. Radio: "Today's article was an extract from a geographic manuscript from St. Pavlov Foundation Far East Branch, recorded by Yenisei."

Ms. Radio: "Next is the news broadcast ..."

Vertin: ...

Vertin: Mmm ...

Vertin: Ms. Radio?

Ms. Radio: Yes, I'm here.

Vertin: I ... What time is it now?

Ms. Radio: It's 4:15 p.m.

Vertin: The nap went on a little longer than I thought.

Ms. Radio: Yes. How are you feeling?

Vertin: Think I had a dream. Many animals were jumping over a broken bridge.

Ms. Radio: I read you a story which has zebras and sheep in it.

Vertin: Zebras and sheep?

Vertin: I don't remember that ...

Vertin: Hmm?

???: Excuse me. Is Timekeeper in the room?

Vertin: I am.

???: May I come in? There is something I need to confirm with you ...

Vertin: I'm sorry, who's that?

Sonetto: Hmm? It's me, Sonetto.

Vertin: I might have taken too long a nap. Never mind, please come in.

Sonetto: Timekeeper, you don't look very well. Are you alright?

Vertin: It's ok. I had a weird dream.

Vertin: What's going on?

Sonetto: Oh, it's a letter from the Foundation. A colleague from the Russian branch was transferred to the headquarters today. She has shown a strong willingness to perform long-term field missions ...

Sonetto: Thus, the headquarters intends to transfer her to the Timekeeper Squad. Would you have a meeting with her? It is said that she is experienced in geographical exploration and survival in the wilderness. She could be a great helper.

Vertin: Geographical exploration? What's her name?

Sonetto: Please hold on. Let me check her file here.

Sonetto: And her name is ...

Sonetto: Yenisei.

6#2